# Our Love Is God

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# Our Love Is God

by n7punk

Summary

Adora and Catra stopped speaking not long after they graduated from their acting college and Adora took off on Broadway while Catra struggled to get her foot in the door. Catra used to fantasize about getting to stand opposite Adora on the stage, but two years later playing her love interest sounds more like a nightmare than a dream, even if this musical could finally put her on the map. Adora just wants Catra to stop acting like she's actually the villain off-stage, but she's not sure a musical about death is somewhere real love can bloom again. (Heathers on Broadway Catradora AU)

Notes

For this Broadway AU, the crew is going to be performing a real (off-Broadway and West End) musical, and while I personally think the musical is less triggering than the movie, there are still most of the same sensitive topics in it and thus those plot points might be mentioned in this fic. I am going to try to avoid some of them, but it's definitely going to be impossible for certain things, so triggers for the musical are listed under the cut and just be aware references to these things could come up but aren't planned as part of the story itself.

▶ Warnings in order of likely reference:

Rating note: Uhhhh T? M? We'll find out!

# Auditions (Prologue)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora has been to a lot of auditions, but the nerves never really go away. A lot of her friends from her previous shows have managed to get calls for this one. Some of them have worked with members of the creative team before, so the family reunion isn't that surprising, but it's nice to have so many familiar faces waiting for her when she walks into the waiting room. It's a double-edged sword, though; she wants this role even more than usual if it means she might get the chance to be in a show with them again.

For better or worse, nerves become the last thing on her mind when the doors open and another familiar – but far from friendly – face strolls into the waiting room. Adora feels herself bolt straight up in her chair as Catra strolls into the room, eyes cutting around the room as she assesses her competition just like their old acting coach instructed them to at auditions. When she locks eyes with Adora, she comes to a halt. Adora's lips part in shock, but Catra's scowl. Her ears pin back as she turns away to check-in.

She posts up on the far end of the room, doing her best to ignore Adora on the far end of the room, slowly curling around her binder in her lap.

Who is she reading for? This audition was invite-only, what got her the call-up? She hasn't been on Broadway yet in a named role, just that one ensemble part that Adora could tell, even from her tour bus on the other side of the country, that Catra only took because she was desperate for something between dud off-Broadway auditions. She doesn't want to be nameless, she wants to be the lead. Netossa is inclusive in her casting, so it's not surprising she would invite Catra even though there hasn't been a magicat role in Heathers' previous runs, but it does leave her part an open question.

She's not here for ensemble. That's going to be open casting after the other roles have all been filled to balance out the cast. Adora jitters her knee, bouncing the binder in her lap. Catra's voice is deeper than most of the roles. Off the top of her head, Adora knows one of the Heathers has a lower voice and that's all she can think of for her. Catra could probably work Heather well.

Adora *should* be mentally prepping for her audition, but all she can focus on is the music binder hanging loose by Catra's side. It would help her figure it out, but she's not going to develop laser vision to see what Catra brought with her to show her range off. She always had trouble picking pieces that were far enough in her range to be comfortable and close enough to most roles' octaves for her to have a chance of landing them. Her depth is amazing for ensemble, but Catra could never be happy there.

The audition room door opens and a guy Adora doesn't know walks out, replaced by a girl she doesn't recognize either. It's getting closer to her time. She glances around the room, making sure none of her friends still waiting are looking directly at her as she quickly stands up, clutching her music binder, and tries to stroll casually over in Catra's direction.

She's pretty sure Catra only waits to say something until she's close because she doesn't want to be overheard and labeled as difficult to work with.

"Wow. Are you sure you're an actress?" Catra mutters under her breath as Adora tries to casually post up beside where she's lounging against the wall. Adora resists the urge to scowl. On stage? Sure, the energy of the music carries her. Off-stage she has never been able to manage it without stakes. Usually there are enough at auditions for her to manage it, but there's almost *too* much when it comes to Catra.

They haven't spoken in almost two years. They were already on thin ice from how Adora was focused on her career – sorry, "ego trip" – when she landed a pretty significant role on Broadway while Catra was still struggling in small theaters blocks away. Then the production won a Tony, and a touring version was put together, and Adora went to "fame whore around the country" in Catra's words. Adora's new friends didn't think she was arrogant, but she had changed in Catra's opinion.

"Who are you reading for?" Adora asks, leaving all their history at their feet. It's probably manipulative of her, maybe even proves Catra's point. They both know they can't cause a scene here or neither of them will get the part. Catra narrows her eyes at her.

"Duke," she says, reluctantly. Adora nods. One of the lower female parts. A powerful figure, even if it takes a bit for her to become a tyrant. Catra could embody the energy well. Heather Duke leads her own song, too. It's the kind of role Catra has realistically been looking for. Not headliner, but even Adora hasn't been headline in the three years since her Broadway debut.

"Don't tell me you're here for McNamara," Catra says. Adora snorts.

"No, worse. Veronica," she informs her. That would mean even more face time if they somehow both managed to snag the roles, not to mention Catra having to walk past her face on all the promotional posters. It would probably be the end of them, actually, if they weren't already finished.

Adora still can't make herself think of them like that.

"Not going to work out. You act like a Martha and look like a Heather," Catra comments, sounding like she's just barely biting her tongue from a worse insult. Adora feels a drop in her stomach. It's not even that Catra is insulting her – it's that she's right. Adora doesn't really fit in this musical and she's pretty sure she only got called because she has some connections in the show. It's the exact kind of privilege Catra accused her of falling into.

"Adora?" a voice calls from the door. Adora looks up to see Spinnerella smiling at her as she holds the door to the audition room open. Adora straightens, pushing off the wall, and takes a second to take a deep breath.

It looks like she's lingering. Might as well lean into it.

"We'll see about that," she promises Catra in the same low voice they have been using for this entire conversation. Catra's eyes flash and Adora is certain they stay locked on her as she

walks away.

Adora has never not risen to a challenge. Maybe there isn't a role for her here – she still wants to work for one and show exactly why she got where she is.

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By the time Catra's audition is called, she has oscillated through enough emotions to decide that she does want the part if Adora is cast – *especially* if Adora is cast – because at least she could taunt Adora for half the show. She hadn't seen the musical before she got the audition invitation, but she has listened to both cast albums to prepare and she thinks *Candy Store* would be fun against Adora. She'd at least get to gloat in a bullying anthem as the Heathers tempt Veronica to the dark side.

So of course that's what they have her do. Against Adora.

The audition starts normal, but Catra gets four lines into the song that she brought before the director, Netossa, instructs her to stop and take it in a weightier tone. That's usually exactly what Catra tries to avoid and she's worried Netossa intervened because she heard a strain in her voice that she didn't detect herself, but despite how nervous it makes her, it also makes the second take easier. It's a growl that can rise up in her chest and ends up very different from what she planned, but Netossa grins and then points for her to go wait in the corner of the room.

Adora never came out of the audition room after going in. They've held back a good twenty people in the back of the large room and Catra sits on the far end of the group. Normally she would be worried about being perceived as anti-social – she is, but it's not good for getting roles – but Scorpia apparently got here way ahead of her and got held back, so she can easily smile at her, let Scorpia half-hug her, and sit beside her while seeming perfectly cordial with her castmates. Adora is near the middle of the group with the rest of her bitch pack and Catra avoids looking at her until Netossa calls a wrap on auditions for the day and claps her hands, walking over.

"Great job, everyone! This is the second day of auditions, so keep in mind we've seen a lot more people than are here today, but you all impressed me and I want to see a little more from you. I'm going to pair you up and have you run a few short snippets from the show. We're going to change roles up for these because I want to see your range," Netossa explains, graciously holding her hands out for the stack of papers Spinnerella hands off to her, flashing a smile to the woman before she twirls away. Netossa flips through scripts, reading off scenes and names, until the moment Catra dreads.

"*Candy Store* bleeding into the *Beautiful* reprise verse. Catra and Adora," Netossa says, despite her earlier promises of changing their roles. Catra's feet stick for a minute before she manages to nod and moves forward to accept the script. Netossa doesn't look up as Catra

takes the paper from her hand. The parts Netossa wants her to read are highlighted in a shade Catra has to squint to make out at all on the page.

“Catra, you’ll be Heather Chandler. Don’t worry about raising the register, I like the growls. Adora, take Veronica and run with the clapback angle of moving *Beautiful* here. I want to hear *your* take on her, don’t worry about sticking to the notes, this is already off book,” Netossa lists off, causing Catra to pause as she looks down at the sheet.

Okay, so Adora is clearly a favorite already. What’s new. One thing, actually – Netossa likes something unique Catra is bringing too. They can’t just rewrite a part like that to be in her register without making other changes and all of her life experience has indicated no one is going to go to that kind of effort to include her – see the near-invisible highlighter that could easily just be underlined in pencil – but Heather Duke might actually be within reach and this is just an exercise.

Standing across from Adora on the stage feels a little like exercising demons. She’s glad Netossa told her she could own it because she doesn’t have the notes of this number memorized but she can look between the page and Adora, feel that pull and frustration, and pour it out into her voice. She doesn’t know the choreography, but this isn’t a full run. It’s easy to casually circle her as she sings, looking back over her shoulder to smile coyly as she offers high school heaven and popularity at the price of everybody else’s happiness.

They lock eyes as Catra growls out the last swell of the chorus, because Adora is *working* with her. The problem is, for her many weaknesses, Adora also has her strengths. It’s so easy for Catra to catch on the faults Adora has that she doesn’t and wonder why she gets all the accolades, but Adora has a presence on stage it’s hard to quantify. She’s not the loser mouse caught in the popular girl’s trap, she’s a force of her own ready to take a stand despite how she isn’t even doing anything but standing there with the right energy. The last line of the chorus leaves Catra’s lips and Adora only gives it a second to linger in Catra’s gloating air before she offers her response as the piano chords shift in the background.

Adora raising her hand, holding it out to her, and pouring out *you know you’re beautiful, you say you’re numb inside, but I can’t agree* brings chills to Catra even with Adora glancing away midline to look at her script.

It’s a totally different story from the love ballad that it’s supposed to be. It’s asking a villain to lower her defenses and be real. It’s hitting way too close to home, but Catra’s tail lashes behind her and she finds herself advancing on Adora as she reads the last few lines. She means to be threatening, to be above it, like a Heather would be.

She fists her hand at her side and tells herself that it’s an acting choice to look like she’s holding herself back from taking Adora’s hand when it gets within reach. She isn’t. It’s more like containing herself from punching her. She’s just angry that they’ve ended up in this position at all, final piano notes hanging in the air with their gazes still locked.

With her breath rattling in her chest, it feels like they’ve been on stage for an entire song, not just two verses. Catra quickly looks away as the other actors politely clap in the background, huffing out a breath and trying to expel Adora from her lungs.

“Great job, thanks for indulging me,” Netossa thanks them with a smirk even though Adora wobbled on that last note. Whatever. Catra did her part and Spinnerella tells her she can go when Catra quickly walks off stage to give her the paper back.

She leaves before she can see if Adora was asked to stay or not. Her ears are still ringing with that note Adora drew out, the word *beautiful* aimed at her but aimed at no one, really, because it’s just a song, just a role. Just acting.

She hates that it doesn’t feel that way to her no matter how many times she reminds herself it is. These delusions already ruined her happiness once. She isn’t going to fall for them again.

She hopes she gets the part and she never hears Adora’s name again.

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Adora is at her dance class when she gets a call from her agent. Angella has her own unique ringtone so Adora can panic appropriately when she calls and she quickly excuses herself from the waltz she was too clumsy for anyway. Having some idea how to dance is usually helpful in musical theater, but it’s definitely not her strong suit and she mostly does this just to keep from getting worse. She doesn’t mind ditching it to sit in the hallway with her back against the wall as she breathlessly answers Angella’s call.

“Angella, hi! Any news?” Adora asks a little too urgently. Callbacks were last weekend, solo this time. Adora did her best to belt *Seventeen* by herself but it was mostly acting and Netossa throwing questions at her. Adora has only had one other audition this month. She wants this one. She wants to prove she can be a Veronica.

“More than you’re expecting. Good news,” Angella says, causing Adora’s shoulders to slump with relief even as her heart rises in her throat.

“Did I get it?” she asks, completely breathless.

“Yes, you did. They want you in workshops next week. The show has some changes they need time to work out,” Angella explains. Adora is immediately ready to cancel her plans, but she’s surprised to hear it for such an established production.

“What changes?” she asks, some part of her mind already racing to figure out what it is they think she can’t do that they have to accommodate. She can work on it.

“Well, they’re rewriting some stuff. To start with, Netossa wasn’t a fan of the fatshaming in the original script, so she wants to dial it back to only highlight how awful the bullying is. She says you’re a perfect fit for the changes to Veronica she has in mind,” Angella lists off. Adora is a little shaky, like she always gets when she’s this close to securing something and she sees her next year of possibility stretching in front of her.

“What changes?” she manages to ask. Catra’s words weighed on her thoughts when she went in for the callback. Maybe in real life she was as delusional about her childhood crush as Martha is in the show, but she thinks she can easily act with the strength of a Veronica. Appearance-wise, though, she doesn’t really fit with the secretly-pretty-but-ratty archetype.

“Conventionally attractive,” Angella says. Adora blinks at nothing.

“What?”

Angella seems to be enjoying this conversation, weirdly. The wry twist in her voice doesn’t make sense. Adora is best friends with Angella’s daughter, so she’s on friendly terms with her agent, but usually Angella is very professional around business.

“She wanted a girl who by all accounts could be the Heather or Regina of a more traditional story if she didn’t have one thing wrong with her that made all of the rest of it not matter,” Angella explains. Adora furrows her brow.

“What’s wrong with her?” In the musical, Veronica is just supposed to be a nobody. Nondescript except for her ability to forge handwriting, worried about bullying but not really a constant target.

“She’s gay,” Angella finally elaborates.

It’s an odd feeling, her heartbeat pulsing down to her fingertips. It’s different from the usual shakiness as she tries to process Angella’s words. Netossa tends to bring an agenda – the gay one, usually – to her productions, but this would be a *big* departure for the show.

“Wait- Then is JD…?” She trails off, a small whine entering her hearing like some kind of warning signal going off far enough away that she can’t hear what it’s blaring for. Instinct is telling her to brace for impact.

“Janis Dean in this one, the ‘school dyke outcast.’ Catra got her call this morning and already accepted, apparently,” Angella says.

Ah. The whining really should have been closer to an air raid siren. Or an ambulance – Adora might need one to recover from this. She’s about to spend the next year violently in love with Catra on stage.

Chapter End Notes

I’m going to try to make it so you don’t need to know the musical for this fic, but there will be some offhand mentions/references that will be missed if you aren’t familiar. I don’t think you need to watch the musical to understand the “you won’t get Veronica as a role because you look like a Heather and act like a Martha” thing, it’s just clear those are three different roles and Adora doesn’t line up perfectly with any of them.
I watched the original Heathers movie back in the day and uh. did not enjoy it. Do NOT

recommend it. However, there was a really interesting idea there, so when I found out about the musical, I checked it out and really liked it! This was the off-Broadway version because the other didn't exist yet. I followed the West End (British Broadway) version via Carrie Hope Fletcher's (Veronica's actress) vlogs. When I decided I wanted to do a Broadway AU I considered "inventing" a musical, but like, the appeal of a Broadway AU is partially the musical, right? So I wanted to use a real one people might like to see, this is the only musical I've ever really gotten into, and the insane chemistry Catra and Adora have is good for Veronica and JD.

There are three versions of this musical (original off-Broadway, "PG edit" for high schools, and West End). For this fic, there's now a fourth, one mostly similar to the West End version (I haven't actually gotten to watch the West End version for obvious reasons, but I have listened to both cast albums and watched a slime tutorial :) of the off-Broadway version. I'm choosing the West End version for the new songs) but Netossa has once again made revisions for her version, the most obvious being. Yknow. It's gay now and there are some changes to dialogue/songs to acknowledge that and that JD is an outcast for even more reasons than in the original and Veronica's falling for her is even more risky.

# Workshop

Chapter Notes

▶ A bunch of musical explanations if you aren't really familiar:

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Workshop is a rough period. With a musical that needs this many changes while also working within the confines of the original version as much as possible, there are always going to be growing pains, but as rough as Adora feels after she gives a bad take knowing she brought her castmates down, there are bigger challenges this time around. It takes five days of disappointment before she realizes that despite being "in love" in the music room, Catra doesn't want much to do with her. Like Adora, she has a few friends in the crew and she uses the two other girls like shields to avoid conversation with Adora.

Adora is pretty sure that's Catra trying to be professional, avoiding a blow up by not speaking at all even if Adora catches the occasional snarky comment, usually coming from Catra and aimed at one of her friends like she knows better than to aim directly at her – or like she knows going after her friends would just make Adora madder. Adora's friends are just as willing to defend her as Catra's are and suddenly there are cliques happening behind the scenes that have nothing to do with the show. She hears Netossa mutter something to her wife about how weird it is to see JD and Martha blow off half the Heathers and Ram when they're at a fitting.

The part that makes it so hard is that Catra is such a good actress. On their practice stage, she slips into JD's obsessive persona easily, flirty and nihilistic and treating Adora a bit like prey in a way that she can't resist even if she had the strength because it's written in the script. Veronica falls for JD fast, based mostly on lust and later on a shared loathing for society, but it makes more sense in Netossa's version, JD ostensibly the only lesbian out at school and Veronica becoming obsessed with the first butch that flexes her muscles for her and won't out her to the rest of the class.

Every time Catra slips up behind her in the prop aisles of the 7/11, sliding an arm past her waist to offer the empty slushie prop to her, crooning the final line of *Freeze Your Brain* in her ear, Adora absolutely *gets* it. She doesn't usually wear makeup off-stage, but there's something that makes her heart pound about Catra pulling back the drink after Adora sipped it out of her hand and wrapping her own lips around Adora's lipstick marks on the straw.

And then Glimmer yells from the "car" off-stage, and the scene finishes, and Catra walks off the stage to return to only vaguely acknowledging her existence. For the most part, their dynamic is good for the show no matter how strenuous it is, but sometimes Adora just feels so frustrated that she can't give the scene its emotion and it grinds to a halt, and sometimes Catra will give her nothing, too. She hates feeling like she's getting in the way of the production. She hates even more how Catra acts like she's just getting in *her* way whenever

she messes up but then ignores it when she's the one at fault unless the criticism is coming from Netossa herself.

She hates that she can't fix it, but Catra doesn't want her to. The entire cast can tell they have history, even the ones who don't know the story. The two times someone asks, Adora just says they went to the same acting school. It's true. It's by no means the full story.

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Catra fell in love with Adora when she was eight years old, playing a nameless background elf while Adora saved the spirit of Christmas or whatever on center stage in an elementary school auditorium. Adora loved performing, soaking up the music and applause. She had to beg her parents to scrape the money together to send her to their acting college for high school.

Catra didn't really get a choice. She was in her first commercial at two years old. Her mom wouldn't settle for her daughter living a mundane life. Catra's one big rebellion was making a break for the music route as soon as she realized Adora would actually want her to follow her. Her mom didn't want Broadway for her, but eventually she was done fighting about it. It was close enough. Not that Catra was *successful* enough, but she was able to find an adrenaline rush in the music and standing next to Adora on the stage was good for her until the stages they stood on were different, more than just differing roles separating them. The Broadway lights blocked out even the shine of Adora's smile that Catra used to live for.

Sometimes it's a rush to be back on stage with her with the knowledge that their posters are going to be hanging beside each other outside the theater. Sometimes she sees a slip from Adora and their old acting coach's voice echoes in her head, issuing a harsh correction, but no one says anything, because those corrections were usually thrown at Catra. Maybe Adora's presence really is that magnetic and people just don't notice when there's a smile where there shouldn't be or a cracked line.

Maybe Catra is just bitter that the girl she fell in love with didn't feel the same, got everything they both worked for while Catra was left in the dust, and now tries to act like nothing happened and talk to her like they used to between runs back in school. The lockers of Westerberg High's set don't mean they're back in college anymore, but it doesn't make life any fairer than it was under the favoritism-based rankings that got the good girls all the auditions and the Catras burnout.

Netossa finds Catra when she's in a hall on the way back from getting changed for a full costume run. Catra hears someone up ahead and braces herself, but nothing can really prepare her for the director that she thinks might like her but also might hate her guts standing there, seemingly just to intercept her. She points a finger at Catra and she freezes, not feeling especially powerful in the stupid trench coat JD wears because he thinks it's cool for some reason.

“If anyone else was messing with my show like this I would throw you out the door,” Netossa threatens, dropping Catra’s heart into her stomach. She instantly bristles, because she has never been able to kick the defensive anger that lights when she’s scared. Netossa doesn’t seem threatened at all by her lip curling to reveal her fangs. “Unfortunately, your lack of professionalism reads hot on stage, so get on speaking terms before previews begin and we can make this work. Are you exes?” Netossa asks. Catra’s jaw drops.

“No!” she shouts, a little too loudly, before remembering the dressing rooms she came from and quickly glancing back over her shoulder, but no one else is on their way down. When she looks back to Netossa, she doesn’t look like she believes her at all.

“Yeah, sure, okay. Whatever you were, have a conversation about it so you can survive until the part of the show where you’re actually supposed to hate each other,” Netossa says. Catra growls, warning bells ringing in the back of her head saying she’s going to get herself fired before they can even do the promotional photoshoot, but Netossa has graduated from poking at her most vulnerable spot to beating it with a stick.

“They never hate each other,” she grumbles, shoving her hands in the pockets of the big trench coat and finally seeing its merits. Netossa has to know the point of her own show. Veronica never even falls out of love with JD, really, she just realizes he’s an unhinged murderer and she can’t fix that.

The look Netossa gives her now is by far the worst part of the conversation.

“We’re *fine*. I’ll talk to her if it will make you happy,” Catra grits out. Mostly if it will let her keep her job. Netossa’s lips quirk.

“I’d tell you to resolve it all, but I think it’s better for the show that you don’t, really,” Netossa says, which Catra chooses to interpret as an attempt at reverse psychology because otherwise she won’t be able to control the twitch in her eye. Netossa seems satisfied, though, finally taking a step back and giving her a nod. “I need clean runs before previews start,” she reminds her, turning away and waving over her shoulder.

Oh, Catra isn’t going to forget. She isn’t going to think about a single thing except dreading this conversation until they’re forced to have it.

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Graduating from the practice space to the actual theater that will host them for the next year is always exciting. Adora has her own dressing room for the first time. She’s pretty sure she, Catra, and Glimmer are the only ones who got their own space. Glimmer has to have a sink to wash off the hastily-powdered grey makeup she puts on to pretty her corpse up as Veronica writes Heather Chandler’s fake suicide note so she can haunt her for the rest of the show. Adora and Catra… Well, Adora is headline, and she heard Scorpia assuring Netossa that

Catra could share a room with her without it being an issue, but apparently Netossa didn't want to take a chance. She probably shouldn't.

Adora is poking around her room, trying to plan where she's going to put her vocal steamer and snacks, when she's surprised by a knock on the door that doesn't even wait for an answer, the door swinging open as soon as Adora doesn't scream that she's changing or something. She turns and freezes in her tracks when she sees Catra slinking through the doorway, already scowling as she kicks it closed behind her.

"Catra?" Adora asks, stunned. The few times they have managed to end up – very temporarily – alone, Catra has done her best to bolt before Adora can get any kind of meaningful conversation going. One time they just sat in silence when they did end up alone because Adora didn't want to get brushed off and start the next scene annoyed considering it was the ballad *Seventeen*.

"Shut up. We're going to have a conversation, and then we're going to make rules, and you're going to follow them," Catra lays out as she looks around the room before deciding the vanity is the best place to be. She sits on it with no regards for Adora's things she scattered across it while she looked for permanent places to put them.

"Excuse me?" Adora asks, almost surprised by Catra's audacity. Almost. Catra glares at her.

"Apparently our 'tension,'" she makes air quotes, "is only good for the show when it's you grinding on my abs or me climbing through your window with a gun," Catra gripes. Adora is shocked to hear Catra acknowledge it, but clearly she's doing this against her will.

"Uh, yeah, that's not *my* fault," Adora points out, once again annoyed. She has been trying. She has been trying to be polite with Catra and gotten a wall every time. Catra growls, opening her mouth to say something and then cutting off with a sharp *tch* as she looks away. Adora stares at her, processing this is actually happening as Catra cools off.

"I don't want to talk to you," Catra states, like that's news.

"Yeah, that's the problem, isn't it?" Adora points out. Netossa must have talked to her, and Adora knows everyone has at least seen her extending an olive branch once or twice only to get frozen out. She's feeling snarky. She's finally alone with Catra in the same room but instead of running her hands through her hair, they're barely looking at each other.

"Look, you were an asshole," Catra says. Adora opens her mouth to argue that Catra has been the same for the last year, but Catra cuts her off. "You blew me off constantly, wouldn't refer me so *you* didn't seem 'demanding,' never came to my opening night and then said it wasn't a big deal, and- Actually, no, that's enough to never speak again," Catra lists off, her voice still seething when she quotes that last part. Adora feels her heart drop into her stomach, weighted and poisoned like a lead stone.

"I'm sorry about that. I never should have said it. You were always so mad at me and I just returned it without stopping to think about what I was saying," Adora mumbles. She's still mad for how Catra has acted. Catra is still mad at how she acted, clearly, but this part she is completely justified for and Adora kind of feels like crying whenever she remembers it. The

memory of saying she could just come some other time like that would fix it and Catra snarling before she stormed out the door, clearly crying, floats up to the surface of her mind when she can't sleep at night.

Catra doesn't look appeased. Adora doesn't expect her to be. People have said worse things to Catra, but Adora hasn't.

"I said it because I felt bad for not coming and was trying to make myself feel better, not because I meant it or wanted to make you feel that way. I didn't like being so busy I never saw you, but then when I did see you, you were always mad-" Adora starts to explain.

"Gee, wonder why," Catra cuts in bitterly, uncaring about what she has to say.

"-and everything was so stressful it kind of felt like my entire life's work had been a mistake. You were right I used to leave earlier for the show than I had to. I'd go up to my dressing room before anyone else got there to have a panic attack where no one would see," Adora finishes, pressing on to get to the important part. She bites her lip as Catra stills, not moving at all for few breaths before her tail slowly curls. Her eyes lift to make eye contact with Adora as her tail starts to curl the other way.

"If you had those at home, I would have held you for them," Catra says, her voice lower but eyes still narrowed. Adora's stomach still feels like it's spinning. She has thought that before. It's kind of the worst part.

"And let you see that I wasn't grateful for every second of it when you were still working for it? I couldn't. I had to be able to do it. And I did, I just lost you while I got my feet under me," Adora says. Catra scowls.

"There are some things more important than fame," Catra mutters, looking away. Oh, Adora knows. She knows Catra never wanted it the same way she did, but still *needed* it because it was what her mom expected of her and she wasn't about to prove her right when she said musical theater would never get her anywhere.

"You know it was never about that," Adora murmurs. This was her dream since she was a little girl. Her mom loved listening to showtunes. Adora dreamed of being one of the voices on the soundtrack. Cast albums don't get actors famous the same way movies do. She just wanted to get the chance to originate a role or at least end up on a cast album. Catra just wanted to prove she could lead a show. They were unlikely goals, but they weren't about ego. They were dreams. They seemed so in sync that they somehow tore them apart.

"Do I? It certainly seemed like it the second you got your shot," Catra mutters, but it's not snarled and that's the most progress they've made all day. Adora opens her mouth to protest, but Catra hops off the vanity with a sharp sigh and walks past Adora like she's about to leave. She stops when she's close enough to make eye contact and have it catch the breath in Adora's chest, yellow and blue so familiar under lowlight.

"Here are the rules: we don't initiate conversation with or about each other outside of what's needed to get a scene working or set up character. No digs, not even from our friends," Catra says, as if she needs to hold Adora back from that.

“You can leave Glimmer alone?” Adora asks, pointing out just one of many obvious problems. Catra smirks, her tail curling.

“That’s different, that’s flirting,” Catra corrects. Adora’s jaw drops.

“It’s *what*?” Catra and Glimmer? No way. She thought Catra hated Glimmer, and Glimmer isn’t exactly warm to her either given the way she has treated Adora. Catra ignores her shock, holding out her hand as if to shake.

“Acquaintances. That’s the best I can offer. A relationship like I have with the lighting guy. This is my big shot and I’m not letting bullshit dating back to high school ruin it. We don’t bother each other, and we act fucking insane on stage like I know we both can,” Catra proposes. Something rings hollow in Adora’s heart at the idea. She doesn’t want to be a faceless usher to Catra.

“Isn’t that what we’re doing right now?” Adora asks. Catra snorts.

“It’s absolutely not.” Adora looks at her hand. Okay, it isn’t. They’re barely talking enough for scenes to function and that definitely needs to change. She sighs and takes Catra’s hand.

“Fine.” It’s better than barely holding back from fighting because they’re at work. She isn’t delusional enough to think a handshake makes Catra stop being mad at her, but if she isn’t outwardly putting that blame on her, then fine, she can feel what she wants, and Adora will feel her share in private: frustration and sadness and so much longing she feels like she’s going to explode every time she asks Catra on stage if they can just be seventeen together.

No, they can’t. They missed that chance. Now they’re just theater rivals.

Adora refuses to believe that’s what they were meant to be.

Chapter End Notes

They went to an “acting college” for high school because it was one of those combined programs where they started at 14 and graduated with an arts degree at 20.

▶ Everybody’s roles (will pop up as we go, but there’s some explanation of the roles here if you aren’t familiar with the musical. I tried to edit the triggers some versus what you’d find online):

# Previews

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The first promotional shoot is mostly individual cast member shots in front of a green screen. Catra is barely in it. She takes one set of photos with Adora, but then it's just solo pictures for the posters and the rest of the day is for Veronica and the Heathers. Catra tries to be professional and follow through on Netossa's terms. She mostly ignores Adora's pack while trying not to be overt in doing so, she even forces a casual smile at Adora before they shoot, and she maybe gets too intense when she's holding Adora in front of the camera, but JD would be possessive like that, so it's acting. It's what Netossa said their dynamic was good for. Adora's eyes linger on her, questioning, when they pull apart, but then Glimmer calls Adora's name and Adora turns away to follow her.

Catra gets through her shots and then watches from the sidelines as Adora laughs with her castmates like they're best friends, the way they used to together before Adora decided she was too good for her. If she notices Catra lingering behind all the lights and equipment with the rest of the crew, she doesn't look her way. Maybe she's focused. Maybe she's professional. Maybe she just doesn't care.

Catra hates to think that any interaction they had was *unremarkable*, but it seems that way from how Adora has already moved on. Her skin itches, feeling the pull to break all the rules and call something jeering since Adora stopped answering when Catra called out to her softly long ago.

Instead she swallows it down, turns away, and pictures the final posters hanging outside the theater, her solo profile on one side and the other showing Adora plastered against her chest and looking into her eyes like she wants to drown in them. It isn't real, but she's always going to wish it was.

She'll have the photos.

They aren't enough.

They do a full run-through of the show the next day. Catra is intense like she has been from the start, and Adora is doing her damn job for sure, but it doesn't feel the same. It turns out telling Adora to treat her like a co-worker feels like shit. She isn't acting that different, and exchanging a few words between scenes occasionally is even nice, but every time Adora sings a love song at her, Catra feels a little insane. It drives her to give a different take for the next run than she has previously.

The original version of the musical was a tight production a decade ago. It was in an off-Broadway theater like the ones Catra has been relegated to until recently, where she would experience harsh come-downs after every show when she squeezed back into the dressing room she shared with half her cast because the theater was mostly seats and even then there

weren't that many. It proved itself a cult classic and the Broadway version has a bigger budget to go with its theater, but they always have to be versatile in theater.

For the high school party scene, house facades are rolled in front of the Westerberg High lockers on either side of the stage to represent the transition to the neighborhood. Catra gets some off time during *Big Fun* while Veronica is making herself an enemy of the Heathers. With the houses obscuring the movement, a thin futon is thrown on top of one of the lockers and the secret catwalk behind them. Catra re-enters the stage for *Dead Girl Walking* by climbing on top in the darkness and laying down with JD's pretentious book in her hand. The audience can't tell that her "bed" is basically just a sheet and a sheer drop with the window frame from the house façade in the way.

Eventually Veronica gets the idea to forget about her upcoming outing and social ostracization with sex and Catra's bedroom window lights up conveniently. It's a tight fit every time Adora climbs the trellis attached to the window set and straddles her hips, singing at Catra to fuck her until she forgets her own name. Her thighs squeeze Catra's hips and her thoughts are always far from professional. The song is supposed to be comedic. Catra startles cartoonishly and scrambles to find a bookmark when Adora reveals her plans. JD is left playing catchup as Adora jokes about her staying hydrated and all but walks Catra through how to fuck her.

All Catra can focus on tonight is that last part. She makes one change – just one – but it completely changes the light in Adora's eyes as she sings to her. When Adora straddles her, instead of the confusion as she slowly gets with the program, Catra sets aside her book immediately and puts both hands on Adora's thighs straddling her. She doesn't throw the whole direction out, but call it an unconscious impulse, she has her hands on Adora and gets to guide her movements when Adora rocks her hips in time with the music.

It's supposed to just be choreography driving the point home, foreplay between Veronica and JD at best. With them, it's something straight out of Catra's fantasies. As Adora's gaze burns on hers, her lashes fluttering, Catra wonders if she could get off like this. She really wants to know. She only does these rolls at scattered intervals up until the finale where Catra rips her shirt open and they both bounce their hips before Adora kisses her.

They kiss six times in this show and Catra has every one timestamped in her mind. Two are during this song, frantic and messy, and they don't even always land on each other's mouths, but of course tonight they do and Catra fights to hold herself back from deepening it and turning it into a real kiss as the lights go dark. Even caging her desire, their faces stay close together for a moment too long, Adora's heavy pants hitting her face before she seems to remember she needs to "fall asleep" before the lights turn back on and she pulls back.

Catra only ever gets to see the lace-edged bra Adora wears specifically for this scene for a few seconds before they kiss and the song ends. Today, when the "night" falls on the stage, Adora straightens up and they're left staring at each other, Catra still able to see perfectly fine as Adora breathes heavily, her eyes dropped down low like she's looking at Catra too. Normally she's already hastily redoing the snaps under her shirt buttons for the next scene.

This – this extended moment where it's just the two of them, and Catra made her feel *something* that was more than scripted – was exactly what she was looking for. It's almost

like a power trip to see the rise and fall of Adora's bare chest. Catra squeezes Adora's hips where her hands fell and feels a thrill shiver through her. Unfortunately, that's Adora's wakeup call. She sucks in a hard breath and her hands fly to her buttons, a little panicked. The next scene is going to start any second now and she isn't at all ready.

Catra can easily see in the dim light. Adora does this by feel alone. Catra reaches up and starts rebuttoning Adora's shirt from the bottom, making quick work of it as Adora's hands freeze in place at her collar. They're still hanging there, useless, when Catra works her way to the final one and snaps it in place. Catra's hands drop back down to Adora's thighs as she smirks back up at her, soaking in Adora's stunned gaze fixed down on her. She only gets it for a second before Adora looks up and hurriedly moves to lay down beside her for the next scene, but as the lights come on, red glow focused on the nightmare cult scene taking place outside the window, Catra gets to just lay there "asleep" feeling satisfied with an interaction with Adora for the first time in a long time.

She thinks Adora Grayskull just might still be gay for her.

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It's their first show and Adora is terrified. At least previews have smaller crowds, but they're also more *critical* crowds – literally. They'll have a lot of publications in the audience tonight. If anything, this needs to be their best show. This performance will influence how everyone else decides whether they'll come to see this new take with the word bisexual in the opening act.

She has only been through a few true opening nights in her relatively-short career, but each one has felt like the world could end during it. If she fucks up a line tonight, it's going to be recorded forever in reviews. She gets down to the backstage long before she's supposed to and gets in position despite how she knows she's going to have to leave her cue for a pre-show huddle anyway. She needs to feel ready, but there's a lot of movement backstage as everyone gets ready or does their pre-show ritual and it's distracting.

Adora closes her eyes and tries to do breathing exercises because she feels close to hyper-ventilating. This show is such a big deal for her, the first time she is playing lead on Broadway, and unfortunately her anxiety knows exactly how much weight that has. Her hands feel shaky. She can't be shaky for the opening number. She needs-

"What are you doing?" Catra's voice cuts into her thoughts, close and sounding somewhat annoyed. Adora startles, turning her head to see Catra only two feet away, within distance to speak over the ambient music playing as the audience gets settled without being overheard.

"What? Just preparing," Adora says, managing to sound only a little breathless. Catra eyes her like she is suspicious. JD's trench coat mostly obscures her tail movements, but Adora can just barely see the tip twitching from beneath the hem in the darkness of backstage.

“You’re going to fuck up your voice doing that,” Catra points out. Adora feels a guilty twinge in her chest. She knows, that’s what she was trying to avoid, which is why she was concentrating on not having a panic attack.

“It’s fine,” she brushes it off. Catra isn’t appeased, pressing on.

“If you don’t have the air to open the show, you’re going to make a bad first impression for everyone in the cast,” Catra threatens. Adora feels a flare of anger in her chest. Why did some part of her think Catra was coming over to comfort her? That’s not who they are to each other anymore.

“Oh, is that all you’re worried about? Yourself?” Adora is kind of freaking out over here and she doesn’t need Catra heckling her to make it worse. Her chest is hot now, but at least that’s an improvement from the coldness of anxiety and oxygen deprivation. Catra flashes her a smirk.

“Duh. Save your bomb for later in the show. Maybe when JD’s is going off,” Catra says. Adora scowls.

“I’m not going to bomb.” Not if it means proving this new antagonistic version of Catra right, anyway.

“You sure seem worried about it,” Catra chirrups, smug. Adora fists her hand at her side, hating how Catra is right.

“Aren’t you breaking your own rules right now?” Adora snaps a little too loudly, annoyed. She quickly glances around the backstage, making eye contact with Perfuma who is looking over at them with far too much concern for Heather McNamara to be wearing, but she’s far enough away she can’t have heard much. When Adora looks back to Catra, Catra is grinning lazily.

“I don’t know, am I?” Catra asks, turning and sauntering away before Perfuma can come over and try to play peacemaker. She hated the cliques and still thinks they should all be trying to get along, not realizing that apparently the only way to ensure that is separation, because Catra clearly can’t help herself. Adora scowls at her back, but Netossa appears not far away from between two set pieces and starts motioning for everyone to huddle up, so Adora tries to force her expression neutral as she moves to join the circle.

Adora is annoyed, skin prickling, as Netossa gives them a few words of pre-show encouragement. She manages to tune in halfway through, but her eyes keep drifting over to where Catra is huddled up next to Scorpia and Glimmer, the latter of which is hopefully a mistake and not a ploy to get in contact, because Adora hasn’t stopped thinking about Catra’s comment about flirting since she said it. Netossa dismisses them after a brief cheer and they move to get in place. With Catra out of her line of sight, Adora’s annoyance finally starts fading as her eyes land on the center stage between props and curtains. She forces herself to smile to help reset her emotion before the cue comes for the entrances to begin.

She fixes her mind on listening for the beats in the music and proving Catra wrong. The closest she has come to breathing too fast since their conversation is an annoyed huff of air.

As she surges on stage amidst the whirlwind of students in the high school's halls, she has plenty of air for her opening narration.

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Pissing Adora off right before they go on stage isn't sustainable, but damn does it work. Her energy for the opening number is perfect, just an edge of fed up with this high school hierarchy, but when it comes time for their first song, Adora's eyes can't come off of her. The anger easily reads as obsession from the crowd, and Catra maybe plays JD a little cockier at first than he is in the script, but it *works*, it all works, even Catra's hands landing on Adora's thighs again during *Dead Girl Walking* and her hands quickly working their way up Adora's chest in the dark, because ever since the first time, Catra has always done up Adora's buttons for her. She can see what she's doing. She's much faster. It just makes sense.

She loves the intimacy of re-fastening Adora's shirt as if they just did what they pretended to. She was kind of worried the heat would die after this song, released in the passionate choreography, but if anything that seems to make it worse for Adora, which is to say, better for the show and even more satisfying for Catra.

When the audience applauds at the end of the night, Catra knows they fucking killed it. Netossa was wrong: fighting *works*.

Chapter End Notes

You have not seen the last of Dead Girl Walking (threat). And yes, for the uninitiated, the actual choreo is Veronica climbing in JD's lap while he's in bed and trying to ride him even though he's still clothed as she screams at him to get naked and pull her hair.

# Candy Store

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The promotional shoot in an Instagram-famous Candy Store up in SOHO makes sense and Catra isn't going to pretend Netossa doesn't know what she's doing when it comes to their marketing, but she's *too* aware. It's just the Heathers and Veronica, which is to say Catra and the entire internet looking at the photos knows every single person in that booth likes girls off-stage. Catra isn't sure if they're supposed to be in character and this is one of the brief moments of "friendship" while Veronica is in with the popular girls or if it's just all four actresses having fun as they take pictures and give an interview, but the way Glimmer sits with her arm resting on Adora's shoulder, way too familiar for Heather Chandler to be, makes her blood boil.

She doesn't know why Glimmer in particular gets to her more than the others. Sure, she bit back at Catra when she took potshots at Adora, but now they're all trying to be more reigned in and it still drives Catra crazy when she sees Glimmer sat beside Adora at warm-ups. Glimmer is playing Heather Chandler, so Catra at least gets the satisfaction of "killing" her pretty early in the show every night, but then Glimmer gets to haunt Veronica throughout the show, popping up again in her night clothes and faded makeup.

"Does that powder get on everything?" Catra asks in a drawl as she leans up against an unused scaffold backstage during Bow and Sea Hawk's worst moment in the show. Glimmer's head immediately whips to her. Catra takes immense satisfaction in being able to say completely innocent things with the right tone of voice and immediately rile Glimmer up. Maybe her reactions are the reason Catra can't leave her alone.

"Yeah, it's a pain. Aren't you miserable in that leather under the lights?" Glimmer retorts, but Catra just shrugs, unbothered. Glimmer can be as annoyed as she wants. Catra got a bigger role than Duke and a bigger role than Glimmer. She isn't her subordinate in this version. She's a psychopath, sure, but it's fun on stage.

She also gets to grind on Adora every night and all Glimmer can do is be jealous if she's inclined.

"I run cold," Catra offers. She always used to spend winters huddled up into Adora's side, seeking warmth from her as they waited on street corners or even down in the more temperate subway. Even in their apartment she would climb in Adora's bed in the winter so they didn't have to spend as much on heating, and just for that reason. Glimmer scoffs quietly, like she's trying to hide it – not from Catra, that would be stupid, but maybe from Netossa if she happens to be somewhere nearby.

"Yeah you do," Glimmer mutters darkly. She's misreading Catra if she thinks that slight on her character makes her do anything but preen. She works hard to be an ice queen and it's nice to see someone appreciate that effort. Catra glances towards the curtain and does some

quick math on where they are in *You're Welcome* based on what euphemisms Kurt and Ram are exchanging. She has time to pull some stunts.

Catra pushes off the scaffold and slips her jacket back off her shoulders, keeping an eye on Glimmer out of the corner of her eye as she reveals her body from beneath its bulk slowly. She has a lot of practice trying to make undress look casual but seductive from hoping to draw Adora's gaze from the other side of the room, and she knows she succeeds as she throws the jacket over her arm and turns towards Glimmer with a smirk on her face. Glimmer's cheeks are a little flushed and Catra can see her frustration.

"Since you were so concerned," Catra says, tone gentlemanly, which just makes Glimmer narrow her eyes at her. "You could try it to see how hot it feels, but it would drag on the floor for you, wouldn't it?" Catra adds, holding the trench coat up. Glimmer's eyes spark and Catra swears she sees a twitch, a false start where she honestly isn't sure what Glimmer's move would be after she fisted her shirt in her hand, but then Lonnie rounds the corner and waves Glimmer down, drawing Glimmer's glance and a hiss under her breath as she remembers she has a cue to hit before Catra does.

When she looks back at Catra, she has that intense look in her eye Catra is used to from Adora and she hears some epiphany going off in the back of her mind, some *oh* that doesn't make it all the way to her consciousness by the time Glimmer has stepped forward and gotten in her space again.

"I see why living with you made Adora that way," Glimmer says like a threat, smirking at the way it makes Catra still, staring as Glimmer decides to bolt now before this escalates, departing to take her cue while Catra is still trying to figure out what the *fuck* that means.

What way?

*What way?*

--

Adora doesn't like the song *Kindergarten Boyfriend*. Scorpia's voice sounds incredible when she gets the chance to solo it, but it's the realest the show gets in its black comedy with the autopsy on Martha's thought process before her desperate action. Luckily, Adora doesn't have to be on stage for it. She doesn't get a lot of breaks in the show, so usually she's busy guzzling water and catching a breath before she has to go back up. After night three, Netossa made room for a little chair right next to where Adora exits the stage for this song so she could get a few seconds of rest when she has the chance. She's collapsed on it and drinking water when she senses movement in the corner of her eye.

When the show is on, Adora has no hope of hearing any movement backstage, so that's all the warning she gets before Catra pops up beside her, sliding on top of the counter set beside Adora so she can perch on top of it right beside her, looking down at Adora on her small

upholstered chair that matches the carpet out in the hall. Her eyes are bright, which is always a bad sign with Catra. Before she even opens her mouth, Adora's heart is already racing wondering what her new idea is, and it's already *tripping* remembering that they probably aren't in on it together.

"Do you think Glimmer is serious about Bow?" Catra asks in a chipper tone of voice that drains the blood from Adora's face.

*That's flirting,* Catra's mocking voice floats up from her memory.

"Yes," Adora says, quickly and without hesitation. The entire cast has seen the way Glimmer lusts after Bow after Ram dies near naked and walks around like that for the rest of the show. An appreciative eye isn't necessarily incriminating, but the way they act together is.

It's a lot like the way she and Catra used to act. Adora hasn't said anything about Glimmer and Bow's standstill knowing what direction it moved in for her when she and Catra finally got momentum. Glimmer sometimes says things that sound jealous about Bow and never acknowledges there could be anything more behind them. Bow is so emotionally open Adora can't tell if he's also feeling something or they're really just the best of friends, but Glimmer wishes they were dating at least.

Catra *hm*s, turning her head to look out the gap in the curtain as Scorpia draws out her notes on stage. Her voice deserves to lead an entire jazz number, but it can't distract Adora from the twitching of the tip of Catra's tail, wrapping around the edge of the counter as it thumps.

"He's not moving fast enough, then. I could give him *encouragement*. Does she have a roommate?" Catra asks, flashing Adora another smile as Adora squeezes her hand around her water bottle. She downs a long drink trying to cool herself off. It doesn't help.

"She lives with Mermista," Adora informs her when she lowers the bottle, tone tight and controlled. If anything, that makes Catra's eyes sparkle. Her tail flicks again, dancing.

"I wouldn't say no to a double feature," Catra says. Adora feels close to breaking something. She is not about to go into *Yo Girl* with the right energy.

"Sorry, are you trying to help or make things worse?" Adora asks, just barely managing not to snap. Catra's shrug is lazy, but her grin is ecstatic.

"It doesn't really matter to me what happens next," Catra muses. *Consequences* are something Catra has a fleeting relationship with. They never seemed to stop her from doing anything short of breaking the law – and that's only *mostly*. Adora is pretty sure she only carries a metro card on her that's half-used to make it look like she must have scanned it if she does get stopped. She hasn't seen her top it up once since her mom stopped paying for it.

"It matters if it fucks with the show," Adora points out, glancing out at the stage and taking another drink before it gets too close to her entrance. The cool water feels amazing right now, but she doesn't need it on her vocal cords during a song.

“They barely interact. We’ve already proven it’s not hard to act through some bad blood – unless you think Glimmer is that inferior of an actress,” Catra says. Adora doesn’t mean to slam her water bottle when she puts it down on the ground beside her, but it doesn’t really matter; it’s not loud enough for anyone to hear from the audience.

“She could do it just fine. Stop being a brat,” Adora grumbles under her breath. She’s trying not to rise to Catra’s bait and give her the satisfaction when she *knows* Catra is only insulting her friends to get under her skin. This is all *nothing*, just as much an act as JD’s love affair.

“Pull my hair next time you call me that,” Catra quips. Adora jerks her head up, eyes snapping to her.

“What?” she asks, her voice a little horse in a way it absolutely can’t be with still half of act two to go. Catra flashes her a bright, magnetic smile.

“What?” she asks, innocently, before turning away and slipping off the far side of the counter, disappearing as fast as she came as Adora stares after her with her muscles tensing in a flight-or-fight reflex, torn on going after her, trying to stay focused, or hitting something.

Martha is dying on stage, so she has to settle for angrily screwing the cap on her water and hurrying into place. This has to be revenge for *I Say No*. She can tell Catra hates it every night when Adora sings *it’s too late, I’m going straight* as she rejects JD’s manic love. The fact it comes so close to a break when they can be alone backstage is something Adora figured out that she should dread in week two, but usually Catra scowls at her and walks away.

She should probably view those times as a blessing. It has been a long time since she has been this distracted walking out on stage.

Chapter End Notes

> The actual lyric for I Say No is “it’s too late, I’m getting straight” as a drugs metaphor, but they changed that to “going straight” for this version given the, you know, dykery, leaving the implication that Veronica is ready to pretend half of her doesn’t exist for the rest of high school to survive just like she did before. Veronica in this script is supposed to be a more sapphic-leaning bi who just doesn’t like any of the boys at their school for obvious reasons and would have fallen for JD regardless of gender (as she does in the original version of the musical).

# We Can Start and Finish Wars (We're What Killed the Dinosaurs)

Chapter Notes

> I know I put the triggers at the front of the fic, but I feel the need to cover this one again since it's featured front and center here: the song "You're Welcome" is sexual harassment if you want to be extremely sanitized about how you phrase it. I'm going to try not to get more detailed than that or bring it up again after this chapter, but we're dealing with that. Also mentions of IRL homophobia.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora is sat at her vanity doing her makeup for the night when there's a single rap of knuckles on her door and then Catra barges in without waiting for an answer.

"I could have been- What are you doing?" Adora asks, abandoning her admonishment when Catra crosses the room in seconds and throws herself over the back of Adora's chair so she can practically hug her from behind, one arm draped over her shoulders as the other holds her phone out in front of both of them. Adora looks bewildered in the viewfinder as Catra flashes a smile at the camera from over her shoulder. Adora ducks before Catra can take the photo, not totally removing herself from frame but at least making it blurry enough to be useless as she shoves Catra's arm up.

"Just take one photo with me. It won't kill you," Catra scowls, holding her phone out of reach in case Adora tries to take it, which would probably be Catra's next move if she were the one being harassed.

"You barely talk to me and now you want to take pictures together?" Adora asks as Catra tries to drop her camera in front of them again. "Stop it, I'm halfway through my makeup," Adora points out, trying to fend her off as she leans painfully down on her shoulders. Rejections went unanswered, but the implication that Adora will let her do it painlessly in a few minutes finally gets Catra to give up, sulking as she straightens from the chair and cross her arms.

"Hurry up," Catra commands. Adora rolls her eyes as she scoots her chair closer to the vanity from where Catra dislodged it in her shoving and picks back up her mascara.

"What do you want a picture for?" Adora asks. This is weird even for Catra. Catra flashes her a smirk in the mirror like she has been waiting for Adora to ask this entire time. She could have just *said*.

"Instagram comments think we either hate each other or are fucking nasty backstage," Catra says, causing Adora to almost stab herself in the eye and get halfway to choking while she's

at it. Catra's smile says she's pleased with that reaction. She did *not* have to phrase it that way. "If the *truth* gets out, we'll be labeled as difficult to work with, so just finish your makeup and pretend to like me for ten seconds so I can 'be your friend' from upstairs," Catra instructs.

Adora's heart flutters. She could try to use these few minutes to talk to Catra, but she doesn't need her crossed arms and wary stare to know she has her guard up. She finishes her makeup instead so she doesn't look halfway messy and leans back in her chair. Catra immediately walks forward and hangs over the back of it, but this time she flips to the forward facing camera so they can take a picture in the mirror. Adora gives her one shot where she's smiling, and then she turns her head slightly so she can actually see Catra in the corner of her eye.

"I do like you, even when you're infuriating," Adora murmurs to her in a low voice like the internet is going to eavesdrop on them through Catra's camera. Catra stills, her ears pinning back. She growls and pushes off the chair, apparently deciding one picture is enough. Adora only gets out "Catra-" before Catra has stomped out of the room, the door thudding shut behind her at just short of a slam. Adora sighs, disappointed. Maybe she made a mistake making a critical strike, but she didn't think Catra was going to be that open to friendly conversation. She wishes they didn't have to fight anymore.

By the time she has finally managed to tear her eyes from the door, her phone dings with a notification she had been tagged on Instagram.

The photo of them smiling together looks just like a dozen other photos Adora has posted with her co-stars, Adora's messy vanity in the foreground and nothing strained in their eyes. It's accompanied by a shot of Scorpia lifting Catra into the air for no reason during warm-ups and one of Catra and Entrapta doing shots of the bright blue fake drain cleaner Entrapta mixed up for Heather's murder. It just looks like a photo dump of backstage shots, innocent and under the radar, friends enjoying the time off during their job.

As if. *If only*.

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Catra figures if she posts a picture with Adora on a random day once a month, scattering in other photos from set in between, then they'll be fine and the speculation will just be another variety of bullshit in the Instagram comments. She isn't planning to actually talk to Adora outside of this new job requirement.

But some days the comments get to you. She can tell it's a bad day for Adora when she warbles in warmups and hunches down where she sits on the stage, ashamed, as if that's not what this part of the day is for. When Catra is in her dressing room later, she hears Adora continuing to practice. There's often practicing and more warmups filtering through the walls as the show gets closer, but Adora starts earlier than everybody else and keeps doing that particular set obsessively. They have to warm up, but Catra is a little worried her voice is

going to be shot by the halfway point of the show, so she goes and bangs on Adora's door and yells at her to shut up like she's just annoyed about the noise.

It works, but it's not the end of it. The show goes well until *You're Welcome* comes on. It's one of Catra's longer breaks in the show. Normally when she doesn't have to be on stage, she fucks off to hang out with Entrapta amongst the sound equipment so she can get a moment to herself – managing the audio is one of the few times Entrapta is quiet – away from her castmates before she has to go back. Tonight she has a bad feeling. She goes far enough to get a water bottle, but when Mermista and Perfuma rush off stage, leaving just Adora with Sea Hawk and Bow, Catra waits for them to move away and then slips over to stage-side so she can watch the action from behind the curtain.

Adora's voice is wavering. It's supposed to be at this point. The choreography is supposed to feature her trying to distance herself from the jocks as Kurt and Ram sing about all the things they could do together. Adora is acting damn well, with the same intensity they have as Veronica and JD, but there's real emotion behind that "relationship", as different as their feelings on each other are off-stage. They've done this scene a hundred times now. All it takes is one bad day for it to be not okay. Adora is acting like she isn't acting at all, and the audience is certainly going to leave singing her praises, but Catra is itching at how long her break is for the first time ever.

Adora's demeanor shifts as the song transitions into *Never Shut Up Again* like it's supposed to, but she still seems rattled to Catra. As much as she manages to outwardly project frustration, Catra can see the twitch of her fingers, almost like it was going to curl into a fist, when Bow and Sea Hawk re-enter the stage. Worse, Catra sees Bow not go through with the choreography all the way, not getting in her space like he's supposed to. He's up closer than Catra – he can see the look in Adora's eye that the audience can't, and he sees the same thing Catra thinks she's seeing.

Adora is not okay. Catra doesn't think she's anywhere close to a breakdown on stage, but as she chucks her water aside, she worries how convincing Adora's tears are going to be when JD rushes in to save her and how easy it will be for her to stop. They do this every night. It's choreographed, and Adora is basically best friends with both of the crass jocks off-stage, but Catra is more than ready to play the white knight anyway.

She rushes on stage to defend Veronica, gets her ass beat in seconds, and then finally when she's lying on the floor, it's just her and Adora as the bell rings and the other students flee for class. Adora is the one rushing to her side asking if she's okay, but just like JD, Catra's only question is if Adora is. Catra is supposed to be painfully hunched on the floor as Veronica tries not to cry, and she is, but she still manages to reach out and despite how it's unplanned, Adora immediately takes her hand and offers Catra a weak smile as *Our Love Is God* begins.

Catra is supposed to look towards the audience, out into broody space, as she stands and declares she's ready to burn the world down for Veronica. Tonight, she holds Adora's eyes. Adora never has to grab her coat collar and direct her to look at her, instead raising an unsure hand and cupping her cheek. Catra leans into it as she sings her vow. She has never sung the words with the conviction she does tonight, *we'll burn away that tear and raise our city here* a promise she – not JD – intends to fulfill.

Adora's voice is beautiful when it joins hers in harmony, slowly letting JD convince her their love is divine. There's only a hint of an emotional waver in Adora's voice that works for the scene, but Catra isn't sure whether to go through with the kiss. She covers Adora's hand with her own and tries to telegraph that it's Adora's choice without making it obvious from the audience something is different tonight.

Adora does lean in, so Catra closes her eyes for the short embrace, dropping her hands to rest on Adora's shoulders rather than wrapping them around her and caging her in. She can feel Adora's heart pounding where their chests are pressed together. Catra tries to catch Adora's eyes when they part, but they have to rush to the side of the stage for Adora to make her phone call luring the jocks to a secluded spot, so Catra just hovers at her side without touching her and watches.

Adora's hands aren't shaking anymore. Her voice is coy. She twirls the phone cord like she's supposed to. Her gaze is still a little too bright as she glances up at Catra for silent confirmation she'll protect her as she finishes the call. It's a different show than last night's. It's raw, and maybe even better to a critic, but Catra will take the usual any day of the week. The light still isn't back in Adora's eyes as she watches Catra load the gun and questions her actions.

Catra was worried how Adora would react when Kurt and Ram reappear, but apparently it's okay if they're just there to die. They never get anywhere close to each other in this scene. Catra is the one who gets close as she chases down Kurt, shooting him off of the trellis Veronica once used to climb through her window, but the window set isn't in place right now, just a wall surrounding a graveyard with two fresh residents.

There's no way to tweak the final choreography without impacting the framing of the song. Catra is supposed to come up behind Adora and hold her possessively as she continues to sing *our love is god* and Adora, reluctantly and fearing for her life, joins in. Catra tries to tense her arm up so it looks tight as she only loosely hooks it around Adora's chest, but at least Veronica is supposed to look panicked here, and then the lights go down and it's finally intermission. Catra immediately drops her arm from around Adora, taking her hand instead and leading her off-stage.

Bow isn't far and Catra can see the concerned look on his face, but she shoots him a glare as she squeezes Adora's hand and he doesn't approach, letting Catra lead Adora over to the nest of sound equipment Entrapta has built. Most people leave the area alone, afraid of pulling the wrong cord or getting caught in an onslaught of a conversation with Entrapta. Catra usually lets the conversation wash over her and sometimes even learns something, but Entrapta is darting away to take her bathroom break in the intermission as they step inside and that lets her and Adora be relatively alone. Catra turns to her and looks into Adora's eyes.

"Are you okay?" she asks, voice quiet. Adora immediately plasters on a smile and Catra glares at her before she can even reply. Adora's smile falters and she sighs.

"Thank you," Adora says without actually answering the question, gaze fixed on their hands. Catra just nods.

“What kind of asshole would I be if I weren’t worried?” Catra says casually with a shrug. Adora gives a wet snort and shoots her a look through her lashes.

“The exact kind of asshole you’ve been pretending to be recently. Tonight, even,” Adora says. Catra’s fingers twitch in her hands and she feels a spark in her chest, but she doesn’t let go of Adora’s hands. Of course she didn’t ask Adora if she was okay when she was warbling in the dressing room, she didn’t think she had to be caught caring about Adora’s perfectionism. She still waited by stage-side for her. She still knew Adora enough to know she needed to.

“I’m not going to give my co-star a panic attack on stage,” Catra says. That earns a weak attempt at a laugh from Adora as she reaches up and wipes at nothing on her cheek. Catra’s pretty sure a tear slipped out at the end of the song when her back was to her, exactly when it should because Adora was being crooned to by a murderer holding a gun across her chest.

“I wouldn’t have,” Adora mumbles. Catra tilts her head. She’s not trying to make Adora feel worse, just not compromise every wall she has been building when they have the time for Adora to get her head right before the rest of the show.

“Sure, but you wouldn’t have looked in love,” Catra points out. Adora doesn’t look happy with that, which probably means she’s right. Catra squeezes her fingers again. “Hey, what’s going on?” she prompts. Adora hesitates, almost like she doesn’t know. After a minute she gives a small, reluctant shrug.

“I don’t know. Just really anxious today, and somehow that made *You’re Welcome* too much even though I *know* it’s just Bow and Sea Hawk-”

“Adora,” Catra cuts off, voice gentle, because she can hear someone approaching and she’s pretty sure Bow is going to get distraught if he finds out how much that bothered Adora. Adora bites her lip and goes quiet. Catra lifts her other arm. “Would a hug help?” she offers. Adora looks up at her like a kicked puppy and Catra lets her hand go to lift both arms.

Adora pitches into her arms and hugs her back like she’s supposed to during *Our Love Is God*. Catra hugs her tightly, assured now that it wouldn’t make it worse. Over Adora’s shoulder, she sees the person approaching is Netossa, who pauses upon making eye contact. She clearly noticed the choreography changes. Maybe she even saw the change in Adora before the rest of them worked around it. Catra gives a small shake of her head and then nuzzles the side of Adora’s head to cover it up. She wasn’t sure if Netossa would trust her to handle it, but Netossa nods to her and retreats.

Adora doesn’t need to go into the second act feeling like Netossa noticed something went wrong. Catra knows her and she’ll feel like that’s an automatic fail condition. They can talk about it after the show. Catra scent marks Adora’s ear instead. Veronica is hers. On or off-stage, she wouldn’t let anything happen to her.

“It’s okay,” Catra murmurs. Adora’s next breath is a little shaky as she clings to Catra’s back.

“I know. I don’t know why it’s getting to me today,” Adora says, sounding upset, but maybe upset with herself is progress – or maybe that’s where it all started. Catra hasn’t forgotten

what Adora say about dressing room panic attacks, even if she seems to be past that phase.

“Because it’s a scary thing and unfortunately the people you know are good actors,” Catra points out, hand lifting to pet over the back of Adora’s head. Adora makes a gentle noise into her shoulder, arms tightening around her back.

“Does that include you?” Adora whispers. Catra thinks it might be a joke, or at least meant to come off as one. She might be asking if she’s acting all the time when she acts like an asshole. She might be asking if she’s acting right now.

She might be talking about the way Catra vowed on stage to turn everything to dust for her without a trace of wavering conviction.

“Obviously,” Catra scoffs. Adora snorts, but she doesn’t push Catra further aside from how she has her arms locked around her. Catra sees Bow walk by between props backstage, trying to appear casual, but he looks nervous when his eyes land on Adora’s back. They’ve been here a while. They still have their usual intermission chores to run through to be ready for the next act. Entrapta is going to come back any minute.

“I could totally kick Sea Hawk’s ass,” Catra volunteers. It earns a laugh from Adora, but she finally lets Catra go to straighten up and shoot her a thankful look. She doesn’t step back, so there’s still only a few inches between them as she reaches up and dabs under her eyes trying not to mess up her makeup.

“No, you couldn’t. I’m the only person who can beat him at arm wrestling,” Adora informs her. Catra quirks a brow at her.

“I beat you at arm wrestling,” Catra points out. Adora’s cheeks turn pink like the memory is just as vivid for her despite how Catra as kissed a lot more than the corner of her mouth since then.

“You cheated,” Adora says, which is totally true. Catra flashes her a winning smile.

“You think I wouldn’t play dirty with Sea Hawk?” she asks. Adora bites her lip and then seems to remember she was wearing lipstick, as minimal as it is – she really needs to touch up her makeup before going back on stage, another thing they need to cram into this intermission – and quickly lets it go.

“Not like that,” Adora says. Catra shrugs. She absolutely wouldn’t kiss him as a distraction technique so she could slam his hand on the table, but that doesn’t mean she isn’t willing to be underhanded.

“I’d find a way.” She’d defend Adora if she really had to. No one fucks with Adora except *her*. You can remove the “with” while you’re at it. Adora’s gaze is soft, almost hopeful, as she looks at her, but before she can maybe ask something about that night, like if Catra was actually aiming for her cheek or her mouth, they’re interrupted by Entrapta returning and stopping in her tracks, confused, at them standing in the way of the entrance to her nest.

“Excuse me,” Entrapta says, sounding a bit unsure of if those are the words she’s supposed to use in this situation, but Catra hurriedly steps aside to let Entrapta in. “Good to see you, Adora! You don’t come over here often,” Entrapta brightly greets as she drops onto the floor in front of her switchboard to sit cross-legged on the pillow Netossa threw down there in the hope it would do *something* for Entrapta’s back despite her assurances that this is how she wanted to work.

“Yeah, busy show. I, um, should probably go redo my makeup,” Adora acknowledges, inclining her head in the general direction of the staircase up to the dressing room. Catra nods, lifting a hand to wave her out. Adora really does need to do that before they go back on and she seems a lot better, even if she isn’t up to conversation with Entrapta. Hopefully she comes down from her room put together the rest of the way and there’s nothing to worry about.

Adora sends her one last lingering look before she turns to go, but she ducks her head and hurries when she spots Netossa as she’s walking away. Netossa lets her go, making eye contact with Catra instead as Adora passes her. Catra was kind of hoping to just hide in Entrapta’s nest, but she sighs and walks over to her as Adora disappears up the stairs to their dressing rooms.

“Do we need to extend intermission?” Netossa asks her in a low voice as she glances meaningfully at where Adora disappeared. Catra glances at the gently glowing hall entrance in the darkness of backstage and shakes her head.

“By seconds, if anything,” she says. It would be worse for Adora if they delayed the show for her and Catra does think she’s okay now. Netossa eyes her for a moment before nodding. Catra startles when her hand lands on her shoulder and they’re suddenly looking in each other’s eyes.

“Good job,” Netossa says. Catra feels the sharp edges she has been pushing down for Adora’s sake rise in her chest, her tail slowly puffing up as it sways behind her, but Netossa just continues on. “That’s exactly how I want my actors to improvise,” she finishes, clapping her shoulder and leaning away without a trace of mockery. Catra feels speechless as Netossa smirks and then wisely walks away before Catra can ruin the moment.

In theater, they have to look out for each other knowing a lot of things can go wrong in a live performance. Catra would have made those adjustments for anybody.

She wouldn’t have held them afterwards and murmured assurances into their hair, though. Netossa is smart not to point it out, but it still feels like she was thinking it.

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When Adora hears the knock on her dressing room door as she’s sitting at her vanity and packing up for the night, her heart lifts for a second, but when no one immediately barges

inside she realizes it probably isn't Catra.

"Come in," she calls, sighing at herself for getting her hopes up at all. Catra already crossed a lot of lines for her earlier and the show is over. She has no reason to make sure Adora is okay now, especially after the last half of the show went off without a hitch. Their conversation during intermission really helped Adora come back down to Earth. The low-level buzz of anxiety is still in the back of her mind, but she can tell what's real or not. When Glimmer and Bow offered to get dinner as a group after the show today, she gladly accepted. They're her best friends. She'll be happy to spend time with them with Bow actually wearing clothes and the theater far from their minds.

Netossa opens the door, causing Adora to pause as she packs up her bag.

"Just wanted to check in," Netossa offers. Slowly, Adora puts her bag down on the vanity, feeling her heart beat too hard in her chest.

"All good, just getting ready for dinner with Glimmer and Bow," Adora offers, flashing her a smile. It's fine. They're fine. Nothing is going on.

She knew Netossa noticed the changed choreography, as subtle as it was, when she caught her looking at her in the corner of her eye during intermission, but her post-show speech was about how that was one of their best shows – Adora's "acting" was very convincing, and Catra was extremely dialed in – so Adora thought it was fine.

"Cool, it'll only take a minute," Netossa says, closing the door behind her and dropping Adora's heart. Netossa is watching her in a way that Catra often does, like she can see straight through her. "What happened tonight?" she asks, her voice more gentle than accusing, but Adora still tightens her hand on her bag, fisting the handle.

"Nothing, just some anxiety. Happens to the best of us," Adora waves off quickly. She has come a long way from having panic attacks in dressing rooms, but that doesn't mean she *never* has them anymore. Everybody gets stage fright occasionally and that's all Netossa needs to think she has. Netossa arches a brow at her.

"Adora, I don't want to traumatize you on stage every night," Netossa says, causing Adora's jaw to drop. She quickly stands, waving her hands.

"No, no, it's fine! Really, it's not a problem. Bow's like, my best friend. I'm sorry I was off tonight, but it won't happen again," Adora assures. Netossa steps forward so she can reach out and gently lower Adora's hands for her. Adora's stomach is churning.

"Adora, I already pulled Catra and Bow aside to praise them for adapting. Like you said, it happens to everyone and we need to have each other's backs. I want to know if there's anything *I* can change so it doesn't happen again. It wouldn't be a problem to tone back the choreography if that makes it better. You're a great Veronica. I don't want you to come away from this show hurt," Netossa says. Adora draws in a breath, biting her lip and holding it. Everything in her screams *I can do it*.

She couldn't tonight. It's a one-off, she swears, but Netossa's gaze is unjudging, waiting. Netossa isn't shy with her praises or with her coaching. Sometimes she's a little harsh, but she always follows up with praise. She's an amazing director, the best Adora has ever worked with and maybe the best she *will* ever work with. If she says she's just trying not to traumatize her, Adora has to at least try to take her word, no matter what her instincts say, especially after a night like a tonight.

"It's stupid," Adora finally says. Netossa immediately scoffs.

"Doesn't look it to me," Netossa says. Adora shakes her head, glancing back at her bag with her phone inside.

"I promise it is," she mumbles. Netossa's hand landing on her arm is warm and gentle. Adora glances down at it rather than meet her eyes.

"Try me," Netossa says. Adora blows out a harsh breath she has been holding in since 2:10PM.

"It's not even- Like, the show didn't get to me out of nowhere. I knew I was signing up for homophobic comments when I took the part, but some guy went through all my photos this afternoon and left shit on all of them and it just… got to me, so I've been anxious all night, and then when *You're Welcome* came and they were right in front of me it was too much, but I *promise* it's not like that normally," Adora explains, waving her hands as she tries to distance herself from the explanation even as she gives it. Netossa's brow furrows and her eyes look concerned as she nods.

"It's okay, Adora. I'm sorry. It's normal to be bothered by that harassment, especially when the show puts you face-to-face with it. I wish I could protect you guys from that," Netossa offers, her hand squeezing on Adora's shoulder. Adora's chest feels hot. She manages a nod and a small, grateful smile. Netossa still looks concerned as she squeezes one last time and then drops her hand.

"Here's what I want to do. Get in a little ahead of warmups tomorrow and we can workshop a more toned-down version of the scene." Netossa raises her hand to cut Adora off when she opens her mouth. "Catra and Bow did a great job with it today, but I'd rather there's an actual plan in place if it happens again. We'll only use it if we need it, okay? No one is going to notice if the choreo is a little less aggressive unless they've already seen the show three times, and at that point they could use the variety," Netossa says, making it all sound easy. Adora takes a deep breath to reply and then finds she can't let it go. Netossa waits her out. Adora wants to say no, but she also can't say no.

Outside, she hears Glimmer talking loudly to Bow as she bustles down the stairs, no doubt about to knock on her door.

"Okay," Adora rushes out. It's a relief just to make a decision, especially when Netossa smiles at her like she's proud and makes Adora's heart twinge. Adora turns to grab her purse and Netossa steps aside, motioning for Adora to go before her.

“It really was a great show. You and Catra killed it out there,” Netossa promises. Adora’s chest is warm again as she feels the words lift her up a little.

“Thanks. She’s really good,” Adora says as she opens the door. She waves at Glimmer and Bow as they approach, who both light up upon spotting her.

“She really sells the love affair,” Netossa responds from behind her as they exit the room. Adora’s face feels warm as she distractedly agrees and then quickly raises her arms when she realizes Glimmer is going to hug her for no reason as she approaches.

Yeah, she really does. Like she said back when they talked, she acts fucking insane on stage like only they can. Most people who buy a ticket don’t realize they’re actually watching two shows in one, but from Catra’s Instagram comments, apparently some people have. It’s usually a lot less salacious backstage than people like to imagine. When theater romances happen, it’s usually stuff like a person in the ensemble and the lighting guy.

Whatever they have going on might finally fulfill the drama fantasies, if they actually spoke outside of what was needed for the show to work. As warm as Catra made her feel, Adora knows that entire conversation was within the terms of their agreement to make the show work. As they all bid Netossa goodbye and Glimmer tries to convince Bow they can go to her favorite Korean barbeque place, Adora can’t help but wonder: was that really all it was?

Chapter End Notes

Sea Hawk gets really into performing and was too Himbo™ to notice the change in Adora wasn’t just acting or he would have tried to back off too, but Catra and Bow had the situation handled.

# Got No Time to Knock (I'm a Dead Girl Walking)

Chapter Notes

> I might have been a bit conservative with the "Implied" tag.
> Listen I try to make this work without it, but for this chapter you really should watch the choreo for Dead Girl Walking to get the full experience (though the staging is a bit different in this version, the choreography evolves a lot between versions and even by the end of this run they had changed it so Veronica slaps herself instead of JD).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra can't decide if she hates Adora more for declaring her love for her every night or for then rejecting it in the second act. She knows damn well she pulls off JD's hatred as she prepares the bomb. It's such a harsh come down after a show of Adora flocking into her arms and kissing her like it's love. Sometimes Catra gets itchy leading up to a show knowing the whole routine they're about to go through. Adora is getting bold ever since Catra crossed no man's land to comfort her and she sat down beside Catra at warmups this morning, clearly violating the rule that they ignore each other unless necessary.

Catra knew she was going to act up today the moment it happened. She tried to go flirt with Glimmer, but she was thoroughly distracted by the fact Bow and Sea Hawk looked like *they* might be flirting, and as much as Catra would like to throw a cherry bomb into the middle of that love triangle and see what kind of splash it makes, it's not going to happen fast enough. Adora's going to kiss Catra before now and then and she's not going to mean it.

Kissing Adora is *torture*. 6.5. That's how many times they kiss each night. The first half point during *Fight For Me* is not even real because the entire scene except for Veronica is frozen in time as Adora ducks under Catra's arm and lines up with her, lips centimeters from hers as she asks if she could be seen with her and still be proud, breath puffing hot against Catra's frozen face. She's not even allowed to blink. Just thinking about it has her skin hot again and it's less than half an hour away.

"Want a shot?" Entrapta offers brightly, holding out the blue drink she makes for Glimmer's murder to where Catra is laying on the floor of the sound nest waiting for the show to start. The idea of drinking the fake murder fluid doesn't seem to be appealing to most of the cast so Catra is one of the few people who usually drinks it recreationally with Entrapta. It's made out of some sweet syrup shit Catra is pretty sure is meant for cocktails even if it's non-alcoholic, but she turns it down with a wave of her hand this time. She doesn't need Entrapta's homemade energy drink to add on to her restlessness tonight.

Adora likes the drink too, but they can't risk giving it to her often because she'd slam back the whole thing and get the jitters like a dork. Fuck, Catra needs it so bad if thinking about

Adora on a *sugar high* makes her chest hot. Yeah, there was no chance of her behaving tonight.

“Entrapta?” Catra prompts from the floor. Entrapta looks over from her sound mixer.

“Yeah?” she asks, tilting her head and causing her pigtails to swing. Catra’s gaze is fixed on the ceiling above her.

“If you hear Adora or I moaning, just cut our mics and don’t tell anyone,” Catra tells her.

Entrapta doesn’t ask questions. She just says a bright “Okay!” and goes back to setting up for the night. Catra’s tail flicks at her side with a satisfied thump.

Someone is going to have problems tonight. Whether it’s her, Adora, or Netossa remains to be seen.

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Catra is on one from the moment JD enters the stage. Her tone is cutting as she tests Adora in the cafeteria, her gaze is burning as Adora fantasizes about making out with her during *Fight For Me*, and her eyes fix on Adora like prey in the prop aisle of the 7/11. That’s where the first deviation occurs, Catra getting closer during *Freeze Your Brain* than she’s supposed to. When she’s supposed to just hold the drink out for Adora so she can sip it for a comically long time, her other hand falls to squeeze Adora’s arm, and it seems like she’s seconds away from holding onto her waist instead, all but coming onto her.

JD coming onto *Veronica*, which honestly makes *Dead Girl Walking* make more sense but doesn’t help Adora’s blood cool down. It’s a tight turn around from nihilistic flirting in a 7/11 to mattress-tearing sex in the same night, even if there’s a party between it. Adora knows that scene is going to be a problem even before Glimmer walks into the convenience store and Catra has to wrench her hand off of her like it pains her to not be in contact.

The party goes note perfect, but Adora’s heart is pounding as she climbs up Catra’s trellis. She expects this to be one of those nights where Catra puts her hands on her immediately. She doesn’t. She does the whole comically-rushed bookmarking routine and for a minute Adora thinks she has cooled off.

And then her hands lay on her waist, and her eyes burn as Adora controls her air to hit her notes on *let’s make this beautiful*.

“That works for me,” Catra says in the cheekiest voice, with just a little purr running under it, and Adora is ruined before they even kiss, but then they *do* kiss and she thinks she’s going to die. It’s supposed to be a quick and desperate slamming of faces as Adora sheds her jacket and then they part for Catra to pull off her own shirt.

Instead they kiss. Like, *really* kiss, Catra nipping on her lip as Adora fumbles with pushing her jacket back off her own shoulders. When Catra pulls back to shed her shirt, she tugs on Adora's lip and Adora is more than ready to scream the next *yeah* because she needs to scream *something* with Catra laying down beneath her with a pleased grin, shirtless and somehow way hotter than usual in her sports bra that Adora *tries* to be professional about.

Her entire body feels like it's quivering along with Catra's purr which *also* isn't supposed to be in this scene because it might fuck with audio. She almost considers cutting the hip roll because she doesn't need to encourage Catra more with her hands already on her hips, but then her body does it anyway on muscle memory and she decides she needs to focus on just getting the correct words out of her fucking mouth and not thinking about fucking Catra even as the heat flares through her.

The words *slap me, pull my hair* are a bad idea before they leave Adora's mouth, but Catra passively lets Adora mime her hand through slapping her. It must be to lure her into a false sense of complacency, because Catra's other hand that Adora lifts up to her hair comes to life.

It's comedy. It's supposed to be comedy. It is *not* supposed to be Catra's claws hooking under her ponytail, snapping her hair tie as she pulls the blue scrunchy covering it off and tosses it aside. The next line comes so fast, Adora hasn't processed her hair cascading around her face as she directs Catra's hands onto her body again on *there, there, and there!*

Catra must have forgotten all the damn jokes in the show, because instead of Adora slapping her hands over her own body desperately, Catra's hands squeeze her chest when she puts them there, half a second before she rips Adora's shirt open with enough force for Adora to see every muscle in her exposed arms and shoulders flex as the crowd cheers like it always does for boobs.

And now Adora is just grinding on her lap, trying to desperately to hit the notes as they hit the climax of the song and trying not to think about the word *climax* at all because Catra's hips rolling up under her, her fang imprint still on her lip, has Adora's mind lost in a hazy cloud. She isn't even sure they hit all the choreo, she just can't quite remember it as she collapses down into another kiss that is far too real.

The lights go down, night falling, as Catra's tongue enters her mouth. Adora's lips are parted as she tries to stifle a moan she absolutely can't have her microphone picking up. She really, *really* hopes no one is filming from the audience. She doesn't know how different it looked from usual, but it felt like a totally different scene, especially with Catra *still kissing her* even as she does back up her shirt snaps and an ominous music cue tolls from center stage. That means the red lighting is about to hit JD's lawn and they can't still be making out when lights come on*,* but *they're still making out.*

She hopes Netossa is so busy scrambling to find where her damn scrunchie fell backstage that she didn't get to watch the rest of the song. When she pushes off of Catra to fall beside her in the bed, her chest is heaving. She just barely sees the outline of Catra's head turn to face her too and knows she's watching her easily in the dark.

She's going to fucking kill her after this, she thinks to herself as the chanting starts and she startles "awake" into her nightmare.

--

From the start of Dead Girl Walking until intermission, Adora only leaves stage for a few seconds as they both drop behind the set so the stagehands can wheel in Heather's bedroom and kitchen set and the two of them can re-enter the stage from the other side for their early-morning call turned crime scene. They don't have any time for fucking around.

Adora still pushes her against the side of the set right before they step back on stage as Glimmer mimes through Heather's night routine. Adora's eyes are sparking and Catra can see that delicious line of tension in her body as she pokes her chest. She's beautiful with her cheeks flushed and her hair falling messily around her shoulders, some of it stuck to her face from a spit line next to her mouth Catra isn't sure which of them left.

"What do you think you're doing?" Adora hisses at her like she wasn't the one who parted her lips for Catra. She could have pulled back at any second and she didn't do it until the absolute last one that she could choose to be flat on the mattress by the time the imaginary satanic ritual on the lawn had started.

Catra lifts her hand and places it on Adora's lower back, sliding it *down* as Adora's lashes flare. When Catra squeezes, she scrunches Veronica's skirt up in her hand, so close to touching her exactly how she thinks Adora *wants* right now, but even Catra isn't going to feel up her ass without warning or permission.

"Pretty sure just what you want me to," Catra quips, causing Adora to let out a frustrated *ugh* as she glances up at the stage to see Glimmer is lying down. She reluctantly pushes herself away from Catra for their entrance. She just barely manages to make her annoyance look like nerves as they fix Heather's drink. Catra smirks at her as she pours its deadly twin. Tonight, she gets bold and backs Adora against the counter. She sees the flare in Adora's eyes, but she still lets Catra actually kiss her as Glimmer yells from her bed instead of aborting at the interruption like usual.

It only lasts half a second – they *were* supposed to be interrupted after all – but she sees that shiver run through Adora at her breath puffing on her face and it sends a thrill through every inch of her as she purposefully switches the mugs behind Adora's back and hands her the drain cleaner one instead of just letting her grab the wrong one like they usually do.

The onstage romance dies for a while and Adora manages to channel that tension in her body as panic and frustration as the accidental murder plays out. Catra gets to leave the stage for two entire scenes, leaving Adora to try to process her sexual frustration up there alone when there's no time at all to process *anything* because she has to remember every line and every timing beat in the two songs.

It's hard to get the jump on Catra, but it's easier with all the noise backstage. She almost walks into Netossa when she turns the corner into her whispering on the phone.

“Yeah, just get an entire pack if it’s the right color. You worked hard on the outfits, Spinny, I sure you have it memorized by now. We’re definitely going to lose a few,” Netossa says, her eyes suddenly sparking when they catch onto Catra. Before Catra can backpedal, Netossa has already raised her finger to point at her accusingly and pin her on the spot. “Love you, I’ll see you later,” Netossa bids her wife, and then she hangs up the phone, stalking forward as she shoves it in her pocket.

“In case you misunderstood what counts as acceptable improvisation, never make a new stage direction like that again without consulting me first,” Netossa says. Catra is sure no one would have been able to tell they kept kissing after the lights went down, but she’s frozen anyway as Netossa continues, “But that was fucking brilliant and we’re doing it from now on.”

Wait, huh?

“What?” Catra questions, breathless. Netossa narrows her eyes at her.

“Taking the Heather scrunchy off during *Dead Girl Walking* symbolizes her rejection of cisnormativity. It makes her look less put together for the murders. It’s perfect, but *you’re* going to be the one crawling over the sets looking for it after curtain call tonight,” Netossa explains. Oh. Right. Yeah, Catra was definitely thinking about the stupid scrunchy symbolism in this show and not how hot Adora looks with her hair down, which she usually only does for shows and doesn’t even need for this role because she’s supposed to be a little too tomboy before the Heathers choose her and put the bow-wrapped scrunchy over her plain hair tie in the opening number.

“I’ll find it,” Catra says despite having no idea where she threw it, just that it was in the direction of backstage so she could get her hands on Adora again faster. She doesn’t need to make Netossa madder at her than she already is. Netossa must get a silent notification because she pulls her phone out again and checks the screen, unlocking it and scrolling through something. Catra wonders if she can flee now to go start looking for the scrunchy before intermission, but just before she’s about to, Netossa glances up to her again.

“If Adora complains about you after this show, we’re going to have problems,” she says. Catra plasters a smile on and takes a quick step back.

“She won’t.”

--

Catra vanishes at intermission. Of course she does. Netossa appears to “check-in” and Catra, sensing consequences, turns into smoke and leaves Adora to breathlessly assure that everything is fine and the show is going great, really, although she’d like a new hair tie. Netossa tells her to leave it down so they can try this new direction and Adora manages to keep her face from twitching.

Catra has plenty of time to hide before Adora can get to her during their offstage moments in act two. They've never hit *I Say No* and *Meant To Be Yours* with as much energy as they do tonight. Catra tries to pull another vanishing act after final bow, but she isn't going anywhere in her costume and Adora knows where to hunt her down. Adora follows her up to her dressing room knowing there's no way she slipped past her. She doesn't knock, instead throwing her door open to find Catra standing in front of her vanity, already changed into her own jeans and a tank top as she packs her bag.

Adora has been simmering in sexual frustration for the better part of two hours. She managed to cool off some at intermission, but her annoyance at Catra diminishing didn't let her libido fully stand down. Catra looking up to flash her a lazy smile lights all those sparks on fire again.

"What, you've already changed? Were you just going to leave?" Adora asks, kicking the door closed behind her and stalking over to Catra. Catra's smirk only grows as she turns to face Adora, hopping up on her vanity beside her bag. She doesn't seem at all bothered by Adora getting up in her space to corner her.

"I don't wear a costume that's meant to be ripped off. *You*, on the other hand…" Catra says, reaching up and carefully hooking one finger over the top button of Adora's shirts. She's wearing the ripped and ash-covered version of the costume from the finale over her regular one, but it's fixed with snaps just the same as her main one because she has to put it on in a hurry after the bomb goes off.

Adora's mind fuzzes a bit like static as Catra's smirk curves to reveal a fang and she drags her finger down, pressure popping the buttons at her neck open, revealing her collarbones. This isn't what she planned for.

She didn't have a plan at all, she realizes as Catra hooks her finger over the next set of snaps, tugging on it lightly to pull it away from Adora's body before she pulls it harder. *Pop*. Adora's cleavage is now on display, but Catra isn't even looking at it, taking far too much pleasure in holding Adora's quivering gaze. The show is over. She clearly isn't doing it just to fuck with Adora to see what the limits of her performance are.

She might be doing it to fuck Adora, though.

Catra hooks her finger over the next button, a satisfied purr joining the stifling hot air between them, and Adora can't take it any longer. She growls under her breath and then she surges forward and kisses Catra. She's annoyingly ready for it, a satisfied purr rising in her throat as she parts her lips and licks into Adora's mouth. Fuck. *Fuck*. She doesn't know what the hell they're doing, but Catra arches into it and her hands run down her body like she *threatened* to do in the seconds before they walked out into Heather's kitchen, but this time she actually squeezes at her curves.

Adora is going to die. There's not enough air in this dressing room and there's not enough time before they should leave to avoid suspicion that could compromise their reputation with the show, but she thinks she's going to die if she doesn't grind on Catra again in the next few seconds. She doesn't even know what the suspicion would be, because she has no idea what they're doing. Outside of roles and some practice exercises back in high school – and that

one time they were arm wrestling, and *maybe* the first night Adora got drunk because she's a fucking mess with alcohol in her blood – they've never kissed. They do it all the time for the show now, though, and somehow letting Catra claim her mouth feels like the only conclusion to this game.

Catra bites her lower lip, tugging it again, and lines up to whisper in her ear as Adora groans and grabs her hips.

"Every night you're grinding on my abs, I think about how you would look riding my strap," Catra purrs to her. Adora gasps out, analysis and second thoughts going out the window. She wants that. She has thought about it and then tried not to so she could look Catra in the eye the next day. Apparently Catra doesn't have that problem. Catra purrs, pleased with Adora's speechlessness, and shifts her legs apart so Adora can press in closer. The feeling of Catra arching her hips up into her is the last straw.

"Brat," Adora growls out as she reaches up, pulling on Catra's hair. Catra moans with a tiny gasp on the end that Adora needs to hear again, right now, preferably with Catra face down and naked. Catra's tail is loud as it thuds against the side of her vanity and they are *so* going to get caught, but Adora doesn't really care with Catra's mouth on hers again. She's pretty sure it's too late to fire them. Critics love their "chemistry" too much, even if it's fogging up the dressing room.

"Do you have any roommates?" Catra manages to get out between kisses. Adora moans into the next one, groaning a little, as she remembers that conversation backstage. Glimmer can shove off.

"No," she says before kissing Catra again, running her hands up her sides and squeezing. She could get her naked here. She shouldn't, but she really wants to. This shirt would look so good on her floor back home, though.

"Perfect," Catra purrs before ducking and nipping at the corner of her jaw. Adora kind of feels like she's going to die if she doesn't get off here and now, but they could easily get caught like this and Netossa runs a tight enough ship Adora knows it would be a stupid risk. Her apartment is far, but it's private, and she needs more than a messy dressing room hookup. She needs to know what Catra sounds like when she doesn't have to worry about moaning.

"Let me go change," Adora agrees, breathless and biting down a groan when Catra's tongue runs up the side of her neck. Her thoughts are a mess of tangled X-rated images, frantically flipping so fast she can't decide which one she wants first. "And put up my hair again," Adora adds, an edge of annoyance slipping into her voice. Catra lifts her head just so Adora can see her grinning as she threads her hands through her hair. Adora has to fight to not let her lashes flutter closed at the feeling.

"Don't bother. I'm just going to take it down again so I can pull it," Catra tells her, smugly, illustrating her point by giving a slow tug that pulls a moan out of Adora's chest.

After they fuck through the mattress, Adora might still kill her anyway, if Netossa doesn't get to her first tomorrow.

“Fine,” she agrees, markedly more breathless.

*Please*. She feels like she’s on fire as she steps back and takes in Catra sitting on the vanity with her legs spread, lip bitten and hair wild.

Adora is going to *ruin* her in forty minutes.

--

Catra normally loves stage door. A few fans gather there at the end of the night to get an autograph and few moments time their favorite actor. There isn’t always someone there and there definitely isn’t always someone there for *her*, but every time there is she thinks of every dismissive thing her mom said about musical theater as she signs the autograph with a glow of pride. It’s especially nice having people come up and tell them how much her version of JD and this show means to them.

Catra has never wanted less to do with stage door than tonight. Of course there’s people there for both of them, what Catra is pretty sure is a couple wanting both their autographs and then a magicat hovering in the background for Catra. Catra tries to smile and listen as the girl gushes about what a dynamic show it is and how amazing it is that she’s in this role – there were more barriers than just her gender for it and conversations like this remind her of that – but the whole time she’s aware that Adora finished first and is still just standing there a few feet away, obviously waiting for Catra to be done.

“It was great talking to you, but I have dinner reservations I have to get to before they run out,” Catra lies through her teeth, handing the signed playbill and sharpie back out to the fan, who glances over at Adora with pink in her cheeks.

“Of course, thank you so much for talking to me! Have a great night,” she bids her. Catra sends her a wave of relief as she turns and walks towards Adora, speed picking up as she passes by the small huddle of people. Adora is grinning at her for some reason and has been the entire time Catra talked to the girl. When she reaches Adora, she grabs her hand pull her along with her before she can say something dumb, because that smile usually preludes some stupid teasing.

“Which direction is it?” Catra hisses to her, tail lashing behind her. Adora twists her hand in Catra’s so she can twine their fingers together as she takes the lead, pointing in the direction of the subway entrance just a block away.

“This way,” she promises. She’s still grinning, but she waits until they’ve crossed the next street to speak again. “That girl totally is going to hang that poster of you over her bed,” Adora adds, smug about that for some reason. Catra growls under her breath.

“I only have one bed I’m thinking about right now,” Catra growls. Adora makes a noise low in her throat, but that finally shuts her up. The subway better be running on time tonight.

Catra needs her hands in Adora's hair immediately or she's going to break something. She has been waiting for this for half a decade. She can't wait any longer.

Chapter End Notes

Adora's just proud of her ~~gf~~ sorry what was that?

# Happiness Comes / When Everything Numbs

Chapter Notes

Title from Freeze Your Brain

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It has been a long time since Adora shared a bed with Catra and it has never felt more right before. After multiple rounds that required a break for dinner in between them, Catra is a purring mess and happily collapses into Adora's arms at the end of the night, trapping her in the best kind of way. Adora wakes up at three in the morning needing to pee, though, because she really needed to before and just ignored it to avoid disturbing Catra.

She thinks Catra is deeply asleep enough for her to cautiously edge her arms out from under her and make her way to the bathroom. She tries to be slow and quiet as she goes, not turning on the bathroom light until she's all the way inside.

She looks like a wreck and a morning shower isn't going to erase the bite marks on her neck or the bruises on her thighs, but she has a bit of makeup in her apartment and some skin color pantyhose she can maybe wear tomorrow to help. She has no regrets, just a fleeting worry about how much her castmates might see and what they – specifically Glimmer, Scorpia, and Netossa – might say about it. Whatever. That's a problem for future Adora. She uses the bathroom, brushes through her hair because it's so wild from Catra's hands she worries about it knotting overnight, and walks back into her bedroom to find Catra freezing in the middle of picking her shirt off the floor.

Adora stares at her as Catra tries to turn invisible by not moving an inch. It doesn't really work with the tip of her tail twitching. Slowly, Catra looks up at her. In only the dim light from the lamp Catra switched on, she can't make out much of her expression, just wide-eyed staring with her ears pricked up to focus on Adora. She already has her jeans on. Her hand is holding tightly onto the shirt as she slowly straightens back up but doesn't move otherwise.

"You were going to leave in the middle of the night?" Adora whispers, feeling her heart fall to the floor. They didn't really talk. Any time Adora tried, Catra told her to shut up so they could kiss again. Adora thought they could do it in the morning.

She's pretty sure Catra thought that too and that's why she's trying to leave now. If Adora's apartment layout wasn't weird, she might have already bolted, actually, but Adora's bathroom is connected to the living room, not the bedroom, so Adora is blocking her only exit.

"Yeah, well, I have to go home before work tomorrow to change my clothes and shower, so…" Catra shrugs, looking away and trying to sound casual. Her voice is rough like gravel.

It might be the hour. It might be blown out from too much use. It might just be too late at night for her to cover it up and act.

“So go in the morning,” Adora proposes, stepping through the door slowly and closing it behind her. From the twitch of Catra’s ears and tail, she can tell she’s closely watching the door as it clicks shut, head ducked slightly as her eyes fix on the handle.

“Not really a morning person. Crepuscular and all that. Probably wouldn’t wake up in time for it,” Catra says, leaving them both just staring at each other, waiting for the other to make the next move.

Adora feels lightheaded. She reaches up to press a hand against her forehead and then drags it down her face, screwing her eyes up. It’s too late for this. Every thought feels like static. Why can’t Catra stay? Why did they do this at all if she didn’t want to? She can’t successfully talk to her well-rested, much less now.

“Don’t, please,” is what Adora manages to get out. They’re either going to fight now or they’re going to fall back to sleep together.

They fight every single night, and sometimes not just on stage. Catra is quiet, looking down at the shirt in her hands. Adora walks forward and Catra doesn’t acknowledge her approach, but her ears pin back as Adora covers her hands with her own and gently pushes them down. She leans forward hesitantly, but Catra still doesn’t pull away, so Adora presses a gentle kiss to her cheekbone right by the base of her ear. She lingers there as she carefully pulls the shirt from Catra’s fingers and drops it on the floor. She reaches up, cupping Catra’s jaw and cradling her face. Catra’s breaths feel shaky and unsure where they’re hitting Adora’s shoulder.

“I can give you new clothes in the morning, or wake you up early enough to swing by home if you want,” Adora offers in a whisper. Catra manages a snort.

“I *don’t* want, and people might recognize them as yours,” Catra murmurs. Adora’s hand still hanging by her side twitches. She’s not really surprised by that this is supposed to be secret given the complication of the show, but still, Catra not wanting to be seen with her and trying to sneak out in the middle of the night without talking isn’t what she was hoping for from this.

She didn’t really go in with a plan, just a desperate need. She’s pretty sure it’s the same for Catra and she might just be sobering up now. Adora closes her eyes and rests her forehead against Catra’s temple.

“I’m not going to sleep if you leave,” Adora whispers. Catra huffs.

“Okay.” That could be agreeing to stay or agreeing Catra is okay with her losing sleep, but her voice is soft, so Adora is going to assume the former. Adora drops her hand to Catra’s hip and Catra reluctantly turns back to the bed, letting Adora lead her back to the twin in the middle of the room. At the edge of the bed, Catra pauses and then sighs, reaching down for her fly. Adora’s hand slides down from her hip, fingers hooking in her waistband.

“Let me?” Adora asks. Catra’s hands still. After a second, they fall by her sides. Adora swears Catra holds her breath as Adora unbuttons her pants and slides them back down over her hips. She’s aware of her own breath hitting Catra’s chest as she bends to push the pants down Catra’s thighs. She’s not wearing underwear. Could she just not find it? Was she in that much of a hurry to vanish?

She isn’t now, sitting down on the edge of the bed so Adora can pull her pants down the rest of the way, kneeling to pull each leg off. As she does, she drops a kiss to each thigh, earning a lashing tail thumping against her bed. When Adora starts to stand, Catra reaches up, hands framing her head. Adora lets her pull her in, though she lets out a surprised sound in the back of her throat as Catra kisses her.

Given Catra’s eagerness to flee, she assumed whatever this was didn’t involve soft midnight kisses that slowly introduce tongue when there’s no way they’re following through on it right now. She could kiss Catra until she falls asleep, though, so she just closes her eyes and sinks into it until they part for Catra to draw in a breath and she doesn’t press back in. Adora leans back, trying to get a look at Catra’s face in the low light, but Catra quickly turns and tucks herself under the sheets, shuffling over to make room behind her and flopping her head down on the pillow as dramatically as Glimmer does when she’s pretending to be Heather Chandler.

She’s probably avoiding eye contact, but it’s cute and still makes Adora smile to herself. Catra’s ear that’s sticking up twitches as Adora climbs into bed behind her, shuffling closer until she can drape her arm over Catra’s waist and press a kiss into her shoulder. Catra’s tail thuds quietly against the mattress, but she doesn’t otherwise react, so Adora settles in beside her for the night.

Even with the uncertainties lacing the air, Adora feels part of her automatically settle with Catra pressed against her. She wishes she could sleep like this every night.

--

Catra leaves when the light hits. It’s hard because she’s deep asleep and Adora doesn’t have a bedroom window to give her a harsh wakeup call, but Adora is half crushing her in her sleep and that’s enough for her to wake up and check the clock. This time when she gets up and quietly dresses, Adora doesn’t wake up too. Catra’s ears feel like they’re stuffed with cotton when she looks back and sees Adora sprawled out in the bed around a suspiciously empty space, snoring softly. There’s a burn in her chest, but she ignores it as she pulls her shirt over her head and looks away, slinking out of the bedroom door.

She doesn’t know how she’s this touch starved when she grinds on Adora every night, but she doesn’t want the desperate and fumbling kisses of *Dead Girl Walking* right now, she wants Adora’s arm gently draped over her and her nose mashed against the back of her neck. That’s not wise for her to get invested in again, though. She’s not risking everything for something

that is probably only going to fall apart again. She'll take Adora's cautious touch and her secret midnight kisses. She'll go by morning.

The touches go, too.

--

Adora wakes up alone. She's not really surprised. She checks her phone just in case, but there's nothing there. It's early for Catra to be awake, but while Adora slept like the dead with Catra in her arms, she has no way of knowing if that was mutual. She's really bad at gauging that with Catra. She shoots Catra a *get home okay?* text and then goes about her morning, which involves a lot more clean up than usual. Her sheets should really be washed, she needs the longest shower of her life, and the kitchen needs cleaning too because Catra pulled her into a make out against the counter while dinner was cooking, and then when they got a little lost in it and her tail ended up sweeping some stuff onto the floor. Adora had other things to worry about last night than picking it up.

When she gets out of the shower, Catra has texted her back a simple *yeah*. Adora snorts and relocks her phone. She wasn't expecting anything else. She's just glad Catra didn't actually sneak out in the middle of the night. She thinks it would have been a little horrifying to go to the bathroom and come back to an empty bedroom. Catra didn't wait much longer, clearly, but Adora was at least braced for it this time.

There are certain things she can't brace for, like getting another text and checking it to find it's actually Netossa and she wants them to come in early to test new *Dead Girl Walking* choreography. Somehow, Adora felt more prepared for the song the first time they ever tried it.

--

Catra tries to decide if it's worse for the footsteps approaching to be Adora or Netossa as she hears them climb the stairs, eventually deciding Netossa because she doesn't know what *she* knows and thus doesn't have a plan for any confrontation with her.

It's Adora, she knows that from the way she knocks. Catra steels herself and then kicks her feet up on the vanity, trying to look casual.

"Come in," she calls, voice bored. Adora slips in through the door, closing it behind her and sending Catra a hopeful look that immediately makes her tail lash. "No," Catra states flatly, pointing at her. Adora pauses, looking at her for a long moment, assessing her.

"No?" she questions, as if Catra wasn't perfectly clear. Catra shakes her head.

“Nothing.” None of those puppy eyes, none of the soft shit Adora clearly wants that Catra is *not* giving her. They have a show to do. If they… There are *things* that could happen that would make Catra need to quit the show so she didn’t have to hear Adora sing her supposed love to her one more time, so they’re just not going anywhere near that territory.

Adora stares at her for a long minute. Catra looks back, refusing to flinch, only looking away to glance at the door pointedly. Her tail twitches when Adora steps forward, upgrading to a full lash when she keeps going and crosses the room. Catra tenses up, ready to stand and tell Adora to leave, but Adora ducks down to meet her instead. Her hand comes up to cup her jaw in warning so they don’t headbutt when Adora bends to nose her cheek. Catra’s tail lashes hard enough against the arm of the chair to hurt, and she probably should grit her teeth now and say *something*, but Adora’s hand feels so right against her face.

She tilts her head up and Adora’s lips meet her, soft exactly like they shouldn’t be right now, but Catra’s eyes are already closed and she’s sinking into it.

“What part of nothing do you not understand?” Catra mumbles as her hand comes up to tangle in Adora’s shirt, tugging to get her to realign for the next kiss. Adora’s teeth are somehow gentle when they sink into her lower lip and Catra briefly has visions of screaming Adora’s name. She can’t tell if they’re premonitions or memories.

“The part where you’re trying to take my shirt off anyway,” Adora informs her breathlessly before kissing her again. Catra growls, sucking Adora’s bottom lip between her teeth so she can bite it and tug in the way that causes Adora breath to stutter. Catra ducks her head and bites down on the point on Adora’s neck where she knows she left a mark last night, even if Adora covered it up. Adora lets out a small, stifled cry that finally satisfies the violent urge in Catra’s chest and she lets her go, flopping back in her chair and lightly shoving Adora away as she reaches up and wipes off her mouth. Adora’s eyes are half-lidded and Catra knows hers are burning.

“Now get out,” Catra instructs. She needs to get her head on straight and her thoughts professional before they have to go down and practice the new choreography Catra accidentally invented. She expects Adora to fight her on it just like she fought her on the *nothing*, but instead she just looks down at her with a cryptic gaze for a few seconds. Her chest is rising and falling a little too quickly from the kiss as she slowly nods.

Catra expects her to straighten, so of course what she does is lean down all the way and press a sweet kiss to Catra’s cheek, pulling away before Catra has even processed what she’s doing. Adora walks out with Catra’s jaw hanging after her, heart skipping a few beats.

How did she manage to get the last word with a schoolyard-level kiss?

And what *was* that?

--

Despite the new choreography being more intense, it's somehow easier to do *Dead Girl Walking* today than it has been every day previous. The coil of tension that has been underlying all her interactions with Catra is finally snapped, and Catra is being carefully neutral and passive, not saying much and just nodding and absorbing Netossa's new instructions. They try out enough takes for them to find something Netossa is happy with, and then they have to practice *that* twenty times before Netossa feels comfortable incorporating it into the show, but they finish before Adora gets totally keyed up again. With it now a part of the plans, Catra doesn't chuck her scrunchy into oblivion anymore, instead dropping it off to the side where it will fall right behind the set for – fairly – easy collection.

Except Netossa doesn't want her to put it back on the same night.

"Can I at least wear my regular ponytail after intermission?" Adora asks, trying not to sound distressed, as Catra picks up her prop in the background. She really liked having a role where she could have her hair up. She always feels like it's falling in her face no matter what she does otherwise and it makes it harder to catch near-invisible cues. In the original version of the musical, however, Veronica never got a Heather scrunchy and always had her hair down.

"Yeah, I think that could work if we lean into the 'tomboy' look from the start of the show," Netossa muses, hand on her chin as she thinks. Veronica isn't supposed to be a big target for homophobia at the start, but there's something off enough about her that she needs the Heathers' help to get by. Adding the bow-wrapped scrunchy when they change her into the coordinated outfit she wears for the rest of the show was supposed to represent how she could cover up who she was, but not change how she felt inside.

Adora breathes a sigh of relief as Catra vanishes from her periphery, probably taking their moment of distraction to outrun any serious kind of conversation, though Adora isn't sure if it's her or Netossa that Catra wants to avoid more. Glimmer told her that Netossa came up looking for them right after they left and asked Glimmer if she knew where they were. Then Glimmer asked Adora that question too and Adora suddenly remembered she needed to head down early for a quick warm-up before the new choreography practice.

Netossa's eyes fall on the entrance to backstage Catra disappeared through for a long moment before she looks back to Adora.

"Hey, are things really okay with Catra?" Netossa asks in a low voice, her critical gaze fixed on Adora's face. Adora tries not to give any reaction despite how many emotions are tied to that question. She thinks the answer is yes. She's still barely talking to her, but after making her scream her name, she has more hope in that regard. She always felt like they were circling something a little more than friends before and now she knows without a doubt that was true.

She just has to figure out how to reintroduce friendship to it, too.

"Yeah, we actually got dinner together yesterday," Adora says, pulling up the same lie they told at stage door as she waves Netossa off before she thinks far enough to realize how that sounds. Dinner can be innocent, though, right? She gets dinner with her castmates all the time and it's not a date. Netossa arches a brow at her.

“Oh? What did you get?” Netossa asks. Adora tries to push down the heat rising to her face. Not dessert, that’s for sure.

“Lo mein.” That’s what she fixed quickly on her stove for them anyway. Netossa looks dubious at best.

“Any problems with how the show went last night?” Netossa asks. Adora plasters a smile on her face.

“Nope, all good!” she promises.

She *says* that, but when it’s time for their first kiss post-*Dead Girl Walking* that night, Catra leans in and really kisses her just like she did last night, and Adora kisses her back all night for the three remaining kisses in the show. Adora is still left alone in her dressing room at the end of the day, head collapsed on her arms as she hunches over the vanity remembering how soft Catra’s lips were against hers and how it felt to breathe her in under the lamp light.

She thinks Catra got what she wanted, but her entire body feels like it’s aching from far more than soreness.

Chapter End Notes

Chapter count is finalized <- desperately hoping I’m correct

# Fight For Me

Chapter Notes

> First spoken scene after meeting JD -> first scene after Fight For Me (previous spoken scene is her and JD *meeting* for the first time)
> Also I know I have the content warning at the start of the fic, but this first scene features slurs and some homophobia (I added stuff that wasn't originally there and there's discussions)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Netossa left most of the songs as unchanged as they could be outside of gender differences, but some of the spoken dialogue scenes got revamps. The first one after Veronica has met JD is the most glaring one. Catra has been faking passivity Adora doesn't believe at all since their dressing room encounter, but she's being intense on stage in a way that feels a lot more real. Maybe she was just horny before and this is now acting, but Adora doesn't believe that. She can't.

She also can't fight the way she feels when Catra completely ignores her in warm-ups and then looks at her like *that* in Westerberg's "cafeteria". *Fight For Me* is starting to become emblematic of their entire relationship, Adora singing to her, desperately putting herself forward, as Catra stands frozen in time as a statue or moves in slow motion as she fights and completely ignores Adora. It's Veronica's internal monologue, but it's not far off from how Adora feels.

"Your mouth was hanging wide open," Glimmer declares to the audience, tone carefully poised, as she sets the croquet ball down in center stage. Adora jerks her head up like she always does, ponytail hitting the back of her head.

"No it wasn't. It was just a really intense fight," Adora corrects. Glimmer makes a little *hm* that sounds satisfied, Heather completely convinced in her own knowledge.

"Come on, admit it, you like the new girl," Glimmer says, voice sing-song, as Perfuma steps up to swing at the croquet ball and misses. Glimmer rolls her eyes at her and motions for her to move aside. Adora nervously fidgets with the handle of her croquet mallet.

"I was just impressed seeing someone stand up to Ram and Kurt," Adora deflects. Glimmer pauses facing the audience, but Adora knows from the stage direction that Glimmer's mouth has just fallen open in exaggerated disbelief and annoyance that Adora is putting up a fight on this.

"You were totally ready to fag it up with her," Mermista comments smugly from the side as Adora flinches, but Glimmer is quick to turn around and snap at her.

“I am *talking* to my *friend*,” she hisses at Heather Duke for talking over her. Mermista’s mocking smile immediately vanishes.

“Sorry, Heather,” she apologizes quickly, body language retreating to focus on the mallet in her hands much like Adora is. Glimmer lets out a *hmph* and then turns back to the croquet ball.

“It’s fine, you know. Guys like girls like that,” Glimmer comments. She’s really a phenomenal Heather, line delivery always making it clear she’s either in charge or up to something – in this case, trying to convince Veronica to out herself.

“I like guys. I had a boyfriend freshmen year,” Adora quickly points out. Glimmer looks up to send her a condescending look.

“I know, and that virgin was more effeminate than the new girl you want to throw your panties at,” Glimmer says, and then she swings the mallet back and whacks the ball with perfect precision. This might be the part of the show with the highest chance of something going wrong. If Glimmer misses her swing, they have additional lines to go through as Heather snaps at them to shut up and then takes a second turn at it – and third, if necessary, because she would be bratty about it and pretend it never happened. The original staging for the scene didn’t even have a real ball here and it was supposed to just be imagined, but Glimmer is scary good at croquet it turns out, so it’s usually not a problem for her to make the shot.

She hits it first try tonight, the ball shooting towards backstage and rolling out of the audience’s view, where Castaspella is waiting to emerge with the second prop ball in one hand and a plate of snacks in the other. Lance is already waiting in the corner of the stage, supposed to be reading on the “patio” and not paying much attention to them until Veronica’s mom walks in. As soon as an adult is listening, the conversation is dropped and they return to musical’s original script for the time being.

The subject of her and Catra always ends up dropped, never concluded. She wants an answer, but she doesn’t want an end. She’s too afraid to push Catra right now and find out they’re one and the same.

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For all of high school, Catra thought there might be a chance that Adora felt something for her beyond friendship. Adora didn’t say it often, but she seemed confused when someone would imply that it wasn’t universally held silent knowledge that Catra was attractive. *Attractive* and *dateable* are two separate things, though. Catra could never tell if she was anything more than “the hot friend” to Adora. They had shared some heady moments, and even a few kisses while practicing scenes, but nothing as intense as what they go through in this show.

Catra wasn't sure they would ever actually kiss off-stage. Now that she knows what Adora sounds like moaning, she is at a crossroads. She still doesn't know if this makes her just someone Adora is sexually attracted to or if, when they got an apartment together, Adora was also hoping that at one point they would upgrade to having just one bed.

They didn't. Instead Adora went on tour and without a shared lease Catra was forced to move back in with her moms for five months, which was somehow worse than all previous eighteen years combined because she thought she was finally free of her mom trying to manage her. Catra can't go back to how low she was then. She has to be very careful with how she plays this now. She can't get caught up in the fantasy that it will all just work out now when it could cost her a dream role and maybe the kickstart to a long career.

The best thing she can think to do is stay the course she was on – treat Adora like a co-worker. As a show progresses, casts usually become friends, so sure, she's more willing to let Adora talk to her at first call now, especially if it keeps her from pushing for more, but she tries to avoid interacting with Adora off-stage. In character, nothing genuine can happen, no love confessions or rejections outside of the script, and things will stay the same as they have been. They're finally okay, Adora's eyelashes flutter when she grinds on her abs every night, and Catra at least gets to kiss her when she has the trench coat on.

During the show, they're in love, and Catra finds herself falling into delusions she hates herself for having, but if she limits their interactions behind the scenes, she gets to experience the high of Adora being totally gone for her for two hours straight every night. She knows she's being intense from the praise Netossa gives her, but she can get through a show getting drunk on moments like this, so that's what she does. She avoids Adora, finding paths up into the rafters and perching spots on top of sets no one else seems to look up to find, and when she re-enters the stage, she gets to wrap her arms around Adora and kiss her for real. Adora always lets her do it like she likes it.

Adora might play by the rules and not bother Catra if she just spent her time off-stage hanging out with Entrapta, but when their interactions are limited to being on stage, they're also limited to when Adora is in love with her.

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Final bow is always a high. It's fun when the audience laughs, cheers, or applauds during the show, but they have to stay in character, remember the next line, and hit the next note. They can't really soak it in, and they definitely can't react. During final bow they can just walk out on stage and smile as much as they want as they thank the crowd for giving them an amazing night. Adora enjoys it for every show.

Final bow is the only time Catra will touch her "outside" of the show. She and Catra come out last and as a pair, Catra holding her hand. She always stops at the midpoint of the stage, gestures for Adora to go first like a gentleman – probably to distance herself from JD's stage persona in the eyes of the audience – and Adora walks up to the edge of the stage where she

does a little twirl and bow. Tonight the audience has been especially uproarious, laughing at all the right moments, but also gasping with shock or fear when there was a reveal.

Adora feels a rush through her entire body as she beams and waves to both sides of the audience, ending with a little bow before she turns back to where she left Catra mid-stage and starts applauding for her to take her walk. She's glancing over at Glimmer to exchange a smile and see if she's also feeling especially high tonight – from the glow of her face it seems like she is – when Catra reaches the front of stage and it happens. Catra raises her hand to wave and she gets a loud boo from the left of the audience.

Adora's head whips around and she glares at the audience, but she can't make out who did it. It's not unheard of for people to boo the "villain" characters, but usually they can read the room and not do it during the bows. All Adora can see from behind Catra is her ears pinning back and a slight stutter before she bows like usual and waves only to the right side of stage. That doesn't seem to go over well with the heckler, who boos again, this time letting Adora narrow in on a few seats that could be the culprit. Before she can scrutinize every person, Catra turns around to walk back towards where the rest of the cast is arranged in a line, clapping for each other.

Catra is still smiling, but she isn't. Her eyes aren't doing the same thing as her mouth. The heckler could just be doing it because she's the villain, but no one did anything when Glimmer, or Bow, or Sea Hawk came out. They could just be homophobic. Maybe they have a problem with Catra specifically. Adora doesn't really care why they're doing it – what she cares about is how high they all felt before this person knocked Catra right off the ladder. The rest of the audience is still cheering, but Catra's head is ducking a little as she approaches Adora, and Adora can see a look in her eyes that seems a little like dread to her.

Adora lifts both her hands, beckoning Catra in. Catra's ears twitch, perking up, as she follows Adora's encouraging smile. She's supposed to join Adora as she steps back to line up with their castmates so they can all join hands and bow together. Instead she slots perfectly between Adora's hands, letting Adora frame her face and pull her in close.

If it's a homophobe, then they're going to have to put up with one more lesbian kiss tonight than usual. The crowd cheers and wolf whistles as Adora kisses Catra softly, eyes closed and ignoring the vague noise of dissent from the left that is being drowned out. It's a quick kiss. When they part, it's only by a few inches, Adora still cradling Catra's face as they make eye contact to check in with Catra's back shielding them from the audience. Catra is a little wide-eyed, maybe stunned at Adora's boldness, but when Adora drags her hands down to take up Catra's, she gives a small smile and lets Adora lead her back to the line with their castmates. When they all join hands and give the final bow, the booing has finally stopped, and Catra might not be radiating that careless joy Adora was feeling when she first stepped out on the stage, but she's smiling again.

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Catra hasn't been booed on stage before. Not at a real performance, anyway. At their acting college, sometimes they were encouraged to be cruel to each other while performing so they could learn to "handle it with grace" or whatever the justification was, but she has never played a prominent villain before. She knew this could happen, but it still usually *doesn't*. Usually last bow is the final high before she steps off-stage, out of her delusion and into the cold wash of reality, but tonight she got shoved directly into the ice early.

She has no idea why Adora kissed her. She knew she was going to do it as soon as her hands cupped beneath her ears to tug her in, but she doesn't know why that was how she chose to show her support for Catra on stage. All their castmates are shooting them looks as they depart for backstage, causing Catra to duck her head and scowl at the floor.

"Not cool," Mermista comments, plainly, as the lights go out on stage behind them and up out in auditorium. Catra's tail twitches. It's a stunning endorsement – really, it is, at least from Mermista. She's not about to kiss Catra to prove a point, but it does still make Catra feel a little better.

"I don't know how people can think that's okay, even for antagonists," Perfuma sighs with a shake of her head. Finally, Catra forces herself to look up to see what Adora's expression is like.

Focused, is the answer. Focused on her with an edge of concern. She squeezes Catra's hand. She never let go of it while they were on stage and Catra took the offered support. She lets go and Adora reluctantly drops her hand too, but it certainly doesn't help the edge of concern in her gaze.

"If it's a homophobe, they should have gone to a different show," Adora says, sounding like she's replying to Perfuma, but her eyes are still locked on Catra. Oh. That's why she did it. Right. Stick it in their faces. By sticking their faces together. Normal.

Catra is going insane. Out of nowhere, Glimmer elbows her in the ribs, because no one has ever been able to resist kicking Catra when she's down, apparently.

"Next time we can make out in center stage," she jokes while Catra is still recovering her air supply.

"What the fuck?" Catra points out, weakly, as she clutches the spot Glimmer hit. She didn't know she was *strong*. Glimmer rolls her eyes and ignores her like she didn't just commit assault and make it look casual, instead sending Adora some kind of look over the top of Catra's head.

When Catra straightens up, Adora is looking away. Catra looks between them, not sure what the hell she just missed and not liking it. She has been flirting with both these girls backstage and she's pretty sure Glimmer still hasn't forgotten the way she treated Adora during workshop even if they asked their friends to collectively pretend it never happened so they could all get along for the show. The cast has grown closer, which yes, even includes Catra and Glimmer, but nothing has gone right tonight.

“I, personally, find it the mark of a great performer if you manage to elicit such a strong response from someone, even if it’s negative!” Sea Hawk declares proudly from the side, like that helps. It’s so stupid it kind of does, actually, because it makes Catra snort as Mermista reaches up and puts a hand over his mouth.

“Yeah, you’ve had to tell yourself that,” she says, dryly, which even gets Catra to crack a smile.

As unsocialable as she tries to make herself, apparently her cast still has her back.

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Adora is glad that everyone they work with wanted to say something to Catra to make her feel better, but it kept them down in backstage later than they usually would have been. She takes longer to get ready to leave than Catra does, needing more time to change and to take off her makeup, so she’s worried Catra will leave before she’s done, but Netossa caught her as they were heading up to apologize and give her advice for if it happens again, so when Adora goes to knock on her dressing room door, Catra is only just about to leave, opening the door and blinking at her in surprise. Adora offers her a hopeful smile.

“Hey, you got dinner plans?” Adora asks, fidgeting with her bag a little.

“Why, have a rule against kissing without a date you’re trying to justify?” Catra asks, tone dry enough to make it clear the very idea is a joke. Adora feels a twinge and ignores it, just like she ignored the look Glimmer gave her like she was expecting Adora to have a reaction to her make out proposal.

She did, but if she asked Catra to go out with her right there, the entire cast would be all over them tomorrow.

“You did amazing tonight. They don’t deserve to bring it down. Let’s celebrate,” Adora explains. She’s not stupid enough to think Catra would agree to a hangout, much less a date, under normal circumstances given how much she has been avoiding her, but she doesn’t want Catra’s last memory of tonight to be someone booing her. Catra eyes her suspiciously.

“It’s getting late,” Catra says, like that matters given her sleep schedule. She’s just delaying.

“You can’t say no to dinner if I’m paying,” Adora hedges. Avoidance aside, Catra accepted her offered embrace when she needed it tonight. She wants Catra to know that’s not a one-time offer dependent on circumstances.

“Try me,” Catra immediately says, because she can’t *not* be contrary, but she doesn’t sound like she means it as she eyes Adora.

“I know a fantastic Korean barbeque place that’s open late and nearby,” Adora adds. Catra *hm*s, tilting her head as she considers her. It’s really cute how her ears stay in the same place,

pricked up and focused on Adora. After a moment, Catra sighs dramatically.

“Fine, I guess,” she agrees like she’s doing Adora a favor. The way Adora perks up doesn’t exactly disprove that, though.

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The place smells fantastic from the moment they walk in the door, but Adora clearly neglected to mention some things when she was trying to coax Catra out of her dressing room. It isn’t just a barbeque place. There’s an open karaoke stage in the main restaurant space and then private karaoke rooms making up the entire second story. They might be singers, but Catra isn’t in the mood for it after getting booed on stage, and she probably wouldn’t be even if things went well after a long show. The food smells *amazing*, though, so she tries her best to ignore the poor rendition of *My Way* happening in background in favor of eating.

Whoever hated her in the crowd tonight, they didn’t come to stage door, and those who were there apologized on behalf of the entire audience. She highly doubts everyone who came was interested in her – one of them was even carrying a poster of Sea Hawk to get signed – but most of them did still ask for her signature at least on their playbill. It was sweet. It made her feel better after a hard end to the show, but part of it did feel coddling. She prefers the Adora method of just making out to ignore the haters.

Adora seemed angry when the incident happened, but now several blocks away from the theater and in this tightly packed – but at least not too busy – restaurant, she’s glowing as she talks, avoiding the topic of the show where she can, giving Catra no further insight into why she did what she did. She had a different interpretation of why it happened than Catra did, clearly, but they didn’t have to do *that* about it. For a second it didn’t matter, though. For a second Adora was in love with her even after the show ended.

There’s an alarm system going off somewhere in the corner of her brain that is supposed to be in charge of plans, but she’s a creature of impulse and no one, not even herself, can control her. She shouldn’t be in this small booth, looking at Adora with stars in her eyes as she “cooks” for them, but she doesn’t even mind that Adora can barely come up with topics that aren’t related to work. It seems like it’s her entire life, which tracks with how they fell apart.

If they did fall in love, it probably wouldn’t work once they weren’t in the same show. She’ll probably lose even *this* when the show is over.

Her heart falls to the bottom of her stomach. If their next show sees them going separate ways, would they go back to never talking even if they made an effort to be friends again once the show wasn’t in jeopardy? She has been avoiding putting in that effort to keep herself safe, but hearing Adora talking about the dance classes she takes between shows, she realizes she’s going to be a fucking wreck once she loses what they have on stage, fake as it is, and

someone is trying to sing a fucking *love song* in the background, and it's too late for her to be spiraling like this because she's probably not going to fall asleep until four A.M. now.

She glances back at the karaoke stand as Adora moves the food she "grilled" onto her plate proudly.

"Hey, let's get a karaoke room after this," Catra proposes, looking back to Adora, who immediately furrows her brow, confused.

"What, you want to sing after a show?" she asks, because yeah, if *Adora* proposed it, Catra would call her stupid. Catra *hms* as she grabs her utensils.

"I'd like to hear your voice," she says, cryptically.

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It's not singing so much as desperately trying to stifle every sound in her hand after Catra has looked around the room and confirmed she doesn't think there are any security cameras. She can't tell if they got their money's worth or totally wasted their time with the private room because Catra isn't about to get that vulnerable in public herself and let Adora return the favor, but even just making out with her in the booth afterwards has Adora feeling a bit of that high the audience brought for the first part of the night, so she's leaning towards it being worth it.

Catra's teeth on her lip, one hand down her pants and the other feeling her up like she can't stand to not be in contact, doesn't have a price. They only stop because Catra hears someone coming down the hall and they're not willing to push their luck further. Adora ducks her head as they walk out, worried that the glow within her heart is visible, and when they reach the street corner Catra pauses, glancing down at their hands. Adora is pretty sure Catra only held hers as they walked out to give her confidence after they committed a literal crime in the backroom.

"I'm south," is all Catra says, glancing at the subway entrance a few feet from them. Adora's glow was already dimming anyway knowing this separation was coming, but she was hoping they could at least travel a little further together. Her apartment is up on the north side of the city, apparently in the opposite direction of Catra. Adora pauses, following Catra's glance down to their hands, and then she turns so they're facing each other and squeezes Catra's hand, trying to coax her gaze up. When Catra does meet her eyes, her expression is guarded, so different from the soft sighs she offered Adora just minutes ago.

"My place next time?" Adora offers, trying to sound casual, although some of her hopefulness slips out. She doesn't know there's going to be a next time, but she hopes there's going to be a *something* and they can't keep doing this in public. She found out from Entrapta that she and Catra live together when she was looking for Catra during intermission last week. Catra's ears and tails twitch, some kind of aborted movement not getting cut off fast

enough to hide completely as Catra blinks up at her with wide eyes. A second later she's looking away, ducking her head even as her tail sways behind her legs.

"Yeah, sure," Catra mutters hurriedly and then she takes off for the subway, rushing down the steps at just short of a run to avoid any kind of reaction, or maybe just outrunning commitment.

Adora wishes they could fall asleep in each other's arms, but she takes a deep breath and when she lets it out she doesn't feel her heart deflate.

There will be a next time. Now if only she could get Catra to talk to her between now and then.

Chapter End Notes

Heckler was one of those people who thinks it's funny to boo the antagonist, but also Adora was right and the reason he booed Catra specifically was because he is kind of homophobic and to those people Catra/JD is viewed as the "aggressor" in the changes to the musical since that's the character that was genderswapped. Obviously Veronica is bi now, but she was always a girl and Janis Dean is a butch and as dyke as it gets.

# Big Fun!

Chapter Notes

> Kurt and Ram suck but aside from the toxic masculinity and "You're Welcome", Bow and Sea Hawk are having the time of their lives being homoerotic bros

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra sits next to Glimmer at warmups because it's funny. Normally she hangs with Scorpia, but lately Perfuma has been doing that too and she can't keep watching Perfuma flirt with an oblivious brick wall or she's going to be compelled to intervene and she absolutely does not want to involve herself in that. She'd much rather get Glimmer hot and bothered.

Her and Glimmer have a contentious relationship. At first they only held back from insulting each other under orders, but slowly that restrained hatred has been fading and now they – mostly – just annoy each other when they're bored. Glimmer responds to her flirting and then tries to pretend she didn't, but she's fun to rile up and it's a lot low stakes. Catra doesn't really care whether Glimmer flirts back or not, and she is pretty sure half the time Glimmer reciprocates because she's trying to make Bow pay attention, but Catra is always keeping an eye on Adora's reaction, so she can't really complain about that.

Right now, Glimmer's making a similar face to the ones she sent Catra back during workshop, only today she's looking across the stage at where Sea Hawk and Bow are warming up for their on-stage antics by playing fucking leapfrog with each other and discussing what underwear they're going to coordinate for tonight.

"I think I'm feeling the red pair," Sea Hawk declares, because he can't say anything in a normal tone of voice, not even his micro brief choices. He and Bow have to match because there's a joke about it in the show, but it's still a conversation Catra would rather not hear. She doesn't particularly like them wandering around backstage in only their underwear after they get killed and stuck with that as their ghost outfit in act one, but at least Bow and Sea Hawk have this general goofy and sweet energy that makes the nudity easier to forget about.

"The one with the white trim? I think I have that in my bag," Bow clarifies, grunting in the middle as he vaults over Sea Hawk's back. Catra is about ready to put her head in her hands. *She* warms up with pilates, not whatever this homoerotic ritual taking place on center stage is. Netossa can't come fast enough to kick off the vocal warm-ups.

Glimmer turns to Catra and her smile has a bit of a manic edge to it. She throws an arm over Catra's shoulders that causes her to let out an *oof* because Glimmer is shorter than her and practically dragging her down to the floor.

“You need to warm up for the fight, right? Want help?” Glimmer says. Catra almost laughs. She can already picture Glimmer “helping” her get into her pilates positions by putting her hands in all sorts of places they don’t need to be. It would be fun to fuck with Adora – her expression looks a little stony in the corner of her eye – but Catra hasn’t forgotten how much Glimmer’s casual elbowing feels like a punch, not to mention *this* where even Glimmer hanging off her shoulders hurts.

“It’s better if I do it by myself so I have practice holding the same pose still,” Catra tells her. She needs to fight in slow motion in addition to standing “paused” as Veronica’s inner monologue lusts after her, and that is way harder to make look good than just stage fighting at regular speed, even if it’s safer. Her stretching routine is carefully selected so she can make it look clean. Catra catches Adora looking away in the corner of her eye. She turns her head to throw Glimmer a smirk.

“If you’re that desperate to get your hands on me, though, we could try *Dead Girl Walking*,” she teases, going all-in. Glimmer’s cheeks turn dark and she quickly drops her arm from Catra’s shoulders, letting Catra finally straighten up to see Adora’s head has whipped around to face them, her eyes boring into the back of Glimmer’s head. Clearly Glimmer wasn’t expecting to be called out so directly from her blush.

“You should probably be doing that with Starla,” Glimmer deflects from her own obvious reaction, her eyes trailing over to Adora’s understudy on the other side of the stage, standing a little too close to Sea Hawk and Bow’s antics. Unlike them, though, she’s actually paying attention and she looks up at the sound of her name, flashing them both a smile. Starla and Lonnie take over for them two nights a month, and sometimes they also sub in on random days when they need more time off, but usually she and Adora are off at the same time because Netossa says it’s a waste of their chemistry for them to have staggered days off. Catra has only done a real show with Starla once outside of practice. She thinks she proved she’s a good actress even when she’s not frustratingly hung up on her love interest, but she’d rather get to be all over Adora any night of the week.

Catra’s eyes drift over to where Adora is pretending she isn’t watching the whole thing. Slowly, Catra smiles and looks back over to Starla.

“It *has* been a while since we practiced together. Hey, Starla! Want to do *Dead Girl Walking* and *Our Love Is God*? It’ll give Bow and Sea Hawk a bit of a warm-up too,” Catra offers. If anything, it will get Sea Hawk and Bow to stop what they *are* doing, and it will be a casual run through since none of them are in costume yet – though Catra isn’t sure that will necessarily stop Sea Hawk from stripping anyway. Starla smiles back brightly.

“Sure!” she agrees. She’s on stage every night either way since she’s in the ensemble, but Catra has played that kind of role and it’s nothing like getting to be center stage. Even if the audience is just their castmates, it’s a nice experience, and if Adora is watching from the sidelines with a burning gaze, well, maybe it makes it a little easier for Catra’s JD persona to rise in her chest.

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It's kind of rare for Catra to be noticeably worked up certain nights now they've hit their stride because she's *always* intense, but when she decides to introduce tongue to the *Dead Girl Walking* kiss is a dead giveaway. They haven't stopped with the real kisses during the show since they started. Their priority is always the choreography and moving on to the next beat in time, but anyone who sees the show will say they are the most passionate lovers they have ever seen on stage.

Off-stage, that's usually not true, but when Adora sits down to take a drink during *Kindergarten Boyfriend* tonight, Catra appears over the top of the counter. It's the first time she has approached her during a show runtime since they went home together and she has a smirk on her face Adora is smart enough to dread.

"What did you do?" Adora asks in a low voice, glancing around to see if anyone is paying attention to them. They aren't. Catra's shit eating grin only grows wider as she scoots closer to the edge of the counter and leans over to purr in Adora's ear, breath hot on her neck as she speaks.

"I brought something from home," Catra says in the kind of voice you could develop a fetish for. Adora immediately feels her body temperature rise a few degrees.

"And what was that?" Adora asks, not meaning to drop her own voice lower, but that's what it instinctually does in response. Catra gives a small, smug *hmph* that Adora wouldn't even catch if not for the rush of air breathed across her skin.

"Free after the show? I believe you said your place this time," Catra asks. Oh. Adora feels a shiver of anticipation. Probably best she doesn't ask more questions while they're mic'd.

"Yeah, I'm free," she agrees, voice throaty. She immediately takes a drink of water trying to shake it off. Catra's eyes are sparkling as she pulls back.

"Excellent," she says, straightening up and preparing to hop off the counter. Adora quickly reaches out, grabbing her wrist. Catra pauses, her tail flicking as she sends Adora a look both curious and wary.

"Stay this time?" Adora asks, voice quiet to not be overheard. Catra's tail flicks and she scoffs, hopping off the counter and tugging her hand out of Adora's grasp without answering the question. Adora watches her back retreat pretty sure she knows the answer.

Well, at least that disappointment will keep her from going into the next scene glowing.

--

Catra was supposed to get in, fulfill the fantasies that have been floating in her mind since the first time they performed *Dead Girl Walking*, and get out.

She packed a change of clothes, though. She was done for as soon as Adora realized that. Adora makes some kind of argument about Catra just increasing her stress by leaving before soaking in the afterglow and then does her best to make sure neither of them can walk straight anyway until Catra ends up melted into the bed beside her, blinking as she watches Adora gently brush strands of hair out of her face. It tickles a little as she sweeps them away from her eyes and that's the only reason Catra is blinking so much. The purr filling the room is also obviously just endorphins.

The soft look on Adora's face is also clearly just her being dumb. She finishes arranging Catra hair for her and moves to scratch at the base of her ear. Catra lets her eyes fall closed, purr rumbling through the room. It feels so nice. When they lived together, Adora used to stop by her bed sometimes and do this for her before climbing into bed for the night herself. Around the time she stopped doing things like that – stopped caring, or having the time, or even being home to do it – was around the time their life together fell apart.

Catra feels her brows pinch together and quickly turns her face into the pillow before Adora can see any distress from the memory. It ruins all Adora's work making sure they could stare into each other's eyes uninterrupted, but that was too soft for them anyway. Catra is trying to keep things distant enough to avoid another heartbreak that could ruin the show, but she's aware the end of Heathers is a ticking clock as much as a countdown.

She holds herself back until the show is over, and then what next? They manage to talk once a month on a day off? Catra isn't ready to lose seeing Adora every day, even the days when they don't talk for it out of costume. They already struggled when they were supposed to be best friends and roommates. She doesn't know what she can give Adora now that would make her want to come back when the show ends. Adora said something about getting her feet under her when they talked back during workshop, but Catra hasn't seen much sign of her learning to have a life outside of her current show.

"Hey," Adora's voice is gentle and prompting as she pets over the back of Catra's hair. Catra grunts into the pillow. Adora's hand trails down so she can scratch at the base of Catra's neck, which at least unwinds some of the tension starting to gather in her back again.

"Did you like the barbeque place?" Adora asks, startling a questioning trill out of Catra. When she peeks out of the pillow at Adora, her smile is soft and her eyes are dazzling. Catra is so gay it's bad for her health. What the fuck. "I go there a lot with Glimmer and Bow after a show," Adora adds. Catra lifts her head and flops it against the pillow so she's laying on her side again, one ear trapped beneath her cheek as she takes in Adora's face. She just looks sincere, which is annoying.

"Don't you see enough of them at work?" Catra deflects. She doesn't really know what Adora's post-show routine is anymore. Adora shrugs.

"I mean, yeah, right now, but we aren't always working together. When Bow was in a different show, we ended up setting a weekly hang out and that was our favorite spot. We couldn't always make it, but we did most weeks, and we still do it sometimes," Adora explains, trailing her hand over to pet Catra's shoulder instead now. Catra's ears twitch as she considers that. That's clearly something Adora instated after they lost their friendship,

probably to avoid a repeat. Once a week. Could she be okay with that, being friends again and seeing Adora once a week?

No, she couldn't. They'd stop being friends really quick. Getting so little of Adora, she'd feel like she was drowning any time Adora looked at Glimmer instead of her. She doesn't want to lose Adora's hand softly petting her shoulder like this, though. Maybe if they were going home together afterwards, she could stomach it, but they probably wouldn't always be in the mood for sex and that just leaves Catra desperate and clingy.

Adora suddenly leans forward and kisses the bridge of her nose, startling Catra.

"Hey! What was that for?" Catra protests as Adora leans back again with a satisfied grin.

"Your thinking face is cute," Adora tells her, smugly, as she drops her head onto the pillow. Catra grumbles as her tail thuds, tucking her blushing cheek into the pillow like that helps her hide when she's still looking up at Adora with one wide eye and wondering what she really wants from her. Catra wants to be the love of her life. She thinks Adora might just want to go karaoking with her. That doubt is what cause them to fall out.

When Adora reaches out and tucks Catra's hair behind her ear again, her touch is soft and reverent. They're both still naked, and Catra is definitely going to fall asleep in Adora's arms tonight. She's going to wake up purring, and Adora is going to pet her as she slowly rouses, and she might even offer for them to share a shower together because she did that once like an idiot in high school and Catra almost died on the spot.

Catra has to bite her tongue to stop herself from blurting out *what are we doing?* If there is any difference in their answers, it spells disaster for the show. She can have this and she can even enjoy it, but she can't know if she gets to keep it until it's already too late.

She's going to fucking enjoy it while she can.

--

It takes Adora a while to realize Catra isn't avoiding her backstage anymore. At first she thinks Catra is just slipping up and continues to give her space in case she drives her further away. Even if it's often to mess with her, she likes the rare occasions when Catra comes up to talk to her mid-show and she doesn't want to discourage her. It's only when she's walking past Catra draped over a speaker during intermission, eyes closed and *uh huh*'ing along as Scorpia gushes about some kind of plans they're making soon, that she realizes Catra isn't even trying to hide anymore.

It's hard to tell what plans Scorpia is trying to arrange because she keeps rapid-firing through ideas, but Catra is just laying there calmly and seems to have accepted any outcome, even Adora finding her. Catra's eyes slit open as Scorpia rambles and Adora feels frozen in her

spot as blue and yellow fix on her. Catra's expression doesn't change at all, just slowly blinking at Adora as Scorpia continues to talk.

Adora doesn't decide to do it, but something – Catra's expression, her relaxation, her finally coming out of whatever corner she was hiding in – has her transfixed and the next thing she knows her feet are carrying her across the room. Catra's eyes open all the way from slits as Adora approaches, but aside from twitching her ear up to listen to her and a thump of her tail on the speaker, she doesn't react.

"Oo, I found the best pastry place the other day, but it's on the other side of town! We'd have to reroute- Oh, hey, Adora," Scorpia greets as Adora walks up beside her.

"Hey," Adora greets casually, like her hand isn't lifting to ruffle Catra's hair. Catra lets out a startled *prrbt* as Adora scratches at the base of her neck. Scorpia lets out a surprising *squee* beside her as Catra flushes and either tries to hide her face in the speaker or rubs her cheek against the black plastic.

"Aw, I wish I could do that," Scorpia muses sadly, looking down at her pincers. Catra growls at them both but she doesn't get up and Adora swears she leans into it when she threads her fingers through her hair and scratches at her scalp. Adora might be having an out of body experience. She can't believe Catra is letting this happen, and during *intermission* too. They're going back on stage in three minutes.

"Catra! I've got your shots," Entrapta appears out of nowhere to declare, startling Adora and causing her to drop her hand from Catra. Catra sits up slowly, scratching at the ear she was just lying on and holding out her hand for one of the solo cups from the Big Fun scene that Entrapta is carrying. Normally they're empty. Right now they're filled with bright blue liquid.

"Oh, hi, Adora. Do you need sugar too? I can go get another," Entrapta offers, holding out the empty stack of cups she is carrying to indicate she could fill it. Adora blinks down at them and then looks up to Catra for confirmation. Catra blinks at her slowly over her cup, a smirk pulling at her lips.

"Come on, do shots with me, Adora. I promise Entrapta makes her poison delicious," Catra teases. Adora looks down at her cup of fake drain cleaner that she doesn't know the recipe of, just that it's really sweet and apparently full of enough sugar to pick up a tired JD mid-show. She knows Entrapta and Catra down these things like shooters when they want to.

Adora takes an empty cup from Entrapta and flashes her a smile.

"Oo! Wait, Scorpia, do you want one too? We can all do them!" Entrapta offers as she hands it off. Scorpia perks up from her sad contemplation of her lack of hands and eagerly nods.

--

Catra is curled up in Adora's *Kindergarten Boyfriend* chair as she waits for the show to start, scrolling through Instagram on her phone and reading comments. Not her comments, though: Glimmer's. She passed by them yesterday during intermission while Entrapta was bringing over more cups and the jug of drain cleaner. Glimmer doesn't do anything by half measures, so she jumped in and then flagged Sea Hawk down to film it, who also wanted to join, and then half the cast was quickly downing "shots" with a very real sense of urgency so they could get on stage on time for act two. They were all laughing and the video really conveys how much they all got swept up and then realized they were running late and scrambled. Glimmer edited lights over it at just the right times to make backstage look like a fake club.

It looks like they're all friends. They kind of are. Catra has been dodgy backstage, but she has still been bonding against her will with Adora's friends thanks largely to moments like this.

About three seconds of the video are dedicated to a shuffle of cups between Catra and Adora. It starts with Catra giving Scorpia her shot and helping her drink it after Scorpia poked a hole in the side of her cup with one of her spikes. Catra then turned to Adora and downed her drink instead as Glimmer laughed, and then when Entrapta dumped more drain cleaner into Adora's cup, Catra started to drink it *again*, so Adora took it out of her hand and made aggressive eye contact as she chugged it.

The comment Catra's eyes are currently fixed on is *do you think Catra's like that with their bedsheets too*.

The internet already thought they were either fucking or hated each other. After the kiss during final bow, apparently they're dating. The internet was half-right before. They aren't now. Obviously.

She doesn't know if Adora knows yet. She clearly doesn't keep up with comments like Catra does since she didn't know about the initial rumors. They don't want those to start again, so coming out and clarifying that the kiss was… Well, Catra can't clarify something she doesn't know the answer to herself, so online, they're dating apparently.

"Catra?" Adora sounds surprised. Catra keeps her eyes fixed on her phone for a long moment so her slow blink isn't too suspicious before she looks up to meet Adora's gaze. Adora looks surprised to find her here despite how Catra hasn't avoided her backstage in a week. Wordlessly, Catra turns her phone around to show Adora her phone. Adora looks confused, but she bends down and covers Catra's hand with her own so she can turn the screen up to a better angle. Catra blushes and tries to control her tail, but Adora's fingers feel so gentle over hers and she's already embarrassed about what she's showing her.

Adora's eyes dart up to make eye contact with Catra briefly before she looks back at the phone. Her tongue darts out to wet her lips and she slowly releases Catra's hand, straightening up.

"Is that a… problem?" Adora asks, cautiously. Catra snorts, taking back her phone and eyeing the comment one last time before closing the app.

"No," she decides, sliding the phone into her inner trench coat pocket. She looks up at Adora, waiting for a reaction to that. Adora bounces a little on her toes and glances around backstage

to see who's listening in. The answer is no one. Catra came down early, because Adora usually comes down early, and she wanted to do this in an isolated but semi-public space to limit conversation options.

"Cool," Adora decides, looking back to her and suddenly ducking down. Catra squeaks, surprised, as Adora hooks a finger under her chin and tilts her face up so she can press a quick kiss to her lips, even briefer than any of the ones they'll exchange in the show.

Except this one leaves her breathless because it's not in any script. When Adora straightens up, she beams at her. She opens her mouth, about to say something, but then Sea Hawk starts singing as he descends the stairs and Adora looks over, aware they're about to be interrupted. She looks back to flash Catra another smile and then she walks away, slowly starting to jog to meet Mermista and Sea Hawk at the bottom of the stairs, greeting them brightly.

Part of Catra's soul has already unfurled from the chair to follow after her. Catra can see herself going to wrap around Adora's arm and hanging off of her as Adora talks with her friends. She's a little too breathless to speak right now, though, so she's just going to leave that as a vision of dubious validity.

Now she has the same question the internet does, and it's stupid, because she also knows the answer is no.

Chapter End Notes

I'm posting like crazy partially because I got a little ahead in writing (I wanted to write this, not edit, so I wasn't keeping up with posting lol) but allllso because I'm trying to get this whole fic out before the 12th when the SPOP Big Bang starts since I'm going to be posting daily for that as well. No idea what I'm doing afterwards 👍

# Beautiful

Chapter Notes

What if Twister, but gayer

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Vocal warmups are done, but half the cast is doing stretches together even though most people have pretty light choreography. Adora should be joining them, but it's the last show of the week and she's really ready for her day off tomorrow. No matter how much you love your job, some days you're just tired. She's trying to conserve energy by sitting near the back of the stage and she's zoning out a little. She doesn't notice Catra getting up from her own spot and it startles her when Catra suddenly steps in front of her and drops down into her lap, straddling her legs and settling in like she belongs there.

"Hello?" Adora blurts out, luckily, instead of something worse and far too revealing – to Catra, or to the rest of their castmates still on the stage. They could not be in a more compromising position, in broad daylight, *at work*, if they tried. Adora half expects Catra to lean forward and ask her is she wants to practice *Dead Girl Walking* in a purr, but instead Catra lifts her hand and pokes her face high up on her cheekbone with a single claw.

"Let's play First Contact," Catra says, plainly, like she used to say it in high school. Adora pauses, blinking at her. It has been years since she even thought of that game. If Catra is that bored with warmups, she should leave. It feels like they're being rude to their castmates by ignoring them - and yet Adora lifts her thumb and puts it on Catra's clavicle anyway. Catra's eyes light up. Within a minute, she's pivoting so she can stretch her finger and place her pinky on Adora's cupid's bow. Adora giggles as she pivots to put her thumb on Catra's face near her mouth, poking particularly hard to make it clear she's not going for her cheek but rather the bone lying beneath.

The rules of First Contact are simple: you get one hand, and every time your partner touches you, then you have to touch a part of their body that starts with the same letter as whatever they're touching starts with. Common and scientific names are on the table. They invented the game in middle school when they were sucking so horribly at biology they needed practice learning anatomy names, but they'd be too bad at it to get anywhere if they didn't include common names. Things like the drift between *cupid's bow* and *achimenes longiflora* is what makes it possible to hop between letters and keep the thing going.

Now they move faster, pivoting to always follow the rule of having a point of contact fixed on the previous body part as they work over each other's bodies. Adora's hand eventually gets close enough to Catra's ear for her to break all the rules to lift her hand from Catra completely and pull on it. Catra squeaks, her tail fluffing up as she poorly swallows the growling purr that starts rising in her chest on instinct. Adora grins at her as Catra shoves

hard at her chest, almost enough to get her to fall back, and then surges forward to hiss in her ear.

“You’re going to regret that,” Catra growls.

She really, really doesn’t.

--

Catra really likes waking up in Adora’s bed.

It’s a problem. It’s a problem how perfectly warm Adora is to curl around, how she always lets Catra sprawl across her and how willing she is to be the big spoon, how she always drops kisses on whatever part of Catra is closest when she’s half asleep. It’s a problem how she runs her hands through her hair in the morning, scratching in all the right spots to pull a purr our of Catra chest. It’s a problem how unshy she is with her touches when they’re in the shower together, and how she doesn’t push at *all* by asking about them, the furthest she gets just trying to get Catra to commit to other hangout times that probably involve their clothes being on.

It’s a problem when she looks a little sad and wistful as Catra leaves. It’s a problem, so Catra avoids all that by sneaking out as soon as she wakes up, something she hasn’t attempted since the very first time. She hates walking through the city during the morning, and she especially hates changing trains at Grand Central with all the losers in their business suits and backpacks around, but she slogs through it because she’s having one of those crises that Adora’s touch has a fifty percent chance of triggering where she remembers she has no fucking clue how Adora feels about her or what’s going to happen when they’re no longer singing love songs at each other every night.

Her phone rings when she’s emerging from the subway two blocks from her place and she sighs, expecting a message from Adora, but instead she pauses in her tracks at Double Trouble appearing winking on her screen, decked out in too much jewelry from a glamor shoot. Her agent is usually too busy modeling or jet-setting or tricking widows into falling in love with them to make social calls, but she has a few months left on her contract and she doesn’t think Netossa is ready to start arranging her second cast iteration.

This probably isn’t a call she wants to take in the middle of her walk home, but she’s damn sure she doesn’t want to miss it either.

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Adora is almost always the second person to reach the theater. Starla comes straight over from her morning job half the days, so she usually arrives early, but Adora just likes to be at the theater way ahead of time. It's nice to be there when it's a little quieter. She always stresses about running late if she's not ahead of time and if her other castmates get in early too, they can hang out before the show.

Catra is rarely ever early, and even rarer wanting to hang out, but someone knocks on Adora's door and then enters without waiting for an answer, and there's only one person who does that. Adora looks up, surprised, to see Catra wandering in looking uncomfortable, hands shoved in her pockets and a blush on her cheeks as she looks in the general direction of *down*.

"Hey, what's up?" Adora asks, voice soft, as she straightens to abandon digging through her bag for another hair tie. Catra cuts through them half the time and Netossa bought her a pack of a hundred, but they've gone through a lot of shows and they get lost sometimes even without Catra's intervention. Catra surprises her by shrugging vaguely and wandering over to her vanity, moving a few things aside before she hops up on the corner.

"Have I gotten through all your hair ties yet?" Catra asks, throwing her a slanted smile, casual as if this is a normal occurrence. Catra might be friendly backstage now – well, her idea of friendly, anyway – but she still doesn't usually come to Adora's dressing room unless it's to make out. She *just* bolted to avoid conversation before Adora could wake up.

"I'll buy more," Adora tells her, rolling her eyes. She doesn't know what Catra's war on her ponytail is. She used to tell her she should wear it less because she was going to damage her hair and go bald, but she only occasionally snatched or broke her hair tie to be annoying. This vendetta seems to be new and all Adora can figure is that Catra wants it down because she likes running her hand through her hair and pulling on it. Catra lets out an *aw* that's a little condescending and makes Adora huff, her face feeling hot. She should probably put her makeup on. There's no reason for her not to and it will make it a little harder for Catra to tease her if she blushes.

Catra doesn't move as Adora starts rearranging her vanity, making Adora work around her, and she doesn't stop teasing her either, but Adora smiles the whole way through her routine. When she was in high school, this was the kind of thing she pictured for them, getting ready for a show together and laughing. It feels casual and easy in a way things usually only are between them when they're in a public setting where there's social etiquette keeping them from being too honest.

Maybe they've finally reached the point where they honestly aren't fighting anymore. Adora wants to reach out and take Catra's hand, but she stops herself like she has many times before because Catra is finally coming to her and she doesn't want to drive her off when she's clearly still cagey enough to flee. She isn't shy right now, though, reaching out and dragging her fingertips down Adora's arm when she reaches forward to put her makeup brush back down on the vanity beside her. Adora's breath stutters and Catra laughs at her.

Adora is blushing again, but it's under a layer of foundation now at least. Catra's eyes are sparkling as she watches Adora, so she doesn't know how well that strategy is working.

Catra's gaze drops down to Adora's shoulder. She lifts her hand and traces over her shoulder, tugging on her sleeve in a way that makes Adora think she wants to take it off.

Catra's gaze lifts to meet hers again.

"Give me a good show tonight," she says in a low voice. Adora feels her blood thrum.

"Yeah? And what do I get if I do?" Adora asks, lifting her hand to place it on Catra's thigh, squeezing. Catra's tail twitches, but she doesn't give a reaction Adora expects. Catra opens her mouth, but barely any sound comes out. Slowly, Adora's brow furrows as Catra is rendered speechless. Finally, Catra looks away, her tail thudding with embarrassment. Cautiously, Adora removes her hand from Catra's leg in case that was what pushed her too far. Catra eventually sighs.

"I'm thinking of changing my schedule," she admits. Adora doesn't know what that means, but Catra's ears slowly pin back as Adora doesn't speak.

"Your schedule?" Adora finally asks. Catra huffs, looking back over at Adora, but her gaze still won't lift higher than Adora's shoulder.

"To take two or three days off a week," Catra slowly elaborates. Oh. Adora's heart is pounding now in a bad way.

"Why?" Adora asks. Did she do something wrong? She held herself back so much trying to avoid this, to make sure they were okay for the show and Catra didn't shy away. Was something she did too much when they went home together? Everything seemed *normal*, falling into what has now become routine.

Maybe that was the problem. Catra gives a nervous smile and finally looks up to meet her eyes.

"It might not go anywhere in the long run, but if it does… I got another offer I couldn't turn down."

Oh. It wasn't her, but she doesn't feel much better. Catra is still leaving the show. Adora *has* to give her the show she asked for now. She's definitely going to cry during *Seventeen*. Her throat works for a minute. Eventually, she manages to give Catra an unsure smile.

"I don't think I'm as excited to do the show if you aren't going to be there," she admits, quietly. This might be too much. Catra might have fled after their night together specifically because she wasn't ready to talk to her about this. Catra's ears twitch and she stares at Adora for a long minute.

Then in one quick motion she hops off the vanity and into Adora's lap, kissing her soundly.

--

It turns out to just be one and a half shows of difference. She already doesn't work one day most weeks, so they give Lonnie a single night and the first show for double day. That's all it takes for Catra to have the time to get from her new day-job to the theater in time for the second show of the night. It's going to be hard and she's probably going to be exhausted by the end of the month, but she can't let either of these opportunities go.

"I hope it goes somewhere for you, but I'd love to keep you for the full first run," Netossa tells her as they look over the new schedule. Netossa is clearly surprised that Catra is edging off her commitment to the show. Catra isn't interrogating whether that's just because it's logically a great role to be in or because she's so intense when she's on the stage with Adora. Catra certainly never thought she would be decreasing her hours early when she finally got to play such a large role.

"You're not getting rid of me that easily. I'm definitely staying, and I'd probably take a return offer too. It's just a month of workshop," Catra explains with a shrug. Getting invited to a new musical's workshop doesn't guarantee a role – and especially not the same role – in the show if it even *does* make it to Broadway. They said they wanted her range while they figure out where to take their lead, so they might not want her anymore once they don't need that flexibility, but she can't turn down the opportunity to build a lead role, and maybe they'll think of her if it does come time to cast.

"I'll be honest, if either you or Adora isn't available for the cast change, I'll probably bring in a new couple to fresh things up. I love you both, but I don't want to make false promises," Netossa informs her matter-of-factly. Catra feels her face heat at *couple*. Netossa is referring to Veronica and JD, obviously. It's pretty normal to change up casting when contracts are up to give the show new life for those who have already seen it, so there was never a guarantee they were going to keep the roles – or that the show would even keep running – but given how thrilled Netossa has been with their performance, Catra thought there was a good chance.

And, well, there is, as long as they move in the same direction. She hates that she'll probably have to talk to Adora about that, but maybe she won't – maybe she'll be moving in her own direction. *Shot in the Dark* could turn out to be a musical flop and she could even hate it when she goes in for workshop, but this isn't an opportunity she has ever had before and she can't turn it down, especially since it only affects two of her eight shows a week.

Netossa notices her blushing and sends her a smirk Catra has learned means she needs to brace for impact.

"You should probably go clean up before the show, though. It's a bit early for you to have Veronica's lipstick on you," Netossa says. Catra feels like she might die on the spot.

"It's Glimmer's, actually," Catra says as a kneejerk reaction, as if that's better. It's less vulnerable for sure, considering it's bullshit.

"Uh huh. She wears red," Netossa points out. Okay, well how was *Catra* supposed to know that? Catra turns on her heel.

“I need to go change,” Catra says hurriedly despite how they haven’t even done warmups yet. Netossa chuckles behind her as Catra vacates the room.

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The musical is kicking up its marketing push again after coasting on the initial materials and fan hype, trying to promote Lonnie’s increased presence along the way to make people curious about her JD. They’re taking a lot of videos and photos backstage and in practice, ranging from genuine videos of them preforming to the cast giving interviews or just playing around together. Every time a camera comes out, they’re basically encouraged to goof off, which is how the set-climbing competition starts, but as Adora is doing chin-ups on the crossbar above JD’s window that gives it support, she can’t help but think about how easily Catra would have climbed into the rafters if she was here.

Adora knows she still sees her most nights, but on one of those days it’s *barely* and Catra is usually tired when she comes from workshop. Even when she is here for something like this, she usually sits back and watches to save her energy for the show itself. She refuses to let the quality of her performance decline, so she has to be smart about what she does. Adora she misses her antics at warmups, even when she would pester Glimmer and ignore Adora until she was near her breaking point.

The rest of the cast are her friends, and it really is a dream musical, but it’s not the same when Catra isn’t there. She didn’t need a sign to know she needed Catra in her life, though. She just has to figure out how to keep her this time.

Chapter End Notes

I’ma just update daily at this point tbh

# Meant To Be Yours

Chapter Notes

> Thank you to the commentor who (ages ago) brought up annapantsu's female cover of Meant To Be Yours. I'm Making it relevant.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Originating a role can be a complicated concept. On the surface, it doesn't seem like it – you're either the first person to play a character in a new musical or you're not – but then there's special cases like rewrites. Catra isn't egotistical enough to think how she plays JD means she originated the female version of the role, mostly because she doesn't want so many asterisks attached to that statement when she does make it, but she's pretty sure her mom will be arguing it at her holiday party. Catra is going to be on the Broadway cast album when it's made and getting on one of those albums was a goal for her career, but her best chance to mark off her biggest bucket list item is participating in a workshop like this.

*Shot in the Dark* is exhausting. As dismissive as Catra was ofvAdora's effort early on, Veronica is a really tough role, almost never off-stage and constantly singing. *Shot in the Dark* is similar for its lead, and the writers are constantly changing keys, lyrics, story, and placeholder choreography. It's hard to keep it all straight in her head, but she really likes the team, she really likes playing a heroic lead, and she's ready to work for her damn dream, even if it means showing up with two shows worth of exhaustion already under her belt on the three days when workshop overlaps with Heathers.

She naps a lot when she can catch a minute so she can still bring the energy she needs on stage, and she can't believe she's thinking this, but she's starting to miss her co-stars. It isn't even just Adora. She misses riling Glimmer up, and Mermista's dry one-liners, and Scorpia's bubbly friendship. She suddenly wishes she spent more time with them backstage even though poison shot parties are a rare occurrence anyway and most people are trying to take care of their body's needs between songs.

She makes an effort to spend more time with the cast in communal areas when she can, which doubles as letting her get more Adora time without being obvious since Adora is *always* spending time with her castmates, but sometimes that exhaustion asserts itself. She comes down early for warm-ups one night to socialize but finds, for the first time in her life, she's the first one there. She needs rest, so she curls up and closes her eyes to wait for the others.

It's just supposed to be temporary, but then she's woken by a hand in her hair and voices rising in the air. She opens her eyes, finding Adora standing next to the speaker she's curled up on, hand petting through her hair, as the cast works through their first set of scales. Catra suddenly feels very embarrassed and quickly sits up, but that accidentally dislodges the

blanket *someone* put on her. She doesn't know who did it because she has never seen it before, which means it definitely wasn't Adora.

Adora glances down at her and flashes her a smile, bending down to the floor and producing a water bottle that she holds out to Catra. Catra snatches it quickly, face hot.

It takes her a minute to wake up and feel like she's not going to do damage if she opens her mouth, but then she joins the cast for the rest of the vocal warm-up. When it's time for the physical part, she settles for mostly stretching, two pilates poses, and then returns to the speaker Adora is still leaning against, waiting for her with the blanket thrown over her arm. Whoever it belongs to either doesn't want it back urgently or doesn't want Catra to know they gave it to her by collecting it, which does narrow down the suspects at least. Catra snatches it from Adora's hands with a blush rising in her cheeks again, ignoring Adora's chuckle.

She follows Adora up the stairs and into her dressing room, though, clearly surprising her. Adora doesn't comment, just smiling softly as Catra bypasses her to curl up in the small window Adora has, tucking the blanket around herself again. This is a much better place to rest.

"Don't let me fall asleep all the way. I just need a little rest," Catra mumbles, looking out the window instead of at the gentleness radiating from Adora's face.

"Okay," Adora agrees. God, she sounds *smitten*. Disgusting.

Catra's heart is bursting for totally unrelated reasons she'll diagnose later when she's more rested.

--

A knock with no hesitation only means one thing and Adora looks up from the middle of her post-show routine to see Catra slinking inside, already changed with her bag hanging loosely from her fingers. She pauses as the door swings shut behind her, blinking slowly at Adora.

"Taking off your makeup?" Catra asks. Oh, she's *tired*. She seemed okay earlier, no naps needed today that Adora saw when Catra came in for the second show of the night, but apparently that used the last of her energy supply.

"Yeah. I'll be done in a minute," Adora assures. Catra blinks at her again, even slower.

"Okay." She walks over next to the vanity and plops down onto the floor, leaning against the side of the table and closing her eyes as she waits. Adora hurries with taking off her makeup and changing clothes, only further convinced Catra is totally exhausted when she doesn't open her eyes to leer at her or make any jokes as she undresses. When Adora has everything

together, she picks up her bag and walks over to where Catra might be asleep, petting her hair and ruffling her ears.

“Kitten,” Adora prompts, voice soft, and earns a surprised *prbbt* from Catra as she opens her eyes and blinks up at Adora.

“How about a taxi?” Adora proposes. She’s pretty sure Catra came over here to go home together, although there’s no way they’re having sex with Catra like this and she hasn’t gotten Catra to set foot in her apartment without the promise of that thus far. Adora isn’t confident that Catra is safe to make her way through the subway on her own and she seems to know that.

“That would be slower than the subway right now,” Catra mumbles, reaching up to rub at her eye and then reluctantly standing. Adora slips an arm around her waist that has the bonus of helping her stay steady.

“Yeah, but it’ll be easier,” Adora points out. She *could* corral Catra through the line changes, but she’s not sure Catra could even more fast enough to make it without having to wait on the platform for the next train.

“And more expensive,” Catra protests as Adora steers them to the door and shuts off the light behind them.

“The subway costs money to the rest of us, too,” Adora points out, reaching up to scratch at the base of Catra’s ear to get her to relax enough not to protest more. It works. Catra has nothing more to say when Adora wraps her arm around her waist again. “Come on, we’ll go through stage door quick,” Adora promises. Catra grumbles vaguely but she tucks into Adora’s side and pretends not to see Perfuma’s knowing look when they pass her in the hallway.

--

Adora does what she can to hop in for her during stage door, and she gives them an excuse to pull away early when a taxi lets someone out down the block and they have to bolt to catch it before it leaves. She lets Catra slump into her lap in the backseat as she gives the driver directions and when they get home, she pulls a blanket out from under the couch and lets Catra curl up there “watching” TV as she cooks dinner. Catra is pretty sure Adora is only one step away from offering to feed her, which would be entirely too much, but everything else is just *nice*, especially crawling into bed with Adora at the end of the night and snuggling into her side, already purring.

“Can we have sex in the morning?” Catra mumbles as they get comfortable. They haven’t even *kissed* yet unless you count Adora kissing the top of her head as she was waiting for dinner to cook. This is all exactly what she wanted, which is to say an unattainable fantasy

that could just be playing out because Adora is worried for her. She would have been fine to go home. She still didn't want to.

"Yeah, if you want then. Wake me up," Adora promises with a chuckle, turning her head to press a kiss to her ear. Catra is kneading the mattress now.

"I'll do it," she threatens. Adora is playing with fire joking about that. Adora ducks to kiss the base of her ear this time, but she doesn't pull away.

"Counting on it," Adora breathes into her ear. Catra shivers. If she wasn't so tired, she'd be pulling Adora's clothes off right now.

In the morning. Sometimes it's hard for her to believe Adora will still be there when she turns around, but this is her house, after all. That's why Catra always wants to be the one to come here and the one with the option of leaving.

That and she does *not* need Entrapta telling the rest of the cast how Adora makes her scream.

--

Maybe Adora is pushing too far, but maybe if she doesn't take action Catra is going to take that to mean she doesn't care and she'll slip through her fingers again. Maybe she just misses her best friend and the changing schedule has her terrified to lose her when their contacts up. Catra has moved on from using ambush techniques, so now Adora is stooping to them instead. She at least waits for an answer when she knocks on Catra's dressing room door.

Despite calling her in, Catra seems surprised by her appearance when she walks in the room. Oh, well, her gaze is fixed on Adora's hands. Adora takes a deep breath and smacks the calendar down in the middle of Catra's vanity, where she's in a losing fight with her mussed hair, her pixie cut capable of a bedhead Adora will never get in her own hair. Adora saw her arrive in a cab from her dressing room window. She definitely napped on the way over. Adora takes the brush out of her hand so she isn't distracted.

"What's this?" Catra asks, sounding amused, as she looks down at the calendar. Her ears twitch and a shiver passes through her as Adora takes up post behind her and starts working on gently untangling her hair while they talk.

"I made a schedule of when we could see each other," Adora explains, carefully gripping the base of Catra's locks in one hand so she doesn't pull on her scalp as she brushes out the knots. She glances up at the mirror to see Catra staring at her. Catra blinks, once, but it's more surprised than slow. Adora suddenly feels self-conscious. She points down at the calendar with the brush.

"The show and your workshop are on there and I've tried to account for when you're too tired for anything and times for errands and stuff too. And if you look at next month there's a

lot more room once your workshop is over. I have it filled out all the way until our contracts run out and we can… adjust based on our future plans," Adora says, glancing up at Catra's face in the mirror between brush strokes and trying to gauge her reaction. Catra's tail thuds against the side of the chair and her ears twitch a lot, but instead of saying anything she looks down and starts browsing the calendar.

Adora lets out a breath she didn't know she was holding and returns to getting Catra's hair in order. The knots are gone and it just needs a little more taming. It gives Catra time to review Adora's proposed plan. She figures it's better to make it clear she wants to stay friends and show a plan for how they could do that than it is to just keep quiet and hope. Catra can rip up the NYC landmarks calendar she bought just for this if she's out of line, but Adora *hopes* she'll agree.

Losing two shows together is losing a lot of time, it turns out, and she knows she can't go through losing Catra completely again. She doesn't think she *will*, but it felt easier when they lived together and at least saw each other every day, and that turned out to just be lulling her into false complacency. Catra needed more than sharing a kitchen, dedicating time together that was set aside and not cancelled last minute, so Adora will find somewhere in their schedules to crowbar it in. This month is really hard, especially knowing how much rest Catra clearly needs, but the last leg of the show will be easier.

After that… Well, after that they could still be in the same dressing rooms every night or on the opposite sides of town. They just won't know for a while yet.

Catra leans back from the calendar, apparently done consulting it, and leans into her brush, closing her eyes. Her hair doesn't need more brushing, but Adora is happy to continue as Catra sinks into it.

"It's gonna be really hard to keep up with this for the next two weeks," Catra mumbles, flicking one ear down so Adora can brush by its base. Adora pauses, running one hand through her hair before brushing it back down.

"That sounds familiar," Adora comments, restraining herself from saying something pettier. Catra scowls.

"*You* weren't doing two shows then," she points out, cracking an eye to glare up at Adora.

"No, I was just doing eight shows a week for the first time in my life while trying to network and practically learning the role live on-stage," Adora points out. Adora was an emergency cast after one of the main supporting actors broke her arm and they needed to fill her position immediately since her understudy couldn't step up to take center stage every night. Adora will always be grateful for the opportunity, but it was an extremely stressful time. Catra huffs, looking back down and picking up the calendar with more force than necessary, pages crinkling beneath her hand.

Adora struggles with this at the best of times, but she wisely shuts up. She throws in some scritches at the base of Catra's ear as bribes, but though Catra lifts her ear in silent encouragement, she doesn't otherwise acknowledge her, mouth pressed together in a frown.

Adora keeps going as Catra flips the page, stares at it for a long moment, and then flips back to the current month.

“You didn’t factor in the cast album recording, but fine, I’ll do it,” Catra decides, throwing the calendar down onto her vanity carelessly. Adora wants to protest how hard she worked on that, especially when she had to piece together clues at times to determine Catra’s availability, but she’s too busy panicking about that first thing.

“Shit, did we set dates for that?” she whispers, brush freezing mid-stroke. Catra snickers at her.

“Actually read your damn emails. We start the first week I’m out of workshop,” Catra says, going from derisive to weary by the end of her sentence. Adora curses under her breath again and pulls out her phone to check her inbox that she *swore* she cleared.

She did, but she didn’t read all the way to the bottom of Netossa’s last message.

“Okay, I’ll rework-” she trails off when she lifts her gaze, eyes meeting Catra’s in the mirror. Catra looks tired and it’s the first show of her week. She was in workshop today and yesterday, though. Slowly, Adora puts her phone away again.

“Hey, I want to see you, but I don’t want to make you burn out either. I’ve been there, trust me, it sucks. We can just focus on getting through this month and re-evaluate,” Adora promises, hooking her arms over the back of the chair so she can hug Catra from behind. A smile twitches at Catra’s lips and she turns her head to rest her forehead against Adora’s arms, closing her eyes. Adora just holds her for a moment as Catra’s tail curls.

“I can do it,” Catra promises in a low voice. Adora squeezes her arms around her.

“Sure you’re not just saying that because I couldn’t?” Adora asks. Catra smirks, but she doesn’t open her eyes, tail curling back and forth over the edge of the chair.

“It helps,” she jokes, but she softens it with a small nuzzle into Adora’s arm. Adora watches her take a deep breath. “And I want to,” Catra adds in a tiny whisper. The words lift her up, but it also breaks her heart how scared Catra sounds admitting that she cares.

Adora ducks to kiss the top of Catra’s head.

“I do too. I know what it takes now,” she promises. She hopes, anyway.

She’s willing to work for that small purr Catra gives her in response.

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Catra takes naps so she can go a hundred percent on stage, determined not to let the audience see any difference or give a critic another reason to write a negative review beyond her

gender, but she's still usually internally struggling by the end of the show. *Meant To Be Yours* is her last big song. She's meant to be rattled and in pain for *I Am Damaged* and it's a lot easier to work through any exhaustion then. Lately she has been counting the notes on *Meant To Be Yours* until she has her breakdown and leaves Veronica's house. She is going to walk away from this show with Netossa saying she was the most dedicated actor she ever worked with if it kills her.

Tonight it's easier. Tonight she holds the school's petition like she held the calendar up in her dressing room two hours ago. Tonight she feels some demon Adora put in her two *years* ago rise in her chest and breathe out with the chorus. Tonight she sings it with more longing than anger. She feels an actual tear slip out when she cries out upon finding Veronica's staged body. Her breath rattles in her chest as she gathers her strength one last time, because *I can't do this alone* felt true for so long, as did the refrain *still I will if I must*.

But she doesn't. But when final bow comes, Adora wraps an arm around her and ruffles her ears on stage in front of everyone as the rest of the cast laughs, and Catra isn't smiling just for a camera or pretending to be her friend. Now they have a damn schedule for that, apparently. Catra looks up at the beaming smile on Adora's face as she looks out at audience, waving completely oblivious to the way she glows and radiates happiness on the stage.

*All is forgiven, baby*. Maybe JD's right. Maybe it's time that it is.

Chapter End Notes

For the 40% of you who have made it this far without listening to the musical or giving up, "All is forgiven, baby!" is the opening line of Meant To Be Yours, before JD goes on to explain he decided not to kill Veronica for dumping him by instead deciding to blame their entire school for his problems.

# Heathers the Musical: Original Broadway Cast Recording

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora has never been on a cast album before and she is *so excited*. This was pretty much her Broadway dream. She guesses she'll have to set a bigger goal now, maybe originating a role like Catra wants. Maybe she'll just collect cast albums and keep shooting for three, or five, or ten. That would be ridiculous, but maybe it isn't. Maybe her goal should be getting in a cast album for a show that's sapphic from the start rather than rewritten. She can figure it out later.

Being in the recording studio makes her giddy. She's bouncing on her toes and grinning as the sound engineers show them around. They're going to be recording over four days, which sounds like a luxury when they usually do these songs all in one night, but they only have a few hours each day and they'll be doing multiple takes to get it perfect, so maybe it actually won't be enough.

Because most of her songs involve Catra, most of her recording times do, too. The recording booth is much smaller than the stage and she's not used to standing still while singing these songs. Sometimes she finds herself lifting her arm to mimic some action, or reaching out to Catra. When she sings the love songs, she can't look away from Catra. It's a little harder to get in character without the whole performance, but Catra is pretty good at riling her up. These days, it's a lot more fun than frustrated, but Catra still gets cagey sometimes.

"Hey, are you doing anything tomorrow night?" Adora asks as they're leaving the studio at the end of the first day. Catra pauses as she holds the door open for Adora, tilting her head at her. The way her ears flop is adorable, but she looks skeptical.

"I thought we weren't going out until this weekend," is all Catra says, eyes darting back at Netossa and Scorpia still hanging back in the recording studio. Adora isn't sure if what they're doing together is still supposed to be secret. The *group* album celebration isn't until this weekend, sure, but that's not what she's inviting Catra to.

"My moms are super excited about the album. They're coming up to watch the show again and invited us to dinner." They're even *more* excited she and Catra are friends again, but she's definitely not saying that part. Catra's ears twitch and then quickly pin back as her tail lashes behind her. She lets the door go behind them, hurrying forward and heading down the hall, leaving Adora to sigh and catch up. Catra has her hands stuffed in her pockets by the time they've reached the stairs down to the studio's main level.

"Their treat. Can't say no to a free dinner, right?" Adora tries. Catra sends her the same look she gave her the last time Adora pulled that card, but it used to work in high school. Catra huffs, reaching up and running her hands through her hair, ruffling her own ears as she thinks. Adora's fingers twitch to replace Catra's touch with her own, but she lets her think about it. This is a lot.

“I’ll think about it,” Catra says, vaguely. She has about twenty-four hours to think about it, but Adora decides not to push her further. Catra likes Adora’s parents more than she likes her own sometimes. Not seeing them for two years and losing that connection in the fallout of their friendship is probably a touchy subject Adora has been purposefully avoiding.

Catra’s hands drop back to her side with a heavy sigh. Cautiously, Adora lets their hands brush against each other. Catra’s ears twitch. Adora wraps her fingers around Catra’s palm and slowly threads their fingers together. Catra resolutely tries to keep looking forward as her cheeks flush.

“Fine! Fine, I’ll go,” Catra cracks like an egg, stomping her foot a little and growling under her breath like Adora did anything other than hold her hand. Adora grins, which only seems to frustrate her more. Catra groans when she catches her expression, pointing a finger in her face with a claw extended. “They’re not allowed to ask how my moms are doing,” she threatens. Adora quickly nods. She knows they’ve seen the show twice because Felina proudly posted about it online both times, but she doesn’t know when the last time Catra even talked to Leona was. They have a contentious relationship.

“I’ll tell them,” Adora promises. Catra grumbles something under her breath that Adora doesn’t catch, but she starts walking again.

She doesn’t drop Adora’s hand.

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“How did the recording go?” Mara asks brightly as they get seated. They got caught up at stage door and Adora’s parents decided to go ahead and meet them at the restaurant to make sure they didn’t lose their reservations. Catra glances at Adora to see she’s blushing too and they both quickly look away from each other again. For *Dead Girl Walking*, they moved the microphones closer together because Adora has to shush her and it’s just easier to get that energy going up close. Adora tried to kiss her where they usually do in the song only to be quickly corrected from the sound booth that they don’t have to do that, *obviously*. It was absolutely mortifying and Catra isn’t even the one who did it, just the one who didn’t question it when she was pulled in. Adora clears her throat.

“Good,” Adora says brightly, flashing Mara as smile that has her glancing between the two of them in confusion. Catra smothers a snort that turns into a cough. They couldn’t be acting more like they instinctually kissed in a recording booth if they tried.

“We’re all done now and it just needs editing. It’s going to come out in the final month of our run,” Catra says with a shrug. Mara decides to just beam at them and ignore all the weirdness. If only more people did that.

“So have you decided to leave the show, then?” Hope asks from beside her, catching on to Catra’s wording. Catra pauses, tail thumping once beside her. Well, no, she hasn’t. But it

could be the end, and ends usually come for her whether she wants them to or not.

“Um, I’m auditioning again, but I’d be happy to stay. Veronica’s really demanding, but there’s not a lot of places to go that are better than leading your own show *and* getting to be gay about it,” Adora hops in. Catra is grateful for it, reaching out for her glass to take a drink while she thinks. Unfortunately, they only just ordered, so it will be a while before she can use dinner as a distraction. She’s probably going to need it. These are *lowball* questions, but she can sense everyone at the table awaiting her answer – maybe Adora most of all, despite how this should have been something she already knew.

“My agent has me open for auditions again, so I guess I’ll just see if something better comes. It is a pretty great role. If one of us leaves, though, Netossa is going to replace us both, so I’ve got to keep my options open,” Catra eventually says, refusing to commit to anything like she has whenever they got close to this topic before. She can feel Adora’s eyes on her but refuses to look over at her.

“How did the workshop go? Do you think that’s going anywhere?” Hope asks from across the table, ever practical and focused on return investment. Catra’s mom Leona is that way, but Hope cares more about Catra’s own career goals rather than her personal metric of success, so it’s a lot less grating from her.

“Really well, I think. Don’t know how long it will take to make it to Broadway, if it even will, but they’ve been working on it for a while already and seemed to like my performance a lot, so maybe I’ll hear from them again,” Catra says. Adora beams in the corner of her eye, as does Mara, because Adora really took after her mom.

“That’s great! I was going to bring you flowers again to celebrate, but Hope talked me out of it in case you weren’t happy with how the workshop went. We didn’t want to assume it was a good thing since Adora said it was so tiring,” Mara says. Catra blinks at her, slowly tilting her head.

“Again?” Catra asks, mind casting back and sticking on two occasions where flowers showed up in her dressing room without reason. One was yellow roses included with what was borderline a love letter, clearly sent from a fan, even though there wasn’t a name or handle attached. Catra was pretty sure she identified the girl who sent them at stage door that night.

“Oh, well, we didn’t want to sign it and make things awkward backstage. You did get them, right? The roses?” Mara asks, glancing between then as Adora blushes and Catra has a small meltdown. Opening night featured blue flowers from her moms and white roses she never knew the sender of. She kept them on her counter for a month, long after they had withered and didn’t belong there. The note just said they were excited for the show’s run. She got similar flowers at the opening of her last show despite just being in the ensemble. A delusional part of Catra thought they could be from Adora, except she was acting too normal to have a secret, so that stupid disappointment just made Catra go even harder on the stage that night. The reviews were *glowing*.

“No, I got them,” Catra says in a small voice as she dies inside. Sure, Mara and Hope seemed positive and praised her on social media, but she still assumed they took Adora’s side in the whole thing. Apparently they didn’t see sides to pick.

Under the table, Adora's hand lands on her thigh and cautiously squeezes. Catra resolutely doesn't look up at her.

She's going to be spending Christmas Eve at their house again, isn't she?

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Adora's parents have to go west to get to the station back to Brooklyn, and Catra has to go west to get south, so Adora hugs them all goodbye outside the restaurant and starts walking north to reach the station up to her apartment. It feels weird to leave Catra behind with her parents, though she's sure it feels weirder for *Catra* to be walking home with her parents now, a good three years after their last sleepover in Mara and Hope's apartment. Adora reaches the subway steps and pauses, pulling out her phone and shooting a quick *hey* to Catra. It just feels wrong to have gone separate ways.

She not sure that actually has anything to do with which direction her parents went.

By the time she has reached the bottom of the steps, Catra has texted her back. *Turn around*. Adora doesn't hesitate or ask for clarification. She jogs back up the subway steps and makes her way down the street. It takes her a few minutes to reach the station her moms said they would be using. When Adora descends the steps, there's a spilt for going south or west. The second she turns the corner of the south branch, she sees Catra waiting just far enough back to not be ran into by every passerby departing the stairs.

Catra's eyes are bright and questioning when they land on Adora. Adora steps forward, instinctually lifting her hands. Catra doesn't hesitate, uncrossing her arms and letting Adora cradle her jaw to pull her into a greeting kiss. Catra's hands find her waist and she sways into her, sighing into the slow kiss. The dirty subway is probably one of the least romantic locations Adora can think of, but she really doesn't care, not when Catra is kissing her like this for a simple greeting.

They get bumped from behind and someone curses at them as he brushes past behind them. Adora reluctantly looks up to see a businessman shouldering past them on his way home late. Adora makes sure to flip off his backpack from behind, making Catra laugh as she glances over at her hand. When Adora looks back at her, her eyes are crinkled around the corners.

"Kind of weird you've never seen where I live," Catra comments casually, voice still sparkling, like that isn't something she purposefully hid from Adora. Okay, maybe not *hid*, but she has always made it clear when they leave the theater that they're going to Adora's place.

"Is that an invitation?" Adora asks, smirking, as Catra scowls. She knows it is, but Catra once purposefully asserted that a hangout was only going to be her, Entrapta, and Scorpia when Scorpia started talking about game night at her place. Then again, that was definitely a thinly veiled excuse for Scorpia to get to know Adora somewhere outside of work and to observe

their relationship. Adora is pretty sure half the cast are onto them at this point – most of all *Netossa,* who pulled her aside a few weeks ago to ask her if the way Catra was playing the show now was okay with her.

It's a lot of kissing. It's definitely okay with Adora.

"Come on," Catra grumbles, stepping back to grab her hand and pulling her over to the turnstile. Adora follows with a grin on her face. *Hell yeah*. They probably aren't going to have sex since Entrapta should be home, so this is based in romance rather than lust. She squeezes Catra's fingers as she pulls her metro card out with her other hand and scans it twice when Catra tries to cram through the turnstile with her. Catra rolls her eyes and Adora kisses her cheek.

"Don't make me an accessory to crime today," she tells her, joking, as she pulls back. Catra is busy blushing and it's definitely not shame over her gate-hopping, but Adora lets it go. She's not going to ruin the moment when they're finally crossing firmly into girlfriend territory.

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The entire cast wants to go out to celebrate the album, so they do it after their last show of the week. Catra is very grateful to have a day off tomorrow. It feels like her first since the workshop started, but even if she won't admit it, she did miss her friends, so she only grumbles a little as she lets them drag her out to some club that's way too loud and apparently exclusive. It can't be *that* exclusive if Sea Hawk of all people is the one with the connection that gets them in, but whatever, he's buying the first round – likely Catra's *only* round – so she doesn't care.

Adora manages to get halfway through her drink, something pink and fruity that Catra would bet has even more sugar than their fake rust remover, when they've only been inside the place for five minutes.

"Am I going to have to carry you home?" Catra asks, half teasing and half completely serious, as she wraps an arm around Adora's waist when she gets bumped by the crowd and nearly spills her drink. Adora looks up, eyes sparkling, and locks onto Catra's eyes the same way she does when she's singing *Seventeen*.

"*Yes*," Adora declares with a grin, and then she kisses Catra on the mouth in front of all their friends, startling her. A wolf whistle rings out behind them and Catra's ears pin back. Oh, shit. Adora is still grinning when they part, but Catra is having a small spiral.

"Okay, come here," Catra declares, tugging on her waist and pulling Adora away from their friends. Adora's brow creases, her unsure gaze darting between Catra and their group as Catra leads her out of earshot, away from the crowd around the bar trying to get their drinks to start their night. Catra moves to stand in front of her, facing her with one hand on her waist to keep her attention.

“Are you thinking clearly right now?” Catra asks. Adora looks bewildered like that isn’t an obvious question to ask. They don’t flirt or kiss in front of the rest of the cast. Catra and *Glimmer* have flirted in front of the cast more than she and Adora have, because that’s meaningless and this is dangerous. *Netossa* is here.

“It’s half a drink,” Adora points out, glancing between her cup and Catra’s serious expression. Catra rolls her eyes.

“And you’re a lightweight,” Catra says. The confused expression is replaced with the worst attempt at playing innocent Catra has ever seen on an actress.

“Pfft, no. Me, a lightweight? Never,” Adora argues, waving her free hand and then going to take another sip as if that proves something. Catra scowls.

“Adora, I’m trying to have a serious conversation,” she argues. This already feels like pulling teeth for her and she doesn’t need Adora making it *harder*. Adora arches a brow at her.

“When do you do that? You still won’t-” Adora’s brain seems to catch up with her mouth and she wisely shuts up, cutting off to take another drink like that covers up *whatever* she was about to accuse Catra of.

“This is about consent- You know what, never mind, I got my answer,” Catra grits out, frustrated, as she moves to step past Adora to explain to their friends don’t worry, it’s nothing, Adora is just *like this* drunk and it doesn’t mean anything. Fucking hell.

“Wait, wait, I’m sorry,” Adora hurriedly cuts her off, stepping into her way and raising her hand to Catra’s chest, trying to stop her. Catra scowls at her, but she looks up and sees Adora’s eyes are panicked. She looks away and reaches up, running a hand through her hair as she gathers herself. She sighs. She shouldn’t be so bothered by things that Adora says drunk. It’s stupid. She *knows* how stupid Adora gets drunk.

“Hey. Hey,” Adora prompts, softly, getting close in her space when Catra doesn’t immediately flee. Catra huffs to herself even as her hand comes up automatically to rest on Adora’s waist. Adora steps close enough to nuzzle her hair, mouth lining up with her ear. “I’m sorry. We’ve been… I thought it wasn’t a big deal. I can think clearly,” Adora promises in a low voice and then holds her breath, waiting to see if that makes it better or worse. Over her shoulder, Catra can see half the cast watching them. Only some of them are bothering to pretend otherwise. Glimmer does the totally unnecessary step of pointing at her eyes and then at Catra’s as if she needs it further illustrated that they have an audience.

Catra’s hand tightens on Adora’s waist for a moment, thinking.

“Are kisses okay when you’re drinking?” Catra finally asks, skipping everything else that just happened for the question she intended to ask when she first pulled Adora aside. Cautiously, Adora shifts her hand to hook over her shoulder, holding her close.

“Kisses are always okay. In the dressing room, in the subway, blackout drunk,” Adora whispers. Catra’s ears twitch.

Adora kisses her in front of everyone. Adora says she can kiss her any time. Adora takes her to fucking *dinner* with her parents.

Are they dating?

“I’m not kissing you when you’re blackout,” Catra informs her, and then she cups Adora’s jaw and tries to introduce her tonsils to her anyway. Their friends wolf whistle behind them again, but Catra closes her eyes and just enjoys how pliant Adora’s mouth is for her, happily opening to breathe her in. She is still a little worried Adora is buzzed right now, but she’s not worried that Adora would say something different totally sober.

Catra can feel her own drink tilting dangerously in her hand and finally pulls back, half expecting to see Adora’s spilling out onto the floor, but though it’s *close*, it’s not quite there. When she looks back to Adora’s face, her gaze is dark and a little clouded and it seems to take her a second to remember where they are before she flashes Catra a hopeful smile and then takes a quick drink that goes through almost half of her remaining cup. Whatever. The faster she drinks the faster she’s taking kisses off the table, but Catra was already planning to carry her home with her because her apartment is closer and she figured Adora would be messy.

“Come on,” Catra prompts, taking Adora’s hand and leading her back to the group. Their friends waste absolutely no time in heckling them, but Adora is grinning like an idiot and leaning into Catra’s side, so she pretends she can’t feel her boss’s eyes on her and that she *isn’t* bothered by people teasing her about her girlfriend, because she might actually not be when said girl is nuzzling her ear instead of protesting being called that.

Tonight is going to be a fucking mess, but maybe that’s okay.

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Adora’s head pounds before she even opens her eyes and it only gets worse when Catra laughs at her groaning and wallowing in the bed, but Catra drops a kiss in her hair and goes to get her a water, so she’s forgiven. Adora knows she feels like this because she drank too much, but her mouth feels like she hasn’t drunk at all in two days.

“I seem to remember someone screaming at Times Square they were having the time of their life last night,” Catra teases when she returns with the drink. Adora releases a groan that just makes Catra laugh again.

“Not worth it. What were we doing in Times Square?” Adora mumbles as she drinks, words refracting back off the glass at her. She squints at Catra, who is mostly a grin, pair of ears, and dancing tail right now in her blurry vision.

“You were really, *really* determined,” is all Catra says. The laughter in her voice tells Adora she doesn’t want to know *what* she was determined to do.

She opens her mouth.

No, it's really better not to know. She closes it again. Catra snickers and bends to kiss the top of her head.

"It's okay, I knew what I was getting into when you got that first drink. Anything you want for breakfast, baby?" Catra asks, hand threading through her hair as she pets her soothingly. For a second Adora's head is pounding too loud to process the words, and then *baby* hits her brain and shuts off higher thinking anyway.

"I- Um. In a minute," Adora finally mumbles, ducking into her glass as her cheeks blaze. Catra snickers again. She distinctly remembers people calling her Catra's girlfriend last night. She can't remember if *Catra* said it, but she definitely heard it and didn't correct the record that Adora has never been quite clear on herself.

"Let me know when your stomach settles," Catra quips. Yeah, Adora is going to need it to stop doing *cartwheels* first.

Chapter End Notes

Somehow they managed to get together without even having a conversation about it, congratulations girls that's the worst anybody has ever done it 🤝

# Final Bow (Opening Night)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Netossa calls a meeting at the end of warmups, when Catra is stretching and trying to pretend she doesn't find Sea Hawk's boasting about his acrobatics annoying, and Bow's awe over them even more so. She abandons her routine when Netossa calls for everybody to circle up, reluctantly joining Adora's side despite how she's standing next to Bow and thus Sea Hawk. She feels a little better about their proximity to the loud pair when Adora slides her arm around her waist. Catra leans into her side as Netossa claps her hands.

"Alright everyone, I've spoken to some of you about your plans, but I want to give the whole cast an update. First of all, you have been an incredible team to work with and if I could keep working with you for five years, I would. Every single one of you is going to leave a tough act to follow, so I want you to give yourselves a round of applause," Netossa declares. Catra claps along with everyone else even though she finds these blanket praises empty.

"That said, it's been almost a year since opening and I want to give people who have already seen the show twice a reason to come back. When contracts are up, I'm planning to change at least fifty percent of the cast," Netossa informs them. No one seems surprised, just nodding. "How much depends on who wants to stay and who I like in auditions." Netossa gestures to Scorpia. "Like Scorpia, it's going to be a damn shame to hear anyone except you sing *Kindergarten Boyfriend*, but I'm excited for you to move on to grander things and I want to make room for an actress who might have trouble finding roles because everybody's so uptight about waist size," Netossa explains.

Catra already knew Scorpia was leaving the show. She respects Netossa's decision to bring more body type diversity into her show, even if she was making a strong statement about society when she cast Scorpia as Martha. Scorpia has managed to get in talks for another show already with the notice Netossa gave her. The part isn't any bigger than Martha's, but the character also isn't the subject of ridicule and she'd get to do a jazz number, so it's better role overall. Catra is excited for her, but they're definitely not going to be in that show together, so it's back to seeing each other once a week at most.

Netossa reaches into her back pocket and produces a folded paper and a pencil.

"I've got the call list. I'm going to leave it out down here and – only if you're comfortable – I'd appreciate if you'd give me a check next to your name if you want to come back, an 'x' if not, and a circle if you're open but pursing other options. You absolutely don't have to and if you want to tell me later but keep your choices private, you can come to me any time. I just want to know who I definitely need to open auditions for," she explains, gesturing in the direction of the craft table backstage.

Catra stares at the list like it might as well be a bomb as Netossa goes on to praise them again and talk some logistics about the cast change over process, taking questions from the group

before she holds up the list on last time and reminds them it will be by the water backstage and they can come to her after the show, too.

To fill out the list, Catra would need to know what she's going to do. She's auditioning. She should put a circle. She knows she should.

She doesn't want to. She's so scared to leave this cast behind. She's scared to not be in a show with Adora again and see them fall apart, she's scared to move to a new show to find it stressful behind the scenes when everybody has been so great to work with here, and she's scared that if she indicates she's even thinking of leaving that Netossa will replace them and she'll be out of a job without even an audition. Okay, she has an audition this weekend, but *still*.

The emotional turmoil makes it a good show night, at least. When she's upset is when JD is at her best, obsessive as she wonders, if she doesn't sing *Seventeen* to Adora every night, would she even come home on time? Throughout the night Catra checks the list, but Adora is barely off-stage outside of intermission and though Catra checks it quickly before final bow as the music plays on stage, nothing is beside Adora's name.

Out of the corner of her eye, she sees Adora watching her, and when she walks away Adora checks the list too, but Catra can see she doesn't write *anything*. This is so stupid. They *both* have auditions next week, she knows they do, because they both said at the same time that they needed to cancel their hangout. How much would that happen once they weren't on stage together? It's fine now, when they're going to see each other anyway, even if it's just for work, but-

But her eyes immediately catch on the list when they walk off-stage at the end of the night and Catra hates having a goddamn personification of all her fears, so she growls under her breath and marches over to put a circle next to her name as her castmates filtering upstairs send her glances of confusion. When she straightens from writing, Adora is standing right behind her.

"The odds of us getting in another show together are pretty low," Adora murmurs as she moves in close behind her, left hand falling on Catra's waist and the other reaching around her to take the pencil out of her hand. Catra's tail lashes. She knows. She barely even considered that as an option because it would be delusional. Adora drops a kiss to her cheek as she adds a circle next to her own name like that isn't a big deal.

"Better work on your damn schedule again then, huh?" Catra says, crossing her arms and glaring down at the list of names, barely even registering what her other castmates have indicated on it.

"Just give me a time," Adora promises, and then she tugs on her hip until Catra reluctantly turns around to face her, letting Adora kiss her cheek again. Her crossed arms unfurl and her tail starts swaying behind her as Adora pulls her into her arms and slowly out of her sulk. It's amazing how easily Adora's touch can unwind her.

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When you're part of show, it becomes muscle memory, and that doesn't activate only on stage. Sometimes Adora opens the refrigerator and finds her left foot stepping back, her entire body moving with a slight spin like the handle is JD's hand as she instinctively moves through the blocking. She doesn't exactly put on a voice for Veronica, but on stage she projects her voice more than she normally would, and sometimes she finds herself randomly using it in the aisles of the grocery story.

The instinctive singing is the part people usually anticipate. Adora has laughed about the question at stage door enough for *that* to be muscle memory too rather than genuine humor. When she randomly hums to herself, it almost always morphs into one of the numbers from the show – if not from Heathers, then from her last one. She actually gets pretty tired of singing from a show like this and doesn't feel the need to sing around the house like she once did when being on stage was just a dream, but she still gets the songs looping in her head sometimes and is surprised to find they're even leaving her lips.

Catra is draped in her lap, her back to Adora as they watch TV, when Adora realizes she's singing *Seventeen* as she swirls her finger around a lock of Catra's hair. She pauses and Catra's ear twitches, so she definitely noticed. Adora takes a deep breath and then drops a kiss to the back of Catra's ear, lips brushing against it as she restarts the song much further past the chorus.

*But your love's too good to lose*. Catra hums her part of the melody, head turning so she can nose Adora's shoulder as Adora ducks her head.

*I'll stay if I'm what you choose*. Catra's breath hitches.

"You hear back from Angella yet?" Catra asks, tone joking. Adora shakes her head, pressing a kiss into Catra's hair.

"I don't think they're confident in my dancing," Adora says. Catra snorts.

"They shouldn't be," is all she says. Adora hums the chorus again, waiting for Catra to pick it up. Catra sighs. Then she groans, reluctant. Then she *whines* when Adora loops the chorus again, but Adora pushes on.

*So what's it gonna be?* she whispers to Catra. Catra's voice finally joins her, thin and fragile to match Adora's quiet refrain in her head voice, for *I wanna be with you*.

"I'm not doing the whole song for another four hours," Catra mumbles as she mashes her face into Adora's collarbones. Adora snorts, but she lets it be, dropping a kiss into Catra's hair.

"It's different off-stage," Adora says. It *means* something here. Catra whines again, earning a chuckle from Adora. Okay, she has been brave enough. Adora pets through her hair and lets it go.

If Angella gets a formal offer, they both know Adora is going to take it if Catra finds a new project of her own, but that doesn't have to be the end. Their relationship crashes in flames all over again on stage every night. Adora likes to think she knows a few more of the pitfalls to avoid now.

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When they want privacy, they go back to Adora's. Sometimes Adora follows her home because it's closer and convenient if they just want a little more time together, but they still spend most nights apart. Tonight, Catra was too tired for anything when they got home, but she still started walking in the direction of Adora's apartment when they left stage door and Adora didn't question it despite how Catra hadn't indicated they were spending the night together before then.

It was mostly an impulse. Double Trouble got back to her today. They got asked how she would feel about being an understudy, apparently. It's not the offer she was hoping for, though it's at least *something* after Heathers ends, and usually it's more understood if you depart an understudy role early for a better opportunity, so she could take it as a stop-gap at least.

It's a fallback, one she feels like she needs, because as much as they both love Heathers, Adora got another callback. Veronica is almost never off stage, she's constantly leading numbers, and she has a lot of big emotions to act through. Maybe a role that only really has one song is a "downgrade," but Adora also would have a lot more energy to spend time with her friends outside of work if she took it, and it's a dream role just because her mom loves *Chicago* and she grew up listening to the soundtrack a lot younger than she probably should have.

Scorpia has a new show, as does Perfuma. Mermista might end up in Chicago with Adora. Glimmer just got a callback. Sea Hawk is going to do some musical about sex Catra is dreading having to go to the opening night of to support him. Heathers as they know it is ending. At this point she needs it over with so the feeling of dread can break and she can pick up the pieces wherever they fall.

Adora usually takes a few minutes to get settled at night, but as Catra is staring at the back of her head and wondering how much extra energy she'd *really* have as Mona, Adora reaches up and clicks back on the bedside lamp. Catra's ears twitch as Adora rolls back over and looks across the pillow at her with big, soft eyes. Catra has no idea what she's doing.

"What?" Catra asks, voice abrasive because that's what she defaults to when thrown off. Adora's lips quirk and she reaches out to trace a hand over her cheek, thumb lightly caressing her lower lip like she's thinking about kissing her. Her eyes even drop to it for a second before looking up to hold hers again. She takes a deep breath, but then she doesn't say anything. Catra's ears twitch, waiting for Adora to say *anything*, but she has no idea why she's being weird when they're both tired from a double show day.

“You’re my girlfriend, right?” Adora finally asks, flooring Catra.

“Yes?” Catra responds. It’s not really a question, she’s just incredulous. Adora grins and then ducks forward, kissing her. Catra laughs into the kiss, even *more* confused now.

“Adora, we’ve already said that,” Catra points out, words a bit mumbled with the interference from Adora’s own lips, but Adora finally drops her head back onto the pillow to meet her eyes again.

“No, someone said it *in front* of you and you just didn’t correct them,” Adora argues. Catra rolls her eyes.

“Same difference.” That’s when *she* knew for sure they were dating at least, and it wasn’t even the start of her suspicions, just the confirmation.

“*And* we’d been drinking,” Adora adds, like they haven’t been holding hands and cuddling and shit in front of their castmates ever since. They’ve been referred to as a couple multiple times since then totally sober.

“You can shut up and kiss me now,” Catra informs her. It earns a quiet laugh, but Adora follows orders. Catra can’t believe *this* is what was bothering Adora. She kind of doesn’t believe it, actually, but she lets Adora kiss her softly until the weirdness fades into the back of her mind. It’s easy to get lost in the haze of comfort with Adora’s hands in her hair. The kiss lasts a really long time, long enough for the weariness to start creeping into the back of her mind again. When Adora finally pulls back, she doesn’t go far, propping up on one arm and nuzzling the side of Catra’s head until her face is buried in her hair and her lips are brushing her ear.

“This is going to be the most lesbian thing I ever do,” Adora warns her in a low voice. Catra’s lips quirk despite how Adora can’t see it.

“Stiff competition there,” Catra quips. Adora chuckles and she sounds a little uncertain. She takes a deep breath.

“I love you,” Adora says, quietly.

Catra’s heart feels like it stops. Her breath hitches, but she really doesn’t process further.

“I know it’s ridiculous when I only just confirmed we’re dating, but I’ve loved you for a *really* long time and I just need you to know. Everything’s changing, and I know a part of you is probably still mad about everything from before, so I’m not expecting you to say it back, but if we only have a few weeks left in the show, I want you to know I mean it every time I sing *Our Love Is God*,” Adora explains, nervously. Her arm is quaking a little where it’s supporting her and Catra isn’t sure if it’s from physical or emotional strain.

Adora is *so* lucky this isn’t going to ruin the show, because it easily could have if Catra didn’t reciprocate, except there’s no *reality* where that isn’t true, so instead she turns her head and kisses Adora with a lot more desperation than the last kiss had. Adora huffs some kind of laugh of relief, letting Catra push her back when she lifts her hand to her shoulder. Adora is

dangerously close to collapsing anyway. She tries to fall in the same position she was before so they can look in each other's eyes, but Catra moves instead, prying herself up from the bed so she can kneel over Adora's hips, kissing her again.

She can't hold herself up for long either with how tired her body is, but she needs to be here because it's easier to breathe here, and she needs to breathe to *sing*.

*I worship you*. Adora's breath hitches as Catra sings the second verse of *Our Love Is God* to her, that night where Adora sang *Seventeen* to her still fresh in her mind. It was so much then. Catra has been trying to avoid strong emotion and over-investment to shorten the fall.

Turns out she can fall as far as she wants if it's in love.

*I'd trade my life for yours*. Catra strokes her cheek and Adora covers her hand with her own.

*They all will disappear*. Singing quietly, neither of them hit their notes on the harmony of *we'll plant our garden here*, but it doesn't matter and it's not the point.

The point is Catra whispering *our love is god* to her and Adora whispering it back with very little harmony, words shaking just like her breath when Catra kisses her. She can't keep kneeling and she just kind of melts into Adora's lap as they kiss, but Adora doesn't seem to mind, hands coming up to bury in her hair.

Catra might be ready to stop singing love songs on stage and if she gets to do them with Adora for real.

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Netossa knocks on Adora's dressing room door and Catra scrambles to get out of her lap, quickly hopping up on the windowsill and pretending she's been there the whole time. Adora is a bit breathless and has to take a second to catch up before she can speak.

"Come in!" Adora calls, shooting Catra a slanted smile in the mirror as she goes back to her getting ready routine. It feels like they're getting away with something. They've learned by now that once Adora puts her makeup on they shouldn't really be making out until they're on stage, so she put everything on pause when Catra slide into her lep.

The door opens to reveal Netossa, who doesn't look at all surprised to see Catra in Adora's dressing room. Everyone tends to move between each other's rooms to socialize, but Catra was an exception to that for a long time. Now she laughs along with Adora when someone comes in to mess with her. Adora turns to face Netossa so she will hopefully focus on her and not try to tease Catra about something too revealing. Besides, she knows why Netossa is here.

"I hear you're off to the cell block," Netossa jokes lightly as she walks over to Adora's vanity. Adora glances at the mirror in the corner of her eye to see Catra's tail flicking and then it curls around her legs. Adora flashes Netossa a smile. She's always nervous when it

comes to delivering news like this despite how Netossa has been planning for them to leave since before she even began auditions.

“Yep. I’m going to miss this show so much, you’re all so amazing, but I’m excited for a new challenge,” Adora tells her. She signed her contract this morning and Angella formally sent Netossa the news. She’s about to have several less songs to go through, and especially to not have the weight of leading them, but the dance element will keep the role engaging.

She’s excited to have more time and not have to constantly worry about maintaining her voice. She’s excited for her moms to see her in the new show, even if the outfit is a bit much. She’s really, really excited for three weeks off with Catra, even if workshop is going to be a lot of work. She’s trying to focus on all that to avoid crying about leaving this show behind, because she’s just as emotional about it as Catra is pretending not to be.

“Give me the time and I’ll go to your opening night. I’m excited for you, kid,” Netossa tells her, lightly punching Adora’s shoulder. Adora feels something in her chest bubble as she smiles up at Netossa.

“When you get a new project, you’d better call me,” Adora tells her. She’s going to be so sad to have a new director. Netossa leaves as tough an act to follow as anyone on the Heathers stage. Netossa laughs, but her smile is encouraging.

“I’ll let you know,” she promises. Her gaze trails up to where Catra is curled up in the window. Adora glances in the mirror to find Catra looking up, ears pricked to attention, as Netossa shifts her focus to her.

“I know I said I wanted to change things up, but if you’re not headed anywhere, I’d be happy to keep you as JD’s understudy for now,” Netossa tells her. Catra’s tail flicks once as Adora holds her breath, not sure how Catra would feel about that. She’s already not happy about taking on a new role as understudy. Being *demoted* within her current role seems a lot worse, even if it’s a solid backup plan.

“Yeah, maybe,” Catra finally says, voice a bit distant. Netossa glances at Adora, seemingly not sure how to take that. Slowly, Catra unfurls from the window and stands, stretching. “*Shot in the Dark* wants me back for two nights of showcase performances. Just a few days and it might be that no one picks it up, but they’re trying to sell investors on me, so I’m pretty sure they’re going to offer me the role if it does go somewhere,” Catra informs her.

Talking about a shot in the dark, there’s no guarantees here, but it’s something Catra really wants. Even if it’s off-Broadway in the end, it’s still an original role. An understudy fallback is probably the best she can lock in for now. Catra’s stretching arms drop back by her sides.

“I’ll be happy to take it for now, but I don’t really want to be JD with a different Veronica,” Catra admits. Adora’s heart fizzes. Catra’s eyes dart over to the mirror and for a second Adora gets to hold her gaze and feel her heart burst before Catra looks back to Netossa, who nods, a smile playing at her lips.

“Yeah, I kind of figured. I can put you on call until you’re busy again. I doubt I’ll need to pick up the phone, though,” Netossa promises. The vote of confidence seems to perk Catra up

at least, who manages to flash Netossa a cocky smile.

“I’ll get just long enough off to watch Adora debut in that skimpy outfit,” Catra says, immediately making Adora flush. She suddenly remembers she needs to put on her makeup and reaches for her foundation as Catra leers at her in the mirror reflection. She doesn’t have to do this in front of Netossa, *their boss*.

No one has ever stopped Catra from doing anything, though.

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Catra goes to Adora’s opening night and cheers when Mona steps out onto the cell block in a body suit that covers a lot but hides nothing, suddenly very glad she is sitting with the rest of their friends rather than Adora’s *parents*. Three months later, after *Shot in the Dark*’s invite-only preview runs, Adora comes to her official opening as well. Before Catra goes out on stage, she already has three vases in her room, yellow flowers from her moms and then a set of white roses and dark and washed out ones. She doesn’t need to read the cards to know who’s whose. Stepping out on stage in a brand new role, leading her own goddamn show, with nearly all her friends and family in the audience, is the most terrifying and thrilling thing she has ever done. It’s healing when she realizes she knows exactly where Adora is sitting in the auditorium because there’s cheering coming from that section whenever it could be appropriate.

She walks off stage and straight into Adora’s arms. It’s early in *Chicago’s* run for Adora to be taking a Friday off, but this isn’t the Adora of three years ago and if her excuse before was that it wasn’t a big opening to miss, that couldn’t be less true now. They go out to dinner afterwards to celebrate. Catra isn’t really sure who’s paying, but she knows her friends aren’t letting it be her tonight. In the months since Heathers ended, she has missed her old castmates and the daily routine she had with them in the theatre. It’s great to be together with all of them again; even the ones who couldn’t get time off from their own shows to watch the opening night met up with them afterwards and plan to come some other night.

It's a little terrifying to have her moms in contact with some of them. She thinks she might see a glow of pride in *both* of their eyes as they look around the table at all the amazing actors Catra has made friends with along the way of her career, or maybe she’s just delusionally happy after a night like this, but she can even forgive Sea Hawk for trying to talk about his sex show in front of Adora’s parents like it doesn’t make them all want to die on the spot. She throws herself into Adora’s side, purring as she nuzzles her shoulder and rumbling even louder when Adora turns her head to drop a kiss into her hair.

All the change has been hard as they both prepared for their new shows, especially the period where *Shot in the Dark* was in limbo, but they try to still see each other nearly every day. Even if they often can only crash together, they take the time to have a conversation about *something* before they do it to avoid becoming just two ghosts in the same apartment again.

After the exhaustion of this initial push they'll be able to start properly going out again. It's not the ease of being Veronica and JD together, but even when they struggle, this is *real*.

"I love you," Adora murmurs into her hair before kissing her again and finally lifting her head. Catra purrs.

"I love you too," Catra sighs back. It absolutely sounds exasperated because Sea Hawk is still going on about *Hello, Again* in the background and not *dreamy* or any other dumb adjective. She catches the look Felina is giving her across the table and steadfastly looks away. They haven't *actually* told their parents they're dating yet, but they haven't told anybody and everyone still knew before they even properly started. *Catra* doesn't know when they properly started, because it was certainly before Adora asked her in the bed.

At this point, she doesn't really care, not when Adora is coming home to her. She was terrified of what would happen once they weren't in a show together anymore, and though it hasn't been painless, the world hasn't ended again either. Maybe they'll get in a show together again. Maybe they won't. Catra really hopes they do, even if they're unlikely to ever luck into playing love interests again.

That's fine. It doesn't hold the same appeal to her now that she gets to have Adora in real life, too.

Chapter End Notes

Fic notes up now ~~will be up on my tumblr tomorrow because I may or may not have gotten distracted backing up crew-ra tweets~~

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!